Be my Cheerleader

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41265177.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & He-Man | Adam, Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam & Adora (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, Teela (He-Man), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Endgame Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Fake/Pretend Relationship, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Alternate Universe - High School, Jock Adora (She-Ra), Cheerleader Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) and He-Man | Adam are Siblings, American Football, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Mutual Pining, Fluff and Angst, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Slow Burn, Implied/Referenced Homophobia, Drinking, 18 years old is the legal drinking age.

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by Rinnii

Summary

Adora had never in her life been jealous of her twin. They were two halves of the same powerful person. They lifted each other up and carried the burdens of the other whenever they were too weak to stand alone. They had always done everything together, they had their own strengths and weaknesses, both on and off the field. They were a strong team, and they would always be. Adora had never been jealous of Adam Grayskull until he started dating Catra. Adora, Adam and Catra had been friends since primary school, and he had every right to like her. She was smart, funny, and absolutely beautiful. Now, Adora could never tell Catra the truth about her feelings. She would never do that to Adam. But she would give anything for this not to be real.

Notes

Hi hi, welcome to my first AO3 fic, I hope you like it!

I don't know anything about American football or high school. I did distance education in Australia so my understanding is from dramatic high school movies. Enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

Chapter 1

BANG

Adora and the girl who was trying to shoot her shot both jumped at the loud sound of Catra slamming her locker. The poor junior tried to recover from her stun to ask out the blonde jock, but her overprotective best friend had other plans.

"If you're done being pathetic, we have class to get to," Catra said, crossing her arms over her chest as she cocked her hip. Challenging the girl to continue her useless endeavour.

"O-oh sorry ," the girl said and Adora of fered the girl a sympathetic smile before she disappeared to her own class. Adora raised her eyebrow at Catra who watched the girl disappear down the hall.

"W as that really necessary?" Adora asked, turning back to her locker to push her hair into a ponytail and grab her books.

"Whatever , it's not like you were interested," Catra said rolling her eyes and opening her locker to grab her own books.

"I dunno, I've never met her . What if she was the girl of my dreams?" Adora said closing her locker and turned to Catra as she snorted.

"Doubt it, who finds their dream partner in high school?" Catra said closing her locker again like a normal person and holding her books under one arm. Adora shrugged as Adam appeared beside her and grabbed her in a headlock.

"Hey!" Adora yelled, trying to get away before he ruined her ponytail again.

"Catra! How are you this fine morning?" Adam asked with a grunt as Adora elbowed him in the ribs and he struggled to keep his hold of her.

"Hey Dumbass," Catra said rolling her eyes and walking around the blonde tornado in the hall. Adora slipped out and shoved her twin before she laughed, and he dived to tackle her. They were giant children.

"If you idiots make me late to Lit, I will skin you both alive," Catra growled, and she heard Adam grunt as he got knocked into a locker. Catra glanced over at them and Adora grinned as she released her brother and straightened her hair as she held her books between her toned thighs. Oh, to be a book right now.

Catra swept into the classroom with the two blondes in tow and made eye contact with bane of her existence. Ms. W eaver.

Catra took her assigned seat, the twins had calmed down and now sat quietly to either side of Catra and pulled out their books. Being the teacher's daughter meant Catra couldnt slip. Not an inch. Especially when it came to Adora. Weaver already had her suspicions, even if Adora was too oblivious to notice. Catra couldnt even look at Adora in this class without being forced to talk about it at home. So, she sat, straight backed, answered any questions she was asked and kept her eyes to herself.

Just one more year, then she'd be free.

I..

Lunch was a non-event, the whole friend group made up most of the cheer squad and parts of the football team, spread over two tables as they make a racket. Excited for the football season to start. Their first game was coming up this Friday night and the cheer squad was deep in planning how to boost excitement for the game.

After school was cheer practice, they shared the oval with the football team as they ran drills to prepare for the game. Catra's focus was tested by her two best friends, but one more than the other.

She powered through her water bottle with a very dry mouth as she glanced over at Adora sweating up a storm. Catra forced herself to refocus and instructed her waiting team into the next routine.

They must have run their routine 10 times before Catra was satisfied, she was a stickler for perfect form when it came to their

routine. Bow came over to visit Glimmer once the drills were done. Perfuma was swept up by her sweaty beefy girlfriend once they finished their final run and Catra had to look away. It wasn't that she didn't think it was a sweet show of affection, and a bit gross in a lovey way. The problem was it made her want that and she couldn't have it, not under Weaver's roof. Not yet.

Adam was the first to reappear after the showers. The cheer squad had dispersed and Catra had changed into jeans and put on her leather jacket while she waited for her ride. She was sitting in the bleachers as the lights flicked on the oval.

Adam walked up the steps to sit beside Catra and she glanced over at him before looking back at the oval.

"Adora might be a while. She was still talking to Mermista when I got out of the shower," he said with a grin and leaned back on the bench. Catra sighed and rolled her eyes. "She was telling some story about a junior you bit the head off?" Adam said nonchalantly .

"I didn't bite her head off, I just called her pathetic," Catra said crossing her arms and pulling her jacket tighter around her to brace against the cold. Adam moved and put his arm around her to keep her warm.

Catra leaned into the familiar embrace she had known her whole life. The three of them always cuddled, even if puberty really changed those experiences between Adora and Catra, for Catra at least. Adam was like a cuddly teddy bear, nothing but brother energy and good hugs. Adora lit a fire in her chest when she was close her. Her heart raced, her face flushed, she was a mess. So, she limited those interactions, for her poor heart's sake. She tried not to hug Adam more often than Adora, because Adora hated to be excluded,

especially when it came to Catra. But sometimes she just wanted to be held and she was touch starved from living with Weaver. Scorpia gave pretty good hugs when she couldn't turn to the twins, she was just a little overzealous.

"Thanks," Catra said softly as she rested her head on his shoulder. He just hummed, enjoying the hug as much as she was. It wasn't long before Adora appeared at the door to the locker room and spotted them. She had her jacket in her hand as she approached. She glanced between the two of them and Catra prepared for a comment about missing out.

"Cold?" Adora asked, her concern outwaying her jealousy for the moment and Catra nodded.

"It's freezing," Catra said sitting up straight, and Adam let her go as she stood. "Let's get out of here before I keel over," Catra said with a laugh and Adora nodded. Adora offered Catra her letterman jacket and grinned.

"Want my jacket?" Adora offered and Catra took it.

"Absolutely, you don't need it, you're like a furnace" Catra said slipping it on and walking between her towering best friends to their car. She loved the feeling of the oversized jacket against her skin, trying to hold back from burring her face in the familiar scent. It was bliss.
Catra always studied at the Grayskull's after school, it was best to avoid her mother after school when she liked to drink. She never had dinner at home, Weaver never made anything to eat anyway.

Rocking up to the house Catra followed the twins inside and got a

warm greeting by their parents, Linda, and Dean. Better known as Mom and Dad, her own mother never tried to earn that title like the Grayskull's did. Dinner was in the oven and the house was warm and inviting, it felt like home.

The three threw down their bags in the living room and set out their homework while they waited for dinner. They sat around the coffee table on the floor as they were working in silence, occasionally poking each other or being a nuisance.

Adora particularly liked to poke at Catra or draw on her paper when she was not looking. Catra would retaliate until no homework was done at all.

Mom called them to dinner, and they sat around the table. The permanent fifth place at the table was set and Catra claimed her spot between her best friends. Catra was often the buffer between the two blonde golden retrievers with too much energy as they tried to annoy each other into play fighting. It was her favorited place in the entire world.

They talked about their days and Linda politely asked how Weaver has been. Catra brushed over her being fine and nothing to report but the Grayskull knew better than that by now. They were a safe harbour for the storm that was her relationship with her mother.

After dinner, the three students returned to homework as Linda and Dean tied up and readied for the next day of work and school. Catra was always sad when the end of the night came, and she had to return to her mother. Her curfew on a school night was 9pm so she left it to the last moment to walk home.

"Do you need a jacket for the walk home?" Adora asked, such a wonderfully considerate dummy.

"Nah dummy , Ill warm up with the walk," Catra said with a smile, she didnt want to mention that Weaver would kill her if she showed up with one of Adora's jackets on again. She didnt need more proof for the bonfire of evidence proving her daughter was a sinner.

Adora pulled Catra into a hug, it was one of the last acceptable hug times they had left, besides comfort hugs. Catra savoured it as she squeezed the blonde back before she released her . It was so unfair how good she smelt. Catra tried to keep her blush at bay. Its just a hug you mess.

Adam was next and wrapped her up in a warm hug. Adam took his time, knowing he was able to and abusing the privilege. Once Catra forced her way out of his grip she laughed at his grin and glanced at Adora. She almost looked like she was pouting but smiled back at Catra.

"Later idiots," she said leaving the house into the biting cold. She wrapped her jacket tightly around herself.

The walk home only took about 10 minutes. It was 10 minutes of dread. She hoped Weaver had already passed out from the wine. It would make her night easier.

The lights in the house were off when she approached, it seemed promising. Catra let herself into the silent house and let out a gentle sigh. The inside of the house was barely warmer than outside, but it held no spirit of home. It made it feel icy and cold.

She took off her shoes and headed quietly upstairs to her room. She turned on the light as she opened the door and almost had a heart attack. Weaver was sitting on her bed holding a glass of wine. She looked up when the lights turned on.

Catra put her hand to her chest to try to stop the panic that rose at the sight of her. She took a steading breath, trying to assess the situation. Was she angry? Sad? Disappointed? Catra swallowed, looking at the thing on the lap of her dark skirt and her eyes widened.
"Catra." Weaver started without looking up at her. This was not her first glass of wine, clearly. Catra hoped to God, who she knew wasnt listening, that was her new, empty sketchbook, not her old one.

"Were you at the Grayskull's?" Weaver asked, even though she knew that was where Catra had been.

"Yes Ma'am," Catra forced out, trying to remedy whatever outburst this was going to be.

"Did they feed you?" Weaver asked.

"Yes Ma'am," Catra said softly but clearly. Weaver would chew her out for not speaking clearly, otherwise.

"So, they should, they have the money to spare," Weaver spat, spitefully. Catra swallowed, her eyes on the sketchbook in Weavers lap.
Weaver opened the book finally and Catra could see all the sketches as she flicked through. Catra tried to stop herself from blushing, she knew most of that sketchbook was filled with drawings of Adora. It

wasnt even hard to see that it was Adora, it was clearly her . Catra's feelings for Adora were always a huge inspiration and when she just sketched with no intention, they often reflected those blue eyes she loved.

"W ould you like to explain this?" W eaver asked in a tone that said it was not optional.

I..

Catra was freezing cold, it was early morning, and she was trying to climb the tree in the backyard of the Grayskull's. She could go through the front door, she had a key but she didnt want to alert Adora. She needed to speak to Adam, alone. She finally got into the roof outside the twins windows and tapped as loudly as she dared on Adam's window. Thankfully they hadnt shared a room since they were 13. Adora was a deep sleeper, but she didnt want to risk waking her in case she was up this early for a run or something ridiculous.

Adam's sleepy face came to the window and opened it without a word. It wasnt unusual for Catra to show up in the night after a fight with Weaver and they would let her inside. She would swap between the twins depending on who would wake up. Often getting let in Adam's window and ending up in Adora's room anyway.

Adora was soothing like nothing else in her life. She made her heart go faster and slower all at once. It was hard to sleep but it felt right to lay beside her. Adam was great for cuddles or a sympathetic ear. Surprisingly Adam was much better with emotions than Adora, Adora was always better at punching her problems or taking action to fix it. They were a strong team.

Catra slipped inside and pulled the window closed before she started rubbing her arms quickly to warm up. Adam had returned to sit on the bed as he rubbed the sleep out of his face. Catra put down her backpack with a loud thud. Adam looked at the heavy bag for a moment before he looked back at Catra curiously.

"What's all that?"

"She found my sketchbook" Catra whispered.

"Oh" Adam rubbed his face again, his mop of blond hair spiking up in all directions.

"She flipped out when she saw all my drawings of Adora and she accused me of being gay," Catra said, keeping her voice low but the panic in her tone was unmistakable.

"You are gay, Cat, for my sister," Adam was dopier than usual after waking up and he seemed to think this was funny somehow. It absolutely was not.

"Shhh! No one can know that. She threatened to kick me out. I told her the drawings were for art class, but she didn't believe me, so I panicked." Catra looked nervous suddenly .

"What did you do?" Adam asked curiously , hooked on the drama of the tale.

"I told her I have a boyfriend... she asked me who, but I couldn't think

of anyone, so I said uh..you?" Adam looked surprised and frowned drowsily.

"Why me?"

"I don't know! I panicked. I don't want some random guy trying to get handsy with me! You are one of my best friends. I trust you, ok?"
"You're one of my best friends too Cat, but you know I think of you like a sister, I'm not gonna date you," Adam was barely staying awake at this point. His blue eyes glazing with sleep as he rocked slightly to stay upright.

"Please Adam!" Catra never in her life expected to beg a man to date her, but here she was. Pathetic Weavers voice reminded her.
"We can just pretend to date, it doesn't have to be the real thing, just enough to get mum off my back. It would only be at school, I promise,"

"Ugh, I hate this, I don't want to act like that with you,"

"Believe me, I don't want to either , but I'm desperate. It wouldn't be much, maybe a kiss on the cheek here and there, and cuddles, you like cuddles," Adam held his chin in consideration.

"I do like cuddles..you know if she tried to kick you out, you could always live here with us?" Adam of fered, clearly looking for any alternative,

"I know dumbass, but Weaver could literally ruin my life, if she decides to flunk me in her class I might not graduate. I need her on my side, just until I graduate," Catra said, her begging was grinding

on her pride, but she needed to convince him.
“Graduation is like, so far away though,”

“I know , and I dont need to date you that whole time, just enough for her to think I like guys,”

“I want you to know I hate this, but if it’ s the only way, Id rather it be me than someone who might try something.Ill do it, BUT we have to tell Adora,”

“What!No, we cant, she cant keep a secret to save her life!”

“W e have to tell her Cat, she would be so hurt if she found out we kept this from her,”

“I know , but she wont be able to play along, besides, we wont do it at the house, just at school, so she wont have to see it,”

“W e hang out all the time at school, she’s gonna see it,”Catra flopped down on the bed beside Adam and huffed with irritation.

“Shell be fine, we will just tell her first, and let her know that nothing will change between the three of us. Maybe once I turn 18, I can transfer out of Weavers class. Two months at most, we can do this, then we will just explain to her ,”

“What if she has feelings for you?

“She doesnt”

“I wouldn’t be so sure Cat, I know my sister better than you do,”

“If she had any ability to keep a secret, I might believe you,”

“…”

Catra unpacked her sketchbooks from her bag and hid them deep in Adam’s gross closet. She repacked her school bag and worked out the details of their arrangement.

They kept it simple. Acceptable contact was mostly stuff they already did. Catra added kissed on the cheek, which they hadn’t done since kindergarten and hand holding. Adam added ‘hand on waist’, because it would be expected of him. So Catra agreed.

They would only pretend at school or school events, NEVER at home. Neither of them wanted to make Adora uncomfortable or feel excluded. It was important to them both that nothing changed between the twins and Catra. They needed each other.

They agreed that if either of them wanted to break up’they would, no hard feelings. Catra knew Adam was doing so much for her and if it only lasted a little while, she could work with that.

As long as the school believed it, Weaver would buy it. So, they just had to convince their fellow students.

Once that was all settled, Adam went back to sleep for a few hours

and Catra slipped into Adora's room. Adam gave great hugs, but Adora was her very own heater and Catra couldnt resist it.

Catra took off her jeans and jacket but left her oversized shirt on, probably one she stole from one of the twins, before she climbed into Adora's bed. The blonde was a deep sleeper and heavy to move, so Catra prodded at her until she woke enough to cuddle up to Catra. Being tucked under Adora's chin and protectively cradled against her chest was like heaven to Catra. Adora was so warm, chasing away any chill left in Catra's body as Adora took a deep breath and buried her face into Catra's hair.

"Mm, uok?" she murmured, trying to wake enough to talk. She knew the drill, Catra had a fight with Weaver again. It was hours ago, and she was ok now. She waited till Weaver passed out before she slipped away to hide the rest of her evidence in the closet of her gay obsessions brother. Catra took a deep breath, relaxing in the strong arms that surrounded her.

"I am now ," she said softly and Adora hummed in response before casually kissing the top of Catra's head. Catra's heart reacted at once, jumping against her chest as her cheeks flushed with heat. She felt like she was burning but didnt want to move away from the blissful heat surrounding her. She was more than willing to burn for this.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

> Adam and Catra tell Adora they are dating and Adora takes it REALLY well.

Chapter Notes

> This one got longer than I expected, but there is just so much EMOTION to get through. Ya'kno

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hated Weaver all her life for the way she treated Catra. Catra was her best friend and Weaver treated her like trash. All Adora could ever offer was a safe place to just be. Somewhere Catra could be herself and be loved for it.

Adora's parents had welcomed Catra with open arms from the day she came through their door holding hands with the twins. It was the first day of school and the twins had made friends with the little brunette. Weaver had failed to pick up Catra after school and Catra didn't know how to get home on her own. So, Adam and Adora linked hands with the fluffy haired girl and asked their mum if she could come over to play. Linda sat with Catra and the twins until the pickup period was over, and no one came for Catra. Then she took the three 5-year-olds home.

Weaver was eventually alerted and Catra was fed. She seemed so small for her age. Then Linda helped them with their homework as they waited. Weaver was unimpressed to say the least and Catra looked so scared when she arrived. Linda was not happy with Weaver, but she made sure Catra knew she was always welcome to visit in their home.

So, their friendship blossomed. They were always together, and it left very little room for other friends. Catra could get jealous and self-conscious that she would be abandoned whenever someone else tried. Over the years she worked on her jealousy and now they had a huge group of friends, even if nothing could compare to the three of them. Catra still got jealous sometimes, but mostly when new people trying to join their dynamic.

As much as Adora hated Weaver, she didnt hate waking up with Catra snuggled in her bed, safe and sound. Adora loved waking up with Catra in her arms. It was the only place she knew Catra was truly safe from harm. Adora would always protect her.
Adora glanced at the clock on her nightstand.

5:30AM.

Adora would usually get up around now to go for a run. She didnt have practice today, so she needed to burn that energy somehow. Adora was a morning person, and she loved her morning runs. But this morning, with Catra snuggled against her and getting the cuddles they usually wouldnt share while awake, Adora couldnt bring herself to get up. She snuggled into Catra's hair and took a deep breath as she relaxed back into the pillow . Catra made a soft sound in her sleep as she adjusted, moving closer to Adora' s warmth. Nothing could ruin her day after waking up with Catra.

I..

Catra was acting weird, but Adam was acting weirder. They both seemed worried about something. Adora didnt like to feel excluded when it came to her best friend or other half. She could only help if she knew what she needed to fix She had to guess it was

something to do with Weaver. Adam often let Catra into the house at night since Adora slept like the dead. Adora knew Adam was obviously better with emotions than Adora, but he usually filled her in when it came to Catra. It wasnt that she was bad with emotion, she had plenty of them. She just hated to talk about them and didnt really know how to communicate how she was feeling properly.

Adora would just wait till Adam or Catra to told her what was wrong, it would happen eventually. Until then, she focused on making them laugh and bringing up the mood.

The day was long. At lunch Catra had a weird interaction with Weaver in the hall and once it was over Catra hugged Adam. Adora wanted hugs too, but the bell rang, and they had to get to class. She could get hugs later.

Adam and Adora didnt have practice on T uesdays, so they raced around the track to expend the energy while they waited for Catra to finish her debate club. After several laps around the oval, they paused to catch their breath.

"Man, I needed this," Adam said leaning his hands onto his knees as he panted.

"Seemed like it," Adora said leaning back to expand her lungs as she wiped her forehead. "Y ou and Catra have been weird all day," Adora said with a laugh. Adam looked surprised and huffed a nervous laugh.

"Y eah, I guess so," Adam said standing up to stretch out his lungs too.

"Did she tell you what happened with W eaver?" Adora asked curiously as she stretched her legs, waiting to see if Adam wanted to do another lap. Catra would be done soon and then they could head home for dinner.

"Y eah, just normal W eaver bullshit," Adora nodded, she knew what Weaver was like.

"Maybe she should stay over tonight too? A little space might help," Adora asked as she glanced around, checking for the brunette as she waited for Adam. Adora knew it was unlikely for Catra to want to stay again, she didn't like to rely on people too much, but Adora would love to cuddle all night.

"Uh, nah, I dont think so. Shell tell us if she does," Adam said scratching the back of his neck nervously. Adora watched Adam for a moment, he did seem nervous about something. She wondered what it was. In Adora's experience it took a lot to make Adam nervous, besides when he had a crush on a girl. She wondered if it was that new exchange student, she had seen him talking to.

"Hey Dorks," Catra called from the other side of the field and both twins looked at her before looking at each other and racing towards her. Adora was light on her feet and fast as a quarterback, but Adam was all strength as a line-backer. They were pretty evenly matched. Adora reached Catra moments before Adam and picked her up so Adam couldn't reach her . Catra squealed in surprise and laughed.

"Put me down dummy!" Catra laughed and Adora ran from Adam as he tried to save Catra. Catra was red faced and laughing when Adora finally put her down beside the twin's car. Catra punched Adora in the arm in retaliation but Adora just grinned.

"God you're such a cheater ," Adam said grumpily as he got into the passenger side and Catra jumped in the back, sitting forward between the seats. Adora got behind the wheel.

"I'm not a cheater! I won fair and square," Adora retorted.

"You're not meant to grab the finish line and run with it, Dor ," Adam said rolling his eyes.

"I'm with Adam, seems like cheater behaviour to me," Catra said with a playful smile.
"Catra put your seatbelt on," Adora retorted, instead of engaging further with the discussion. Catra rolled her eyes and buckled up. The conversation didn't die though, continuing all the way home. Adora was relieved to see dinner was ready when they got home, bringing the end of their argument.

Dinner and studying flew by and before long it was time for Catra to leave. Even Adora could tell she looked more stressed as the evening went on. Adora assumed it was because of going back to Weaver's tonight but once Catra was packed up and ready to head out she looked almost sick.

Adora gave her an extra long hug to reassure her but when Catra pulled back she took a deep shaky breath.

"Adora... We have to tell you something," Catra said softly , glancing at Adam who looked equally stressed. Adora glanced between them a few times before settling on Catra. Catra was always the leader.

“Adam and I have decided to date.” Catra said looking up at Adora’s confused blue eyes. Adora laughed and glanced at Adam, clearly thinking this was a joke.

“Very funny,” Adora said.

“Itsuh, not a joke, Dor” Adam added, scratching the back of his neck.

“You cant be serious,” Adora felt her stomach drop and a burning feeling start in her chest as she looked back at Catra. She felt so angry, it was like a hot flush through her body as she felt her hands shaking.

“Really . We thought we would see where it led,” Catra said looking into Adora’s eyes. Adora’s eyes were dark, she was not happy. “You’re the first one we’ve told,” Catra quickly continued, clearly trying to placate her. Like that would help at all.

Adora felt betrayed, like her twin and her best friend had kept something so important from her. That they were hiding their feelings from her until they decided to take this very big leap without a word beforehand. Adora couldnt stop the burning in her chest as she took deep breaths and tried to calm down. She didnt understand this reaction to the two most important people in her life finding happiness. What the hell was wrong with her?

“Why?” Adora asked and Catra looked confused, she was still so close and Adora just wished this was a joke. Adora wanted Catra to both come closer and get away from her. Why were her emotions such a mess?

"Why what?" Catra asked, her voice soft as she put her hand on Adora's forearm. Adora yanked it away and Catra flinched at the qick movement. Adora hated herself for making Catra flinch like Weaver does.

"Why did you keep this from me?" Adora asked, trying to keep the pain from her voice. She thought they told each other everything. How could they keep such a big secret. Surely this was why she was upset. How many times did they hug, and it meant more? How many times have they kissed without her knowing? W ere they sneaking around and hanging out without her? When did this all start?

"W e didnt, Dor ," Catra said trying to move closer again. Adora was struggling to control the volume of her voice. She really wasnt good with emotions, especially whatever this one was. She tried to keep her anger in check, it was hard when she wanted to hit something until the burning in her chest stopped. She held herself back, though she really didnt want to scare Catra.

"Y ou did, feelings dont just come out of nowhere!" Adora snapped and Catra finally moved back, she naturally shied away from yelling because of Weaver. Adora felt horrible so glanced at Adam, and he looked so uncomfortable that Adora looked back to Catra.
"It just happened, nothing' s going to change, I promise," Catra tried again and Adora looked so hurt. How could Catra use that word for this? Promise meant so much to them and she used it now!?

"That' s bullshit Cat, everything's going to change," she snapped, she needed to get away before her anger got the best of her. She never wanted to take it out on Catra. She already had so much to deal with. Adora stepped away and stomped up the stairs. Leaving the two lovebirds alone as she slammed her bedroom door.

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Adora needed to take her anger out on something. She was laying in bed fuming and unable to sleep. She needed an outlet and at almost midnight she needed it soon so she could still go to class. She sighed and got out of bed. She could go for a run, but her parents would lecture her about safety if she went in the middle of the night again.

She remembered they used to have a punching bag somewhere in the shed out back and decided she would dig it out. The night was cool, but she didnt bother to put on any layers, the cold would help distract her.

After fifteen minutes of digging, she found the punching bag and got it set up. She didnt bother with the gloves and just wrapped her hands before laying into the bag.

It helped, the rhythmic patterns of her strikes focusing her mind as she burnt away the energy in her chest. Only the feelings didnt move, it just seemed to grow the more she thought about it.

Adora and Catra touched the same way that Adam and Catra did, so what made their actions romantic and hers not? She knew it was probably down to intention. Catra was straight so no matter how special something felt to Adora, it just didnt feel that way to Catra. Adora would have to accept that.

Was Adora still able to touch Catra? Hug her? W ould she still come for sleepovers? Maybe Catra would not want to be so close to her

boyfriend sister. Maybe she knew Adora was being too possessive and wanted space to explore her own feelings.

Everyone knew how Weaver was, maybe Adora being too touchy with her was causing issues at home. Weaver was religious and pretty homophobic, even going so far as to say Adora would have been perfect if she wasnt a lesbian. Which was pretty unfair to say to a 12 year old.

Adora felt like she was mourning her best friend when she wasnt even gone. She didnt understand where she stood anymore, and she was definitely not jealous. A little bitter maybe, Adam won just by being the right gender? What a rip of f.

Adora and Adam's bedrooms were at the back of the house and with Adam being such a light sleeper she should have expected him when he appeared at the door to the shed. He looked tired and his hair was a mess as usual. Neither of them ever stopped moving, even in their sleep. The only time Adora ever slept in one place was when Catra was in the bed too. She didnt want to accidentally punch the smaller girl.

"Dor , its midnight," Adam said looking at the punching bag. Adora hadnt used it in years now . Since Adam had started forcing her to talk about her feelings, but he couldnt help with this one. Not when it was his fault, she was mad.

"Go away ," Adora said as she landed another hard punch to the bag, causing it to swing back.

"C'mon Dor , talk to me," Adam' s sad voice was like a knife. Pushing

her twin away was hard but she needed space to think before she could talk about it.

"Not now ,"Adora said looking over her shoulder at him as she lowered her fists and her shoulders slumped in defeat at the look at his face. "But soon, ok?"He looked satisfied and nodded before returning to the house.

I..

The act of telling Adora that Adam and Catra were dating was the worst moment of Catra's life by far. All the beatings and emotional abuse from Weaver didnt stand a chance against the look of betrayal in those blue eyes. Catra hated it, she hated it more than anything.
Waking in the shithole she called a house was a cold reality. She wished she could have woken up in Adora's arms just one more time before she decided to hate her forever.

Catra could be a little dramatic, but Adora was everything. Catra was on borrowed time, just waiting for Adora to forget about her . What she always feared seemed to have finally happened, she'd dug her own grave. It was only a matter of time now before Adora left her behind. Once Catra finished using Adam like the asshole she is, their friendship would probably never recover either. Then Catra would be all alone again. Like she should be.

Pathetic Weavers voice reminded her. She pushed herself out of bed and got ready for school. She put together something cute to wear before she did her makeup and hair. She had no misconception of her mother;she knew the only reason she had nice clothes and makeup was because Weaver made her a barbie doll to parade around. She was something to gloat about to other parents or

teachers, how smart, how pretty, how obedient her daughter was. She wasnt always so obedient, but she learned not to fight it, because one day soon, she would get out of this hell.

At breakfast Weaver made a comment about her terrible outfit choice and how she was putting on weight. That mercifully the best she had this morning, and they ate breakfast in relative silence. She got a ride to school in the metal prison of Weavers car and was relieved of further conversation.

Once at school they parted ways without a word and Catra went to find the twins, or any of their friends. She needed to hide in a familiar crowd. Scorpia had a locker near hers and greeted her with a hug. It was crushing, but it was nothing like the one she was missing. Adora's hugs were so protective and soft. They felt so safe.

"Hey Scorp," Catra greeted, not seeing either of the twins around. Catra felt a lead weight in her stomach about the announcement that she would have to do today. She was now dating Adam Grayskull, people would talk. She never thought she cared about lying, but now in the face of lying to all her friends and one of her best friends, it felt overwhelming.

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It took less than a day for word to get around school. From the first kiss Adam placed on Catra's cheek there were speculations. Then there was no stopping the wildfire which was the rumour mill. Walking into Lit holding hands with Adam was the weirdest feeling and getting wolf whistled by students in front of her mother was entirely mortifying. Catra hated all this attention, but she knew it would settle eventually.

She had to stop herself from looking at Adora all day. She had worn an old jersey today and her arms were on display. She couldn't help but look, they seemed so...juicy? They looked good and her desire to squeeze them was at the forefront of her mind. It didn't help that Catra couldn't look into those blue eyes, afraid of what she would see. So, she focused on Adam, trying to sell the lie and get at least some of the physical affection she was missing.

Catra knew Adora must be hating all the fuss as much as Catra was, usually the attention wouldn't bother her but this time it did. She knew why too;it was the wrong twin.

Adora took every opportunity to disappear from the limelight her brother and best friend had created, slipping into class and out again as quick as possible. She even spent more time with other friends between periods. Catra missed her immediately, but she had to remind herself that this was an adjustment and Adora would need time. She just hoped she wouldn't need too long.

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Adora hated this day. She felt the burning in her chest, and it just wouldn't die. It made her angry. She had spent hours trying to punch it out of her system. It made her arms tired and sore. She couldn't be around Adam and Catra right now. So, she asked Bow and Glimmer to eat lunch out on the oval with her instead of at their usual table. They agreed, knowing when Adora needed to vent. She wasn't hard to read.

So here they were, it was a warm day, and the oval was empty except the three friends. Adora had too much energy still, so she paced back and forth between them while she ate her lunch.

Glimmer was watching Adora walk back and forth but Bow was laying back on the grass relaxing as he waited for the next session of word vomit to come out.

"I just can't believe this" Adora repeated for the third time.

"Yeah, you said," Bow replied patiently , eyes still closed.

"It feels like it came out of nowhere!" Adora turned to pace back in the other direction.

"Yeah, it kind of did," Bow agreed. He couldn't deny it. At least they agreed on that.

"I'm pretty surprised too actually , I never thought those two ever acted romantic" Glimmer said eating her lunch with a conspirator look on her face.

"You can't judge how other people show romance, Glim" Bow sat up on his elbows now to look at Glimmer in slight horror. "They might have been hiding it until they found out they both felt the same," Bow loved love. Adora rolled her eyes.

"Yeah, maybe I just seems odd to me," Glimmer said biting her sandwich aggressively.

"Catra doesn't believe you can find your soulmate at school, why the hell would she mess around with Adam. I don't want to take sides when they break up," Adora huffed, bending down to her lunch tray to grab a pudding cup to eat angrily. Adora was trying to justify

herself and she felt like she was reaching at straws. Emotions were hard to understand.

"IF they break up you mean and maybe Catra changed her mind"? Bow offered and trying to read the angry look on Adora's face. She was really heated up.

"Is that why you are so upset? Because Catra might hurt your brother"? Glimmer asked bluntly , she knew Adora was bad with emotions, so they couldnt baby her about this.

"Obviously , why else would I be mad"? Adora asked and Glimmer and Bow exchanged a look.

"Maybe you're jealous"? Glimmer asked and Adora scof fed, looking insulted.

"Y -yeah, right? Of what"?

"W ell, you both follow Catra around like puppies, so maybe you're worried you will get less of her attention now that she is with Adam"? Glimmer said shrugging her shoulders and Adora stopped to look at her. Adora already knew she got jealous when Catra give Adam affection that she didnt give to her . Was she actually jealous of losing Catra's attention?

"That' s stupid, she's a person Glim, not something to be owned" Adora said, even if the pain in her chest suggested Glimmer was right. Glimmer just shrugged not seeming convinced.

“Alright, if you say so,”Glimmer grabbed her tray and looked at the two. “Lunch is almost over , we should get back,”

I..

The week felt like a blur and Friday gameday arrived. Catra and Adora had barely spoken and according to Adam they hadnt spoken about her feelings either. Which worried Catra. She wanted her best friend back and knew that wouldnt happen if Adora didnt deal with how she was feeling. If she repressed it, it would leave them adrift until the spark of their friendship would simply go out.

Catra felt almost lucky to be in her normal seat between the twins at lunch on Friday. Adora had been avoiding them all week, but she wouldnt break the tradition of having lunch with the team on game day.

Adora was qieter than usual, and Catra had spent the week giving her space with no improvement. So, she tried to talk to her now, but Adora gave short responses and fake smiles that broke her heart, so she gave up and just ate her lunch. Adam was now talking to Adora about the game over the top of Catra’s head while she ate her lunch and listened. Adora was more animated talking about the game, so she was happy to just listen.

Glimmer was sitting across the table from Catra while she read the schools gossip paper. No one knew who ran the paper, but it always had the latest dirt on everyone in the school. Glimmer was a little obsessed with it. Glimmer put the paper down and glared at Catra. “Ugh, you two are in the paper again today , gag”Glimmer said folding the paper to show Catra like she cared. Catra snorted and glanced at Adam who smiled at her. Their plan was working at least.

"It' s not my fault they have nothing else to report on,"

"Bow growing his hair out would be much more interesting than this,"

"Dont do it dude, short curls are way easier to manage," Catra said stabbing a piece of apple with her fork.

"I told you," Glimmer waved her hand at Catra like she had just prove string theory.

"Why'd you grow yours out then?" Bow asked as he covered his mouth so he could speak after taking a bite of his sandwich.
"Ma wants me to look more feminine," and it' s easier not to fight it.

"She probably thinks short hair makes you gay ," Glimmer snorted.

"Probably ," Catra shrugged and pulled on her ponytail held up with a red ribbon Adora had given her when she first joined the cheer team.
"It' s so stupid, I know plenty of lesbians with long hair, like Adora" Glimmer rolled her eyes and looked back at the paper.

"Adora just screams lesbian though" Catra looks down the table to where Adora is now arm-wrestling Sean Hawk.

"You're not wrong," Glimmer said and Catra tried to not watch Adora's bicep flex Why did she have to wear that singlet today?

Adora won and Sean went on a long story about how he once arm

wrestled an alligator and won. Adora looked over at Catra and caught her staring. Adora grinned at her and Catra rolled her eyes, it was almost like they were back to normal.

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Adora was not back to normal. The game was halfway through and Adora wasnt in the øne. She was distracted. This should be an easy win against Mysticor Magpies but they were only winning by a few points. They should be crushing them.

The cheer team was about to go on for the halftime dance and no one was cheering louder during the game than Catra.

"GO GRA SKILLS" she screamed as the crowd cheered behind her as Adora got a touchdown. Catra bounced and waved her pompoms as she caught the younger twin's eye. Adora smiled at her as the halftime horn rang and Catra felt butterflies in her stomach.

She tried to push down her blush like she was just having a hot flush and turned to her team. Once the footballers were off the field the cheer team went up to do their half time dance. It was a little racy, but Catra liked hip hop dancing in her free time, and she incorporated a lot of that into the cheer routines.

It was a hit, and once they had finished the crowd was pumped up for the rest of the game. As the team was heading back to the field Catra hip checked both twins on her way back to the sidelines. Adora looked flushed and grumbled, Catra hoped she had enough water at halftime. Adam hip checked her right back which almost knocked her over if he hadnt grabbed her waist. Some whistles from the team as she was pulled upright caused Catra to blush and Adam

winked at her. He was playing this game way too well. It was convincing at least.
Catra got back to her spot on the sidelines and the game continued. They won, but they never really regained the lead they should have had in this game. Catra hoped this was a once off and they could recover before they faced the Horde. Someone needed to talk to Adora to get her head on straight.

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Shower, change of clothes and a short drive later they arrived at the afterparty at Glimmer's house. Her parents were away for the weekend, so they had free reign of the house and what a house it was. Glimmer's parents were incredibly well off. They had nothing short of a mansion with a huge yard and a swimming pool.

The team and cheerleaders were all here along with some friends from school. It was easily more than fifty people for this small get together. Most people were playing games in the living room when Adam, Adora and Catra arrived. Adam was immediately entranced by the beer pong being played.

It took some effort, but Adam finally convinced Catra to play beer pong and Adora found Mermista to play with her. Mermista was better at aiming on the field where she could unleash but she was a decent shot. Adam and Catra were losing and Adora was having fun with Mermista while they heckled their competition.

Adora was starting to feel the effects of the alcohol even after only a few cups. Once they won Adora excused herself so Mermista could play with Sean against Adam and Bow. Adora decided to be responsible and headed to the kitchen for some water. She didnt notice Catra following her until Adora turned around with her glass of

water and jumped slightly at how close Catra was.
"Thanks," Catra took the glass and Adora blinked at her .

"Uh, you're welcome," she said going to the cupboard and getting another glass to fill it from the water in the fridge. Catra leaned on a counter as they both drank in silence. Once the water was gone and they had no excuse to be silent anymore and Adora started to feel nervous again. Why was it so hard to talk to Catra right now. She was being ridiculous.

"Hey , you wanna get some air?" Catra asked suddenly and Adora nodded, maybe that would help. It was loud and humid inside and maybe the cooling spring air would help.

"Sure," Adora agreed and Catra grabbed her hand to drag her towards the back door. Adora tried not to blush at the contact and took a deep breath to try to steady her heart. She was being ridiculous. It's just Catra, relax

Chapter End Notes

Adora really has no idea how she is feeling and it made it so hard to write it. Haha.

Everyone's comments on the first chapter were so lovely!<3

Check out my twitter for art for this fic. @moniiart

Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra talk and it goes about as well as you expect.

TW: Mention of panic attack, but it isn't described.

Chapter Notes

Are we ready for this mess?

Lets goooooo

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra kicked off her sandals to sit at the edge of the pool and looked up at Adora as she dipped her feet into the cool water. Adora looked awkward, but also *so* good in her singlet and jeans. It was probably Catra's imagination, but Adora's arms looked better than usual this week. She wondered if she was doing anything differently.

Adora shifted from foot to foot before she finally sat down, crossing her legs to keep her shoes away from the water. She didnt look comfortable as she fidgeted with her hands. Catra tried to think of anything to say to break the silence.

"Do you read the gossip paper?" Catra asked and kicked herself. Really? This was the best she could come up with. She hated that stupid paper.

"Uh, no, I dont read it, I just hear about it from Glimmer ," Adora said rubbing the back of her neck and not making eye contact.

It had been a week since Adora had looked directly at her and it was killing her. Even if Adora's eyes were full of betrayal, she wanted to see those baby blues looking into her soul.

"Yeah, uh, same. The paper said today that Melissa was thinking about cutting her hair. I thought Glimmer was going to lose it, Ive never seen her intervene so fast," Adora snorted and chuckled. Catra felt a warmth in her chest at the sound and she subconsciously leaned closer to Adora. "You cant believe anything in that paper though, it's all dribble," Catra continued and Adora shrugged.

"I mean, not all of it. Glim said you and Adam were in the paper this week," Adora said and Catra flinched, she didnt want to talk about Adam. She didnt want to lie to Adora' s face about their relationship. But apparently, she was going to.

"Well yeah, its news I guess, but did you read what they said?" Catra asked and Adora shook her head, glancing up at Catra. Catra smiled, feeling Adora's eyes on her breathed new life into her bones. She needed to keep her emotions to herself though, she didnt need to make more of a mess than she already was.

"Well, neither did I, because I dont care, and it doesnt matter ," Catra said and Adora snorted, not averting her gaze again. Catra knew

they had to make amends somehow. She was feeling bold and took one of Adora's hands that twisted in her lap and squeezed it. "I've missed you," Catra said and Adora looked at their joined hands with a small frown. Not the reaction she was expecting.

"I just... I don't get it." Adora said turning Catra's hand over to carefully play with her fingers. She ran her fingertips over Catra's sharp black nails, and she had to hold in a shudder at the feeling. She bit her lip, hoping there was more Adora wanted to say. So far, this sentence didn't make sense. "Why Adam?" Catra stomach dropped at the cold tone Adora uses and she blinks at her. Adora isn't making eye contact again and it's unnerving her.

"What do you mean, Dor?" Catra hopes her tone sounds supportive, but she feels a little rattled as her heart sped up.

"I guess... what do you like about him?" Adora continues to frown at Catra's hand as she runs her fingertip over her palm.

"Uh." Catra tried to think of something she likes about Adam and comes up with nothing. Well, not nothing. She loves her best friend. He's kind, gentle, a great listener and a huge meat head, but those things don't make her feel romantic towards him, because she doesn't...

She has to say something so she should just make something up, to make it sound romantic or Adora will ask more questions. The problem was, Catra has never had romantic feelings for anyone. She had never wanted to hold their hand, kiss them, or even do more. She just didn't feel that way about anyone. Only Adora.

Catra knows she's obsessed with the girl who shared her first kiss. She remembered those determined eyes when she was dared to kiss Catra. Catra was 9 and Adora was 10. It was soft and innocent, and they never mentioned it again. It might have been their first kiss Catra had loved Adora forever. Ever since that gap toothed smile beamed down at her in the sand pit and asked if she wanted to play on that first day of school. She wanted to take care of her for the rest of their lives, in any way she was allowed. That seemed unlikely now. Especially since Catra was ruining everything with her selfishness. Catra knew distance could help her get over her stupid feelings. Ever the self-destructive kitten she was, she just couldnt stay away from this blonde beacon guiding her home.

"Catra?" Adora prompted her and Catra panicked, she was quiet for too long. She needed to think of a lie, what do girls say about boys? How can they even like them! In her panic she decided to do something completely stupid and ridiculous. She will tell Adora, to her face, all the things she liked about *her*, under the guise of her brother's name. They were so similar it wasnt really a lie. T ime to swap some pronouns like a monster.

"Oh, uh, sorry , I was thinking," Adora lifted one eyebrow like she always did when she didnt believe her , but she didnt comment on it. Catra stumbled, feeling trapped in her own lies. "I- I like that he' s so sweet and considerate." Adam was those things too, so she wasnt a liar yet. "I like how funny and dorky he is," uh, that was a stretch, Adam was far less dorky than Adora. Adora raised her eyebrow again but stayed quiet. "And he' s really hot, like half the girls at school think so." that was true, objectively he was attractive, but the whole school agreed the twins were hot. Hot and modest.

Neither twin seemed to think they were much to look at. Everyone adamantly disagreed with that, they both looked like blonde gods. Catra was such a bitch to random people trying to make a pass at the twins because she was bullied a lot when she was younger for being close to the twins. Especially being their only friend for a while. Once they started to gather more friends the bullying stopped but people said awful things to her to try to get closer to the twins and get her away from them. Things she would never forget.

Adora looked surprised at her analysis and frowned, she looked like she regretted asking this question and Catra completely regretted answering it. It must be so weird to hear this about your brother from his girlfriend. She hoped Adora was oblivious enough to stop her reading too much into this description.

"I don't want you to hurt him," Adora said making eye contact again. She looked so serious which made Catra take a sharp breath. She felt her own defences rising from the accusation. I would never hurt him; I'd never hurt either of you. How could you say that?

"Why do you think I would hurt him?" Catra snapped a bit too defensive, yanking her hand away from Adora's lap. She couldn't help it. Weaver always told she was a monster, so why wouldn't Adora assume the same. The fire had started in Adora's eyes. She was rising to the challenge. It always happened this way when they argued. It was like a forest fire which burnt hot and fast until all that remained was the apologies they eventually choked out in its wake.

"Because you don't believe you'll find your soulmate in high school, so what? Are you just going to date him for a while and break his

heart?" Adora snapped back, pushing herself to her feet and looming over Catra. Catra scrambled to her feet, not to be outdone. Though she only came up to Adora's shoulder, but it was something.

"Oh, glad you're not worried about me at all, thanks for your concern," Catra snapped as she crossed her arms. Adora huf fed.

"Cat, you know what I mean," Adora said waving her arms like it made her clearer.

"No, I dont, sounds like you've got a lot of opinions I've never heard before," Catra bit out.

"I just dont want to choose between you two when you break up," Adora said looking sad and Catra felt like she had been slapped in the face. Adora didnt want to choose because she knew Catra would lose. This was her god damn brother she was messing with. Who she was using. Shes..he really was a monster .

"Fine," Catra said, grabbing her sandals of f the floor and storming away. Adora yelled after her, but the tears were already stinging and blurring her eyes. She didnt go back through the house, heading to the side gate to get to the road without seeing anyone. Catra could hear movement behind her and knew Adora was following her. She held back her sobs desperately as she got to the road.

"Catra, wait!" Adora wasn't that close, she wouldn't see Catra fall apart at least.

"Leave me alone!" Catra snapped, not even putting on her shoes before she started sprinting down the dark sidewalk.

"Catra!" Adora yelled but she couldn't hear her following and Catra wasn't stopping. The tears made it hard for her to navigate where she was. She didn't stop running until she was thoroughly lost and her legs burning. She was panting, some of her breaths sounding like sobs as she walked. She pulled out her phone. There wasn't much charge left but she had enough to find out where she was.

Forty minutes to home, she could do this.

The words her mother away told her repeated in her mind like a drum, beating her down. She let out a strangled sob as she felt her phone vibrate in her hand. She looked at the caller ID and seeing Adora's name she rejected the call.

She couldn't stop the panic attack even if she tried. She deserved these crushing feelings;it was payment for her actions. What has she done.

I..

Adam knew something was up when Adora came into the house by the front door and Catra wasn't with her. Hadn't they gone out the back? He looked at his sister's guilty face as she made eye contact, and he knew something was wrong. He excused himself from the game he was playing, he was pretty sure he was winning even if he couldn't remember which game he was playing right now.

"I can't find Catra," Adora spilled immediately when Adam approached her, and he frowned. Maybe he had too many cups of beer. Catra was missing? He thought about the last time he saw her, and she seemed fine. Not quite happy, since Adora and her were not talking but she seemed ok. Did something happen out the back?

"What do you mean Dor?" Adam asked with a frown and looked around like he could see her.

"We had an argument, and she ran off," Adora said her voice wavering like she was trying to hold something back. "I tried to call her, and she didn't answer,"

"What did you fight about? Is she alright?" Adam asked concerned. It was a stupid question, if Adora thought she was upset it was likely she was well beyond just upset. "Ok," he changed tactics, grabbed his phone out of his pocket and called Catra. It rang twice before the line was answered. The music was a bit loud around him, but he could hear the heavy breaths on the other line. Adam felt his stomach drop. Catra is having a panic attack. "Catra, where are you?" He asked and heard a sob. "I'll come get you," he promised and heard her snuffle.

Adora looked a mix between guilty and hopefully as she shuffled her feet and waited for her Adam.

"Seaford Avenue" Catra said breathlessly .

"Ok, Im coming, just breath," he said and heard a soft affirmation before the line went dead. He cursed and pulled up the maps to look for the street. Once he found it, he headed for the door. He registered Adora was right behind him, and he glanced over his shoulder.

"Stay here," Adam said firmly and Adora paused.

"I want to help,"

"I know , Dor, just later . She needs to calm down first" Adora shuffles her feet for a moment and nods. Adam nodded, satisfied, and headed down the street. After a few steps he started to run.

It didnt take him long to find Catra, she was sitting on the sidewalk curb in a little ball on the corner of Seaford Avenue and another street. She was gasping semi steadily, obviously trying to control her breathing. Adam came over to her and sat down beside her. Taking time to join her in her breathing until it evened out.

Once she had calmed down, she slumped against Adams shoulder looking exhausted.

"Maybe we should call this whole thing of f." Catra said so softly he almost missed it. He put his arm around her and pulled her into a hug. Not to tight, but firm to make sure she felt it.

"What happened, Cat?" He said softly into her hair . Catra held onto his shirt as she buried her face out of sight and let out a shaky breath.

"Adora and I had a fight," she said softly , and he nodded his head.

"Adora mentioned, want to tell me about it?

"She said" Catra sobbed "She said I was using you and when we break up, she wont be my friend anymore," Catra sobbed again. Adam rubbed her back carefully. Catra was shaking like a leaf.

"Is that why you want to end this?" he asked softly . He found it hard to believe Adora would be so direct with her feelings, but he knew denying it wouldnt help right now . Adora didnt always know how she felt and thought that I dont know' was a valid answer when it came to feelings.

Catra sniffled and Adam continued to rub her back in slow circles.

"I'm sorry I made you do this, Adam" Catra said, and Adam shook his head softly.

"You didn't make me do anything, I chose to help, so it's not all on you ok," Adam said firmly and after a few moments Catra nodded. "You shouldn't make your decisions based on Adora"

"This isn't about Adora," Catra said pushing back from his arms and frowning at him. Her eyes were glossy and red, but she still looked fierce. Catra's softness was always short lived, she wanted to cuddle then lash out because she felt weak. It was a cycle Adam knew well. "This is about me, I don't want to feel like I am using my best friend, so this is your out. We'll call it off now." Catra looked at him with determined eyes and he knew her mind had been made up. But it wasn't going to stop him from trying to convince her.

"If it's not about Adora, and I don't think you are using me, why would we have to stop this? It's working. You said it yourself, your mum's been nice this week. So why should we stop if there's nothing wrong?" He asked, tucking her head back under his chin and getting an indignant sound from the smaller girl.

"We agreed no questions asked." Catra grumbled even as she snuggled into his arms further.

"You're right. We did agree on that. How about this? If you still feel this way on Monday, we'll call it off. I'm not trying to stop you; I'm just asking you think about it when you aren't upset." Adam said clearly and Catra pushed away from him again. He let her go, offering her a reassuring smile.

"Fine, I'll think about it." Catra huffed and rolled her eyes. "You're so needy," she teased, and he grinned.

"Yeah, I can't help it, I have all this love, I have to crush people with it" he said flexing and Catra laughed.

"Sure, dumbass, nothing to do with the golden retriever blood" Catra teased as one side of her mouth twitched up. Soft Catra was gone like she was never here. Adam pushed himself to his feet with his hands on his knees.

"Well, that golden retriever energy has to go somewhere, so you better let me walk you home," He said offering his hand to Catra. She rolled her eyes and pulled herself up.

"Fiiine, if you must," Catra said with a heavy sigh like it was the most inconvenient thing ever.

"If must, you should text Adora to let her know you are ok. She was pretty worried," Adam said casually and Catra barked a sarcastic laugh.

"Yeah, right. My phone died when you called me, so you can let her know, if you want," Catra said finally putting her shoes back on and crossing her arms.

"Fine," Adam rolled his eyes and pulled out his phone.

"I..

Adora was trying to pay attention to what Glimmer was telling her. Desperate to distract herself from Catra. She finally got a text from Adam to say Catra was ok, and he would see her at home. Adora didn't bother to stay long after that. She drove home since she had only had a couple of drinks early in the night and threw herself down on her bed when she got there.

It was late so their parents were in bed. After some time, moping and running over the argument in her head a couple of times she finally pushed herself up to shower and get ready for bed.

It took hours to fall asleep and the knock on the door barely after sunup was not appreciated in the least.

“I’m sleeping!” Adora yelled before hiding under the blankets. Apparently, that wasn’t a good enough reason to not disturb her , and the door was opened. Adora peaked out from under the blankets when the door closed again, and Adam walked over to her bed to sit down.

Adora groaned and resigned herself to being awake right now instead of getting to sleep all day like she wanted.

“Catra got home ok by the way ,” Adam said looking at the wall without looking at the lump that was Adora. Adora pushed the blankets off her face and saw the look on Adam’s face. It did better than coffee at waking her up and she pushed herself to sit up on the bed.

“Is she ok?” Adora asked, feeling ashamed.

“I think so” he said unsure, and his hard eyes met Adora’s. “What happened Dor?”

“Ask Catra,” Adora said awake enough to be childish, apparently .

“I did, now I want to know what you have to say ,” Adam said and Adora looked down at the bed, picking at the sheets.

"Fineall I said was I didnt want her to hurt you," Adora said glancing up as Adam frowned. "She never believes in dating in high school. So, I wanted to do the sisterly thing, and tell her not to hurt you," Adam nodded with a huf f that sounded like a laugh.

"Dor ', you are making this so much more serious than it is. W e are just testing the waters. It' s not like we expect to be together forever ." Adam said with a soft laugh when Adora looked surprised.

"Y ou dont think you will stay together?" Adora had a weird feeling in her chest, it felt bubbly like soda and made her want to jump around.

"W e dont know , that's what dating is for. If we find it doesnt work, we will just stay friends. That' s why we are taking it slow," he said blushing softly and Adora nodded. It made sense, she hadnt seen them kiss. They must be taking it super slow. Weaver would approve, her being so religious would be so proud.

"Oh," Adora didnt know what to say . She felt like an ass. She rubbed the back of her neck as she thought about what she said to Catra and how she looked so hurt. Catra clearly didnt take it the way Adora had meant it. Maybe she did, Adora was never great at getting her feelings straight.

"Y ep, so make sure you apologise," Adam said getting to his feet. She noticed for the first time he was in his workout clothes and Adora nodded. "Anyways, enjoy your sleep in, Im going to go play

some basketball,”Adora nodded again and once he left, she slumped back into bed with a groan.

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Adora woke again about mid-day and sent a text to Catra. She didnt have high hopes that Catra would respond since it was within 48 hours of their argument. She still had at least 38 hours of the silent treatment left.

Adora: Can we talk?

Adora decided to go about her day. She messaged Glimmer to confirm their brunch plans on Sunday, tidied her room and did homework. Without a response from Catra on Saturday she spent time with Adam playing Mario Kart and throwing the football in the yard. It was nice. It was normal. Adora really needed that.

Sunday brunch was at the Seaworthy Diner. It had red booths with and old juke box at the end of the long establishment. They had been coming here for years, so it wasnt a surprised that the staff knew them by name.

Bow was ordering his food while Adora looked over the menu. Once their food was all ordered Adora drank some of her coffee and leaned back with a long sigh. It was nice to spend time with Glimmer and Bow. They felt completely external to Adora’s current headache.

"So, how' s Catra"? *Or not…* Adora groaned and covered her hands over her face.

"Please, can we not talk about Catra"? Adora asked in exasperation.

"Really? Y ou usually want to talk about Catra," Glimmer pointed out as she put sugar into her coffee. Adora felt guilty, did she only hang out with them to complain? She liked them both, they were good friends and she needed to be a better one.

"Not today , what's happening with you guys"? Adora asked and Glimmer jumped into a explanation of the yearbook club as Bow watched with moony eyes.

Adora listened and nodded, it wasn't long until they got their food. Glimmer continued to talk and Adora nodded along until Glimmer gasped dramatically.

"TEELA! Over here!" Glimmer said standing at the table awkwardly and waving her arm at franticly. Bow looked over where Glimmer was looking and grinned, obviously recognising the red head.

Adora didn't know T eela well, she was aware she was in their year, she was an exchange student from Scotland. She was tall and slender with long red hair and freckles all over her pale skin. She

was cute;she had seen Adam talking to her plenty and she couldnt fault his tastes.

"T eela, how are you? Have you met Adora?" Glimmer asked excitedly and T eela looked at Adora with her soft blue eyes and smiled.

"I dont think so, nice to meet you," T eela offered her hand to shake and Adora clasped it.

"I think you know my brother ," Adora of fered, and realisation bloomed on Teela's face.

"Ohh, Adora, Grayskull, yeah, I know Adam," T eela said with a soft blush on her cheeks. Adora smiled at her, and Teela moved the gym bag on her shoulder awkwardly. Adora noticed the boxing gloves inside the bag and grins.

"Y ou box?" Adora asked and T eela nodded excitedly .

"Y eah, absolutely, I run the boxing club at school," T eela offered and Adora's eyes widened.

"I didnt know there was one!" Adora said excitedly

"It's pretty new, you should join," Teela offered and Adora nodded.

"We meet on Monday nights if you're interested. At the gym. It's probably late enough to not interfere with your practice," Teela said and Adora nodded. Curious how Teela knew how long football practice went.

"I'll have to check it out, what time?" Adora grinned.

"At 5pm, we can't stay later than 6pm at school so it's the last slot we can use,"

"You sure you want to do that after practice?" Bow asked, eating some of his burger. "Won't you be tired?"

"Yeah, I think I can manage, Mondays are always a chill practice anyway," Adora nodded. Teela reached into her bag and got out a pamphlet and offered it to Adora.

"You can always change your mind if it's too much, but come check it out," Teela offered and Adora grinned and took the pamphlet.

"I'd love to," Adora nodded.

"Awesome! Tee, I wanted to ask. Can you send me those pictures from the last game when you get a chance? I'd love a picture to go with the article I'm submitting to the paper ,"

"What article?" Adora asked curiously ,

"Just about the cheer squad and the last game, school spirit and all that,"

"Sure, I will send it through tonight, I better get my cof fee and go. See you all tomorrow," T eela said and they waved. Once Teela was far enough away, Glimmer leaned on the table and gasped.

"What was THA T!?" Glimmer asked in a stage whisper . Adora blushed for absolutely no reason but felt judged.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked, clearly confused.

"Since when do you do boxing?" Glimmer asked conspiratorially .

"Since always, I've picked it up again recently though." Adora defended, she did not want to mention it was since Adam and Catra started dating. She didn't need the ribbing that went along with that.

"Sure, a likely excuse, are you interested in her?" Glimmer asked and Adora gasped.

"What? No!" She defended maybe too quickly . She couldn't shake the memory of Adam hanging out with Teela. It was just weird to like anyone who liked the other twin. Adora tried to shake the reminder of Catra, Catra, Catra ringing in her head.

"Sure, I've seen you join clubs for a crush before," Glimmer accused. Adora paused and tipped her head in confusion.

"What! With who?" She demanded.

"Scorpia, obviously!" Glimmer pointed her finger now . There was a reason she was in the drama club.

"I have never , and would never have a crush on Scorpia, I wrestled in junior year for fun" Adora crossed her arms as she leaned back on the booth. She was annoyed she didn't have any food left to distract from this ridiculous conversation.

"Uh huh," Glimmer looked unconvinced.

"Glim, we should support Adora' s attempts to make friends, it's a good thing," Bow said putting her hand on her pointed finger and lowering it to the table as he laced their fingers together.

"Thank you," Adora was finally getting a reprieve.

"And if you like her , that's ok too," Bow said with a playful smile of betrayal.

"I dont like her!" Adora yelled and her eyes went wide as she looked around at the people looking at her. Teela looked at her in surprise before blushing and pushing the door open to leave the diner with her iced drink.

"I hate you both," Adora grumbled.

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Saturday sucked and Sunday was much worse for Catra. Already angry and hurt as she rage studied, and ignored Adora's half assed text to fix things. Sunday came and it was Catra' s least favorited day of the week, the lord's day. Her mother forced her to dress in formal clothing to go and sit with a bunch of other squares for four hours each week. The collar of her white blouse choked her, and her grey skirt pinched her waist uncomfortably while she sat. She wore skin-coloured tights and kitten heals with her hair tied up and pinned into submission.

Once the torture of the service was over, they drove home while Catra pretended to listen to her mother as she recited information and gossip, she heard after the service. Catra listened for anything that needed her input and dropped a perfect:

"Yes Mother," at the correct time.

Catra looked out the window as they drove through town. When they stopped at the lights near the diner Catra looked in. Catra noticed familiar pink hair in one of the booths and sat at attention as she noticed the blonde sitting with her. That wasnt all she noticed, Catra also saw a tall and beautiful red head talking to the blonde. The redhead looked so happy and Adora seemed engaged in the conversation.

Without any context of what was happening, Catra felt a burning feeling settle in her chest as she slumped back on her chair and glared at the woman. When the lights changed and the car moved, she glared for as long as she could before the diner was out of view.

Who the hell was that?!

Chapter End Notes

There is a strong likelihood that this will be extended to 10 chapters because I cannot get through all this drama, plot and feelings in 7 chapters.

Thanks for reading!<3

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra finally talk!

Featuring the best make-up hug ever.

Chapter Notes

CW for Weavers A+ parenting in this chapter. I've put a warning in right before it starts if anyone needs to skip. Take care of yourselves. <3

Yes, the chapter count has changed. I can't fit all of this drama into 7 chapters anymore!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Monday was a whirlwind of classes, training, and clubs. Catra and Adora seem to have mutually agreed to ignore their argument and give each other silent treatment. Which was their usual road to forgiveness. School isnt the right place for them to talk about it anyway, so Adora focuses on anything else to get through the day.

After school and training conclude, Adora tells Adam she was going to a club and that he could take Catra home. He is reluctant to leave Adora at school without a ride, but he gives in after some convincing.

Adora makes her way to the boxing club. Going to another physical club after training made her regret her choices but it would be nice to talk to Teela. Teela was excited to see Adora and happily introduced

the few members they had. Adora met Lonnie and Rogelio who were in her class, but she didnt talk to them much. She also met a strange girl with purple hair and big glasses who claimed to be there for research. Her name was Entrapta.

After introductions Teela went over the rules and sparring etiqette before her and Adora got on the mat. Adora's overused muscles burned with strain as they circled each other but it focused her mind. Teela was very good, she was fast and mouthy, definitely not afraid to distract her opponent with a verbal lashing. She reminded Adora of Catra but she tried to ignore that. Those thoughts were not what she was here for.

Teela won their first match and Adora stayed behind after the club to sign up and chat with Teela. The exertion helped to clear Adora's head, and she was excited to get home and shower. Maybe she would even speed run the forgiveness course and talk to Catra tonight.

Teela offered to drop Adora home, so she didnt have to walk. She accepted and they chatted on the drive home. It was a nice and easy conversation, if not a little awkward getting to know each other.

Adora went inside after waving to her new friend. The house was qiet and Adora headed for the kitchen. She could see something in the oven but no sign of mum. She noticed Adam and Catra werent downstairs either. Were they in Adam's room? Adora felt her stomach drop at the thought, it wasnt what she meant by taking Catra home. She reassured herself it was just because she wanted to talk things out with Catra. She was **not** jealous.

Adora set up at the kitchen table alone and tried to ignore the brewing storm inside her head. She didnt want to think about what Catra, and Adam might be doing upstairs, but her brain kept circling back to wild scenarios.

Catra's probably just ignoring me, it doesnt matter what they are doing…

The front door slammed and Adora jolted at the noise before her mother came into the kitchen with a shopping bag.

"Hey Pumpkin," Linda said affectionately and kissed the top of Adora's head. Linda looked like an older version of Adora, her blonde hair cropped short, and her face held laugh lines around her eyes from 40 years of joy. Adora hoped to age as gracefully as her mother.

"Hey mum," Adora huffed. Linda looked back over her shoulder at Adora as she unpacked the bag of shopping.

"What's the matter sweetie?" Linda asked, "Where is Adam and Catra?"

"They're off being lovey dovey in Adam's room," Adora tried to hold back the bitter burning in her chest, but she failed miserably. Linda

looked confused and turned to face Adora fully.

"Lovey dovey?" Linda asked, leaning back on the counter as she waited.

"Yeah, since they are dating now," Adora said, erasing an equation with too much force, making the table shake.

"Adam and Catra?" Linda looked surprised, like she couldn't believe it. Was it really so far-fetched?

"Yeah, didn't Adam say anything?" Adora asked, wondering why they would keep it from their parents.

"No, he didn't, uh, excuse me," Linda stomped out of the room towards the staircase.

"ADOS? Downstairs, now!" Linda's loud commanding voice made Adora smirk. It was nice not to be at the receiving end and watch Adam be in trouble for once. Adam was always the more level headed twin, watching and waiting to act where Adora was all action and no thoughts. It meant Adora often got into trouble for breaking things by accident due to her lack of consideration.

"Coming!" Adam called back immediately , and Linda waited at the bottom of the stairs. Catra was the first one to come into the kitchen, her school folder held against her chest. Adam was less organised, dropping some papers on the ground as he came to put them on the table. Linda walked in behind them.

The front door slammed again as Dean arrived home and walked into the kitchen moments later. He went straight to Linda and placed a kiss on her cheek affectionately. He paused to note his wife's unhappy face. He looked at the kids who Linda was levelling with a heavy gaze.

"Hey kids," He greeted them as Catra and Adam got set up to continue their homework. Neither looked as guilty as Adora expected them to look. Dean received varied greetings of hey dad' back from the three teens.

"I'm not sure why you didn't mention it to us, but with Adam and Catra dating now some house rules have to change," Linda started, and Dean looked surprised.

"Adam and Catra? Really?" He asked his wife.

"I know!" Linda tittered, with a small laugh.

"Huh," Dean said. The kids looked at each other , very confused. They were clearly missing whatever they were referring to.

"Anyway , we have to change some rules," Linda started again, and the kids nodded. Catra looked a little embarrassed, maybe she saw where this was going. "No girls in your room with the doors closed, understood? It' s not that we dont trust you, but there will be no unplanned pregnancy in this house," Linda said firmly .

"MUM!" Adam said looking horrified and Catra hid her face. Getting a sex talk from someone else' s parents must be embarrassing. Adora couldn't help but huff a laugh at their embarrassment.

"Dont 'mum' me, there will be no funny business under this roof Adam," Linda said, and Adam ducked his head, looking embarrassed. "Catra, you are always, **always** welcome here. If you need to stay over, you just cant stay with Adam, ok? So, you can either stay in Adora's room, or we can set up a cot for you in the study if you would prefer,"

Catra lifted her head looking like a beetroot as she made eye contact with Adora. Adora knew that look, she wanted to know Adora was ok with her continuing to stay in her room.

"I dont mind her staying with me," Adora said, Catra looked relieved and Adora smiled. Linda nodded her head.

"Good, same goes for you Adora," Adora nodded in understanding, she didnt have any current prospects anyway .

"Makes sense," she agreed.

"Good, now finish your homework, dinner will be ready in about 30 minutes," Linda said and Dean nodded.

"Good talk," Dean said with a goofy smile at his kids and headed to the shower.

...

Mortified is a good word for situations like this. She did not expect Linda to come up with new house rules. Catra really didn't want their parents to know at all. It would be better if they were kept in the dark and she didn't have to lie to the only real parents she ever had.

Adam looked horrified at the mere suggestion of sex with Catra and Catra could only share the sentiment. The idea of doing that with Adam was enough to make her want to gag. He was like a brother to her. She only had herself to blame for causing this awkward experience.

Adora and Catra still didn't talk Monday night as they studied quietly after dinner before Catra went home to a cold quiet house. Weaver was asleep on the couch with the TV on after drinking too much wine.

Catra sat at her window burning a vanilla candle Adora bought her when they were 15 and sketched. Everything turned into something of Adora, her beautiful eyes, her cute little nose, her dark eyebrows. She missed her.

It helped Catra relax before bed. She didn't want this rift between her and Adora, but she didn't know what else to do. She tried to bridge that gap multiple times this week. Should she just try again? Surely it was Adora's turn to apologise.

Tuesday was much the same as Monday, more silence. Except now, Catra was also pissed. She found out who was talking to Adora on Sunday and it turned out that Teela was quite popular with both the twins now. Catra watched Adam and Adora joking with the red head. Teela was laughing and Adam was blushing. She should be pissed on principle, because he was her boyfriend but she also couldn't care less because Adora was laughing too. At least she didn't look as smitten as Adam. Maybe Catra underestimated his attraction to her. Had she really read her best friend so poorly?

Adora looked so happy and carefree in this moment, her lunch completely ignored the conversation Teela was providing. Catra felt her anger seething for the woman and she knew it was written all over her face. She almost wanted Adora to see it, if she would just look this way.

"What's got you all fluf fed up," Glimmer asked as she sat down on the seat across from Catra. Catra glared at Sparkles and when Bow

joined her she glared at him too. He opened his mouth before making eye contact with Catra and closing it again. He could read the mood, she was not to be teased. Too bad Glimmer was blind to it.

"You shouldn't be so jealous, it's unattractive," Glimmer said playfully while picking at her lunch.

"I'm not!" Catra snapped and pushed herself to stand, her chair screeching as she pushed it back. She had barely touched her lunch. The loud noise attracted too many eyes including the two sets of blues. Adam made to go to Catra to check on her and Catra levelled him with her best 'don't' glare. He stopped and looked like a kicked puppy for a moment glancing at Teela. He was confused. She didn't spare a glance at Adora as she ditched her lunch and walked out of the cafeteria.

She knew Adam would probably ask later about her little hissy fit, but for now she just wanted to get away from the burning feeling in her chest. She couldn't handle the choking grip it had on her heart. Running was her best option, though trying to outrun her feelings rarely worked.

Catra decided to go outside, maybe actually running would help clear her head. She pushed open the heavy doors out of the building and headed towards the oval. The doors banged closed behind her but then she heard them open again. She paused to look back, expecting Adam when she saw Adora looking sheepish. Seems Adora didn't get the message. It was common for one of the twins to follow her when she skulked off in a huff but she didn't expect Adora

to follow that tradition right now while they were fighting. Catra felt her heart rate pick up as she looked at her with big eyes.

"Uh, hey." Adora said softly as she approached.

"Hey Adora," Catra said, trying to recover herself. Why was Adora here? Catra thought they weren't finished ignoring each other yet. Adora glanced around and Catra did the same. It was a warm day and the smell of freshly cut grass was on the breeze. Catra looked back at Adora, looking up at her as she stepped closer. It was confirmed that they were alone.

"Can...can we talk?" Adora asked softly and Catra released the breath she didn't know she was holding and nodded.

"Sure," she said, leading Adora to the benches near the oval where they sat down. Adora sat down as she leaned her elbows on her knees and locked her eyes on the ground between her feet. Catra perched on the bench like she was ready to bolt. She hated talking about feelings, Catra's were volatile and Adora didn't always understand them. They were silent for a long time.

Adora let out a heavy sigh and pushed herself to sit upright and face Catra. Catra's eyes were wide and Adora's softened when she realised how worried Catra was. Silent Catra was often the most panicked version.

"I'm so sorry , for what I said and how I acted. I never should have said that. I didn't mean it," Adora said confidently , like she had rehearsed this.

"Why?" Catra asked, her body only getting more tense from the apology and Adora frowned slightly. She clearly thought the apology was going to be enough but fat chance. Catra needed more. She needed Adora to take it back.

"Why what?" Adora looked confused and Catra knew she would have to be the one to lead this conversation. As always.

"Why did you say that? *Why did you say you'd leave me*

"I don't know I just I guess I don't know where we stand right now , with you and Adam dating,"

"You're still my best friend," *Nothing*

"I just feel like I'm not allowed to touch you or hug you. I feel like I can't act like nothings changed." Adora gently takes Catra's hand in hers and Catra relaxes slightly as their fingers lace.

"Of course you can still touch me, nothing's going to change that. You have full hugging privileges, dummy" Catra smiles but it's a little

tight. She wanted to ask if Adora would abandon her after Adam and her break up, but she wasn't sure if she could stop herself from crying at school if the answer was yes.

"Can I hug you now?" Adora asked, her big blue eyes looking hopeful as Catra rolled her eyes to try to break the tension.

"Yeah, dummy" Catra said and was immediately enveloped in the best damn hug she has ever had. Their time not hugging obviously made this hug better than ever. Adora was warm and firm with her arms wrapped around Catra securely. Catra melted a little into the hug, wanting to savour it as she wrapped her own arms around Adora's waist and buried her face in Adora's shoulder. Adora let out a soft long breath like she was deflating and her weight settled on Catra like a grounding presence.

"Took you long enough," Catra snarked into Adora's shoulder and felt her chuckle.

"Sorry," Adora breathed out into the hair on the top of Catra's head.

"You better not disappear on me again," Catra scolded, *Please dont leave me*.

She heard Adora take a sharp breath before she sighed again. More tension in her body slipped away.

I won't," Adora said softly as she nuzzled Catra.

"Promise?" Catra mumbled, embarrassed by her own actions, bringing up such a childish thing at almost 18 years old. Adora chuckled again, but not unkindly.

"Promise," Adora said firmly , leaving no room for doubt. If Catra could purr with delight she would have. This was the best hug ever.

[..]

Tuesday night was almost normal, hugging Catra had completely removed the burning feeling in Adora's chest. Whenever it returned Adora would gently tap Catra somewhere and Catra would smile at her. It made her feel amazing as it chased away the heavy feeling and another much lighter feeling replaced it in her chest.

Catra seemed to enjoy it too, even Adam was relieved they had made up. He didn't seem to mind Adora continuing to bother Catra, so Adora had no reason to stop. She almost expected Adam to get jealous of the affection, but he wasn't.

So that's how the three of them were as they sat on the floor in the living room doing homework. Adora was gently running her thumb over the index finger of Catra's left hand as she tried to do Math. It

was an automatic motion and Adora had completely forgotten she was doing it until Catra moved her hand away. Adora glanced up at her curiously and Catra looked a little flushed.

"It's tickling," Catra explained and Adora nodded. That was fair, it was pretty soft.

"Sorry," Adora said with a smile and grabbed her pen to fidget with instead and Catra smiled. Adam was frowning at his page and biting the end of his pen as he concentrated.

The room was warm and the smell of dinner was making Adora hungry. It really did feel like before Adam and Catra got together. It was a simple supportive bubble. Could it be that nothing had changed? Was Adora making a fuss out of nothing?

"Teela's pretty cool," Adam says suddenly as he looks up at Adora and she drops her pen at the sudden noise. Catra glares at him and he looks a little embarrassed.

"Yeah, she is," Adora agrees, a little confused since this came out of nowhere. "She's really good at boxing too," Adora offers to carry the conversation. Catra huffs and crosses her arms as she adjusts her position on the floor.

"Yeah... she's an exchange student or something right?" Adam asked curiously and Adora nodded. "Do you know how long she's in the

states for?”Adam asked.

“T ill the end of the year I think, Im not sure what her plans are after high school,”Adora said, tilting her head curiously at her brother . Catra was still glaring daggers at Adam.

“That makes sense, I can't remember us having an exchange student before,”Adam said and Adora nodded again.

“Y eah, me neither I guess,”Adora said thoughtfully and glanced at Catra.

“Isnt that Entrapta girl from our class Swedish or something?”Catra asked as she closed her folder, clearly giving up on finishing her homework here. Adora closed hers too, happy to stop math in order to talk while Catra was still here.

“Oh, she's in my boxing club, but she doesnt participate, just watches,”Adora mentioned and Catra raised her eyebrows.

“What?She just watches?Isnt that kind of creepy?”Catra asked

“I guess?Im used to being watched when I do sports though,”Adora shrugged and Catra rolled her eyes.

"W ell duh, but I doubt that club has half the student body in it, it's kind of more personal isn't it?" Catra said.

"She has a point, I wouldn't want someone just watching me while I work out," Adam said, closing his book with a sigh and Adora shrugged again.

"I guess it's a little weird, she said it was for research," Adora said, spinning her pen on her fingers to stop herself from fidgeting with something else.

"Research? For what?" Catra asked, her voice squeaking as it raised slightly.

"I didn't really talk to her ," Adora said with another shrug.

"Of course not, you were too busy talking to T eela," Catra said looking annoyed and Adam shifted uncomfortably.

"Uh, I mean, I was sparring with her most of the club so I didn't talk much with the others," Adora said, she was pretty used to Catra' s jealousy about new friends and if T eela was going to be a regular she had to take the time to reassure Catra along the way.

"W ell-" Catra started but stopped as her phone started to ring. She moved some papers around to find it under the stack and looked at the caller ID. She suddenly looked a little pale and answered the phone with a timid "hello."

Catra mostly listened but she nodded her head slightly as if the person on the other end could see her. She bit her lip and Adora frowned. It had to be Weaver who got this kind of reaction from Catra.

"Ok, Ill be home soon," Catra said softly , and with a small "bye" hung up the phone. She looked at the twins who were watching attentively and then looked down at her schoolwork and started packing things up.

"Uh, W eaver wants me home for dinner," Catra said as she packed her bag again and stood. The twins both stood as well.

"Oh, did she cook?" Adora asked and Catra shrugged.

"Not sure, if she did it' s never going to be as good as Linda's chicken pie," Catra said with a tight smile, and Adora tried to smile reassuringly. "I better go," She said, reaching out and hugging Adam, who gave her a tight hug before Catra turned to Adora. Adora knew she looked hopeful. Catra rolled her eyes before she hugged Adora too, lingering a little while. Adora wouldnt complain about the extra attention, especially not from Catra. She pulled away and Adora missed her already.

"See you tomorrow Dummies," Catra said "Apologise to Linda for me," She said over her shoulder before she left through the front door.

Adam turned to Adora almost immediately and smiled. "I'm glad you two worked it out, I hate it when you fight," he said with a warm smile. Adora grinned back.

"Me too, it's nice to feel like things are back to normal," Adora said with an easy smile as she put her hands in her pockets.

"Did you work out what you were upset about?" Adam asked as he tipped his head.

"Yeah, kind of. I just felt like I couldn't treat her like normal. It felt weird to hug her, not knowing where we stood,"

"I get that. I know it feels like everything has changed, but you two are still best friends." Adam said, smiling.

"Yeah, I know, I guess I was worried about you getting jealous too" Adora looked awkward and Adam looked surprised before he laughed.

"I'm not going to stop you expressing your friendship the way it suits you. I wont get jealous," Adam said, shrugging. Adam really was good with emotions, even Adora got jealous but Adam was so certain of his resolve. His words lightened the weight on her chest. It was a relief to think that if Catra was ok, Adam would be fine too.

She just had to read Catra, which she had years of experience doing. She didnt always get it right, but Catra was never shy to correct her. She was a constant in Adora's life that she never wanted to give up. She would do whatever she could to keep her.

[..] **[CW : Alcoholism,slut shaming,abuse]**

The house was cold and dark but the dining room light was on. Catra put her bag down by the door with a heavy thud. She took a deep breath to prepare for whatever was about to happen. She hadnt been home for dinner in what felt like years now. Weaver rarely asked her to since it saved money to not have to feed your own kid.

Catra stepped into the dining room and her mother was sitting at one end of the dining table looking at her full glass of wine. She didnt have a plate in front of her but a pre-made lasagna sat in the middle of the table untouched. The table was set for one at the other end from Weaver and Catra forced a smile as she sat down.

"Thank you for cooking," Catra forced out as she lifted her plate to serve herself, already missing Linda's amazing chicken pie. Weaver just nodded her head in acknowledgement as she sipped her wine.

Catra was on edge but she was reasonably sure the food wouldnt be poisoned. Weaver often preferred a liqid dinner .

"I got an interesting call today ," Weaver said calmly, and Catra tensed as she looked up at her mother. Waiting for her to continue, which she did unprompted. "Linda called me," Catra bit her lip.

"Oh?" she asked, unsure what else to say . Linda only just heard about Adam and Catra's "relationship" so it made sense she cared enough to check in with Weaver. Her mother would have despised getting this call.

"She wanted to make sure I was aware of your relationship with their son," Weaver said, swirling her glass as she watched Catra carefully over the rim. "Of course I was aware, but why was she not?" Weaver put down her glass as she got to her feet. Catra leaned back in her chair and watched Weaver with wide attentive eyes, ready to run. "Why , child, did you keep this from her? What have you been doing that you didnt want her to know?" Weaver spoke in a calm voice as she approached the other end of the table. Catra slid to the other edge of the chair away from Weaver, knowing her escape would be around the other end and out the door. "What do you not want me to know? Are you keeping secrets?"

"No, ma'am" Catra forced out.

"Have you defiled yourself?" Weaver spat and Catra couldnt stop the glare even if she tried. She knew Weaver believed she was a

sinner even when she acted her best. She would never believe Catra even if she *was* living by the cross.

"No, mother I am still a virgin," Catra said but she was unsure if Weaver would believe her, as it always depended on how many glasses she had. It really was no one's business but her own if she chose to love someone that way. It was her body and her decision.

"Liar ," W eaver hissed and Catra slid out of her chair, keeping it between her as Weaver got closer. "Y oure trying to embarrass me in front of my friends arent you? Y ou better not be pregnant or Ill take care of it myself,"

"No, mother , Ive never done that with anyone!" Catra said, and Weaver knocked down the chair. It banged loudly off the floor making Catra jump. The temporary distraction was enough for Weaver to close the distance.

"LIAR!" She yelled and slapped Catra hard across the face, knocking her down to the ground. Catra hit the floor hard in her shock and scooted back away from Weaver, coming into contact with the wall. She pressed against it, her chest rising and falling as she started to panic. Weaver didnt move for a moment before she put her fingers to the bridge of her nose.

[CW]

"Look what you've made me do, go to your room. I can't even look at you," Weaver said and Catra tried to hold in a sob.

"I'm not lying," she said softly , and Weaver glared down at her.

"Go. Now ." Weaver gritted out and Catra took her planned escape. She grabbed her bag by the door and ran up the stairs. Ignoring her growling stomach. She couldn't feel the pain in her eye yet because of the adrenalin but she was sure as hell not staying here.

She packed some clothes into her bag, not really looking at what she grabbed before she swung her way out of her window. Weaver wouldn't come to check on her , and she never gave her a ride to school after a fight. She knew she wouldn't be missed.

[..]

Catra walked for a while, not heading in any real direction. She knew she would end up at the Greyskulls by the end of the night, but walking really cleared her head. She could feel her cheek now as it pulsed with pain. Weaver had hit her before but she couldn't remember the last time she hit her so hard.

Weaver loved control, and as Catra got older and harder to control, she often lashed out aggressively to assert her power over her. That's why she was certain Weaver would fail her in her class if she knew she was a lesbian. Weaver would try to ruin her life however

she could. Kicking her out wouldnt be enough, so she would try to take away her future.

She stopped at the park which was between her house and the Greyskulls. When they were younger the three of them used to come here and Catra would watch the twins practice.

She went to the swing set and sat down. She gently rocked back and forth, it was getting cooler overnight. Soon it would be her birthday and Halloween. The Greyskulls would probably throw her a party like they do every year. Maybe Mara would even come home for the weekend to celebrate with them. She could rely on The Greyskulls to be a constant like nothing else in her life. As long as she didnt screw it all up.

She felt a pinch of guilt at the thought of what would happen after Adam and her break up. She hoped they would forgive her for her actions. She couldnt bear to lose any of them. Her mind started to circle darkly and the cool air wasnt enough to stop the pain spreading from her cheek to her eye. She decided she couldnt wait any longer. She needed to ice it before it swelled and bruised so badly that she couldnt cover it with makeup.

She shouldered her bag and headed for home. Her real home.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading!

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

> Catra gets some much needed comfort after her stressful night and Adora makes a discovery.

Chapter Notes

> It's been a minute. I got distracted by cowboys, sorry~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was too distracted to study anymore after Catra left. She spent some time playing video games on the tv while Adam persisted with his homework. After dinner the twins helped clean up and then played football in the backyard with their dad.

Dean used to play football in university, but he had long committed himself to his job as an accountant. He unfortunately did not pass on his love of numbers to his blonde haired offspring. But he still had a great arm.

They played until the sun was completely gone and Dean went to the work shed. He was working on something for Catra for her birthday which the twins werent allowed to see.

They headed inside and Adora could hear soft voices in the kitchen when they came through the back door. Walking down the hall to the kitchen, Adora looked in and was surprised to see Catra sitting at the dinner table with a cold compress held to her eye. The soft

discussion between Linda and Catra stopped as the twins entered the room.

"Are you ok?" Adam asked and Catra shrugged with a lopsided smile. It was unconvincing, accompanied by her rattled expression. Adam sat at the table beside her and put his arm around her to hug her without forcing her to move.

"Yeah," Catra said softly as she leaned into Adams' embrace. Adora approached and took her free hand to give it a squeeze. Catra squeezed back. Linda was silently watching the exchange. When Adora looked at her mother's blue eyes she felt transparent. She wasn't sure what her mother could see, but her look was knowing.

Linda was looking at Catra and Adora's hands with a thoughtful expression that brought a flush to Adora's cheeks and she gently released Catra's hand. Catra allowed it and leaned into Adam as she put her head on his shoulder.

"Pumpkin, why don't you go tidy your room? Catra is going to stay for the night, if that's ok?" Linda said and Adora felt a strange flutter in her stomach as she nodded. She knew she had to keep her anger at Weaver inside. She didn't even know what she had done yet but she tried to stay calm. She focused on doing the next logical thing, something helpful.

"Of course," Adora said softly and glanced at Catra who smiled. "Come up when you're ready," Adora offered and Catra nodded.

Adora headed upstairs, where she had made a mess of her floor while looking for the perfect apology clothing that morning before school. Linda came to check on her after she was late for breakfast and saw the bombsite that was her room.

After Adora had rushed to explain to her mother why she was making a mess Linda had just smiled. She told Adora Catra wouldnt have cared what she wore but Catra accepted her apology so obviously she had picked her clothes correctly.

[..]

After some time icing her face Linda put the ice pack back in the freezer and gave Catra a tight hug.

"You can stay as long as you need, love" She said softly and Catra blushed softly at the affection as she hugged Linda back. Adam smiled easily as he waited, holding Catra's bag to take it upstairs for her.

"Thank you," Catra said when Linda released her and she nodded. Dean came in the backdoor with what looked like black oil on his face and he smiled easily.

"You alright kiddo?" he asked kindly and Catra nodded with a tired smile.

"Yeah, Ill be ok," she said and he nodded and pet her on the head. Catra rolled her eyes at the overly dad-like behaviour and followed Adam upstairs.

Adora's door was open as she put the last of her clothes back on the hangers and turned to the couple. Adam put her bag down by the door and hugged Catra tightly. Catra hugged him back for a moment and once everyone exchanged goodnights he pulled the door closed behind him.

Adora looked a little fidgety as she straightened the top on the coat hanger she was holding before she put it in her closet. She turned to Catra.

"Did you bring something to wear or do you want to borrow something?" Adora asked and Catra glanced down at her bag where she knew her pyjamas were and shrugged.

"Just clothes for tomorrow , can I borrow something?" Catra asked curiously and Adora smiled as she turned to her dresser to pull something out for her. Catra walked closer, sitting on the bed as she waited. Adora handed her one of her old jerseys and a pair of shorts which will likely be too big before she sits down beside her.

"How are you feeling?" Adora asked. Catra didnt expect Adora's soft fingertips on her cheek and she jumped a little before she recovered and leaned into the affection.

"I'm ok, the pain isn't so bad now ," Catra said looking up, realising Adora was much closer than she thought as she cupped her cheek. She looked at Catra with such undivided attention that Catra had to fight down a blush that threatened to colour her cheeks. Adora didn't seem to notice the proximity was affecting Catra as she gently stroked Catra's cheek with her thumb.

"I'm sorry that happened," Adora said, her voice a soft whisper . Catra leaned into her hand to stop herself leaning closer to the blonde. She needed to get a grip but truth be told, after a night like this, she really needed this kind of care.

"I hate her ," Catra said and Adora smiled a little.

"I hate her too, you should just stay with us," Adora said softly and Catra huffed.

"You'd get pretty sick of me stealing the blankets every night," Catra teased, trying to break the tension that was growing in the room. Adora huffed a laugh.

"I wouldn't mind, as long as you were safe," Adora said and she looked so earnest. Catra needed to get away from her before she kissed the dummy.

"Thanks, but you know I never run from a fight," Catra teased and this time Adora snorted, finally putting some distance between them as she released Catra's cheek.

"I know , you're too stubborn," Adora said easily and Catra smiled, both relieved and disappointed by the distance between them.

"Like you're one to talk," Catra said, standing up and shaking the clothing. "I'm going to go change," she said and Adora nodded, moving to get into bed. Already in her exercise shorts and baggy shirt.

Catra slipped out of the room down the hall to the bathroom. She locked herself inside and looked at herself in the mirror. The dark marks around her eye were blooming but the ice pack helped with the swelling at least. She could cover it with makeup and pretend Weaver hadnt struck her .

She gripped the edge of the sink as she looked into her duel toned eyes. She took a deep shaky breath, trying to calm herself. This wasnt the first time W eaver had hurt her, and it probably wouldnt be the last. Weaver's words still echoed in her mind.

Her hands shook and she gripped harder on the porcelain. She took another shaky breath and shook her head. Shaking Weaver out of her mind, she turned to the clothing she was provided. Undressing qickly to put Adora' s soft clothing on her body was like a comforting warm hug. Adora's clothing was big on her, meant for a larger

woman than Catra, but she loved how they enveloped her. Catra collected her clothing and with one last glance at herself in the mirror she headed back to Adora. Catra entered the room and Adora looked up from her phone. Adora looked Catra up and down slowly. Catra flushed at the appraisal before Adora opened her dumb mouth.

"You're so short," She commented casually and Catra huffed, insulted.

"Excuse me for not being a giant football idiot like you two," Catra said, rolling her eyes and putting her clothing on her bag before she headed over to the bed. Adora snorted.

"Maybe you are just unusually little," Adora prodded as Catra pulled back the blankets to climb in beside her. She grabbed the pillow as she got into bed and smacked Adora with it. Adora made a sound of surprise before she laughed.

"You think you're so funny, don't you," Catra said, getting up on her knees to hit Adora again. She doesn't get that far when Adora yanks the pillow away from Catra and puts it under her head.

"You've lost pillow privileges," Adora said with a laugh and a cocky smile. Catra huffed as her weapon was taken from her.

"Fine, Ill just use you as my pillow ,"She turned around and flopped back onto Adora's stomach. The blonde let out a soft grunt at the impact but Adora's stomach was anything but soft. "You're a terrible pillow,"Catra said, making a show of rolling around to get comfortable, ending face down on Adora's abs. Adora was laughing but made an indigent sound at being told she was bad at something.

"I'm sure there are softer places to sleep,"Adora said with a laugh.

"Well I doubt you would let me sleep on your tits,"Catra said into Adora's stomach and blushed as she realised what she had said. She lifted her head slightly to look at Adora and could only just see Adora's blushing face over said pillows. "Sorry ,"Catra said, cringing at the awkwardness she had created.

"It's ok,"Adora said with a shrug, not making it clear if she was talking about the awkwardness or if it's ok to sleep on her. Catra shook her head and accepted the pillow Adora returned to her. Catra bit her lip before she smacked Adora with the pillow again. She squealed as Adora tackled her to the bed to wrestle over the pillow .

"That' s it, you're cut of f"Adora said pulling the pillow as Catra laughed and fought to keep a hold of it. Adora loomed over her as Catra kicked the blankets to free her legs. She managed to get her foot on Adora's chest and use that leverage to push Adora off. Adora snorted. "You dirty cheater,"Adora laughed and Catra grinned at her . Adora released the pillow when she was shoved backwards, losing her balance on the bed and hitting her head on the wall.

"Ouch," Adora muttered softly as Catra jumped up to crawl over to Adora. She abandoned the pillow to pull Adora away from the wall to check her head.

"Are you ok? You don't have brain damage do you?" Catra said, cradling her head as she checked her over. Adora snorted.

"You're not that strong," Adora teased.

"Excuse you! If I'm not that strong, how did you fall?" Catra asked, releasing Adora's head to look down at her. Adora tipped her head back to grin up at Catra.

"I tripped," Adora said softly with a cocky smile. Catra huffed and crossed her arms.

"Yeah right, a pro being this clumsy? Unlikely" Catra said and Adora laughed.

Catra slowly started to realise she was still looking down at Adora and they were quite close. Catra blushed deeply as she realised she had crawled into Adora's lap. She jumped back suddenly, almost falling off the bed herself. Adora reached out to steady her but Catra managed to catch herself.

They just looked at each other with wide eyes for a moment before Adora snorted and they both laughed.

After they settled down from their laughing fit they got the blankets back in order and climbed in together. Adora laid on her side and opened her arms to Catra who scooted into her hold happily. Adora tucked her under her chin and in the darkness of the night Catra whispered to Adora what Weaver had done. Adora listened silently as she stroked her back. Once all was said, Adora whispered assurances that Catra didn't deserve it and Catra held back tears. She really wanted to believe that.

[..]

"Guess who' s in the paper?" Glimmer sing-songed as she sat down at the table in the cafeteria. Now that Catra and Adora had made up, they had returned to their usual table with their friends.

"I dont care," Adora said with a shrug, glancing over as Catra climbed onto the bench between her and Adam. She scooted down to make room for Catra, bumping Mermista in the process.

"Do you know you can sit more than a few feet away from your boyfriend sometimes?" Mermista asked Catra over Adora and Catra stuck her tongue out at her without comment.

"Not even when it' s you?" Glimmer asked with a laugh as Adora looked surprised.

"From the game?" she asked, wondering why that would make it to the gossip paper.

"Not the game, want to know now?" Glimmer asked playfully as she waved the paper. Catra stood up suddenly and snatched the paper from Glimmer, getting an indignant huff.

"It's impolite to snatch," Glimmer said, frowning at Catra.

"It's impolite to tease people," Catra returned, opening the paper and looking at the picture.

"Coming from you?" Glimmer teased back. Adora waited for Catra' s commentary on the picture but she was silent as she handed the paper to Adora. "Since when do you care about the gossip paper?" Glimmer asked, prodding Catra.

"I dont care, I just want you to stop singing," Catra teased back and Glimmer squawks.

"I'm a good singer! You've been to my performances!" Glimmer looked legitimately concerned about her voice and Catra quickly

changed her tune.

"Yeah, but cafeteria acoustics aren't doing you any favours, Sparkles" Catra said and Glimmer looked relieved. Adora was so caught up in watching this exchange she forgot that she was meant to be looking at a picture. She looked down at the paper and the big picture, front and centre, was Catra wrapped up in Adora's arms on the bleachers. The title above it read "Cheer Captain Supporting the Team." Adora blushed but skimmed the article. The article claimed the team had a challenging year ahead of them, especially with the lineup this year putting them against the Horde early on in the season. The article was pretty tame but it did make it seem like the football team was cracking under the pressure instead of Catra and Adora having a private apology hug.

Adora huffed, her embarrassment turning to anger as she finished reading.

"This is bullshit," Adora said loudly , interrupting whatever conversation continued without her. Catra looked apologetic but didn't say anything as she pet her arm.

"Just ignore it Dor , they're going to write what they want and it doesn't matter ," Adam said over the top of Catra, putting his arm on Catra's shoulder so he wouldn't elbow her.

"They are making the whole team seem like they are falling apart just because Catra and I had a disagreement," Adora huf fed. Trying to

calm her temper. She wished she knew who wrote this dribble but it was anonymous, which was half the problem. It couldnt be corrected once it was printed.

"I didnt think it was a big deal, sorry ,"Glimmer said looking regretful that she brought this up.

"No, thank you for showing me,"Adora said, getting to her feet and abandoning her lunch. "I'm going to take a walk,"She said, grabbing her tray and passing the paper back to Glimmer.

"Do you want company?"Catra of fered and Adora shook her head.

"No, that's ok,"Adora didnt really want to cause more problems for Catra by being caught being comforted by her again at school.

Adora ditched her food in the bin and headed into the hall. She wasnt walking in any real direction but she found herself in front of the gymnasium. She headed inside, maybe doing some weights would expend this energy .

Opening the door she heard the sound of impact and followed it to the mats. She saw Teela before Teela saw her and stopped to admire her form. She was small and strong, with defined shoulders and core muscles. She was cute, but Adora watched with appreciation, not romantic interest. She worked hard for her form and it showed. Adora can respect that.

Teela moved around the punching bag to adjust her position and noticed Adora. She jumped slightly before she took out one of her earbuds.

"Hey ," Teela said, sounding a little breathless. She was wearing a crop top and leggings to workout in and looked like she had been at it for most of lunch.

"Hey , want to spar?" Adora asked without thinking and Teela laughed.

"You cant spar in jeans Adora," Teela said but she turned to face regardless.

"Afraid youll lose?" Adora challenged and Teela let out a single barked laugh.

"You wish," she said back, and Adora grinned, hoping this would help her blow off some steam. Teela went to her bag to get another pair of gloves and handed them to Adora.

"Dont hurt yourself," Teela warned and Adora nodded.

"I'll do my best, I don't need another head injury today ," Adora mentioned as she took her jacket off and put the gloves on. Teela looked at her curiously.

"Another one? What did you do, Grayskull?" she asked in a teasing tone.

"Catra kicked me into my bedroom wall last night," Adora said, touching the back of her head where it was still a little sore. Teela was suddenly red as her eyes widened. Clearly concerned. "She didn't mean to, we were fighting over a pillow and I lost balance on the bed," Adora explained to reassure her . Teela looked redder and looked away.

"Uh, you two are really close," T eela said awkwardly and Adora nodded, adjusting the strap on her glove.

"Y ep, since we were kids, all three of us are close though," Adora said with a shrug as she lifted her gloves. Teela still looked off in the distance and Adora frowned when she didn't get into position. "Y ou ok?" she asked in concern.

"Uh, yeah, sorry , let's spar," T eela said, shaking her head and joining Adora on the mat with her gloves up. This was exactly what she needed to forget about that stupid paper.

[..]

Practice was easy, no injuries and everyone managed to get through the routine without mistakes. Catra was excited to get back to the Grayskull's because the twin's parents were going to be out on a date night so dinner was takeout and they could play as much Mario Kart as they wanted.

Catra wasn't looking forward to seeing Weaver when she went back to her house but Linda made sure she knew she could stay over again if she needed to. Unfortunately, Catra only packed one outfit so she needed to go home for clothes at least. If things were fine there she would just stay the night and if Weaver was on a rampage she could go back to her real home.

Walking into the house without the smell of dinner was such a rare occurrence but it didn't stop the three friends from looking at each other like mischievous children. They were excited to have a night to just relax and order pizza.

The twins ended up on either side of the couch with Catra spread out between them. Her head on Adora's thigh and her feet in Adam's lap. It was a common position for the three of them to relax when watching movies. Catra as the smallest had to take up the most space possible.

"How are you still winning while lying down?" Adam said in frustration and Catra cackled.

"Pure skill my friend," She teased back and Adora's thigh jostled her head as she went around a bend and fell off.

"That's cheating!" Catra whined as she forced herself to sit up and elbow Adora in retaliation. Adora laughed and fell off the map moments later as she tried to fight back. Adam ended up winning as they tousled and laughed at them while they tried to make each other come last.

[..]

When Catra got home she couldn't hear a peep from Weaver so she went straight to her room. She packed an overnight bag just in case but decided to stay in her room. Weaver was unusually quiet that night.

[..]

Glimmer sat down heavily on the bench across from Adora and Catra raised her eyes from her debate club notes to look at Glimmer. Glimmer looked at Adora as she clutched the gossip paper to her chest. Catra looked at Adora to see her glaring at Glimmer.

"What?" Adora asked, sounding annoyed.

"Did anything happen at training?" Catra asked Adora curiously , she hadn't noticed anything from their side of the field but maybe she had missed it. That was the only reason she could gather why Adora would be in the gossip paper *again* .

"No, nothing happened yesterday ," Adora said, sitting back and putting her hand out to take the paper. She looked down at the picture and her eyes went wide as her eyebrows rose. "What the"… Adora whispered.

"What is it?" Catra asked, pushing up against Adora' s side to pull the paper towards her. The picture on the page was of Adora and Teela sparing. Adora wearing her clothes from yesterday, her shirt tucked up out of the way, shoes off. Both women were glistening from sweat and Adora looked *amazing* . Catra's mouth ran dry, her eyes wide as she took in the image. She needs a copy.

"No one was there with us though" Adora said, sounding confused as she let Catra take the paper off her to read the article. Catra scanned the article and it was a bunch of dribble about the boxing club and its growing popularity. It wasn't anything about Adora, except the headline read "A new challenger has entered the ring" like it was a scandal article. Catra bit her lip, vaguely aware that Glimmer and Adora continued to talk while she looked at the image.

Adora had wanted to be left alone yesterday and Catra gave her space. Catra didn't like that she was willing to spend time with Teela though. The thought of Adora going to someone else for comfort made a burning feeling grow in her stomach. She knew this feeling and she knew she was jealous.

The paper was suddenly plucked from her hands and her head snapped up.

"Hey! I was reading that," Catra said, trying not to blush. She may have zoned out while looking at the photo. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"The article is not that long Catra," Glimmer teased and Catra couldn't help but blush. She glanced at Adora who was looking down at her with a little smile. It wasn't her cocky smile, so she clearly didn't think Catra was looking at *her*.

"I read it twice," she lied easily "I don't see how that photo has anything to do with the article" Catra crossed her arms defensively .

"It's relevant because our star quarterback is hot and sweaty in the photo. It sells papers, it's called marketing,"

"It's called lying, it has nothing to do with Adora besides her being in the club," Catra huffed and Glimmer laughed.

"The media lies all the time, it's what they do, they use her photo because people love Adora, and Teela is new and interesting. So suggesting something scandalous will get people talking," Glimmer said.

"W-what do you mean?" Adora asked with a frown. Glimmer leaned over the table to pet her hand.

"Hunny , they were trying to suggest that you and Teela are an item," Glimmer explained to her carefully .

"What! But we aren't" Adora said, maybe too loudly . Catra put her hand on her leg and shushed her softly. It did not make Adora any less flustered as she jumped from the contact. Catra removed her hand like she had been burned, unsure how to take that reaction. She bit her lip.

"Sorry , just maybe keep it down, you don't want people to talk more," Catra said softly and Adora nodded her head.

"Yeah, sorry, thanks" She rambled softly and Catra smiled a little. Catra felt Adora's hand brush her thigh softly like an apology and it made her heart pound in her chest. Maybe thigh touching was pushing the boundary a bit. Catra laced their fingers together and squeezed reassuringly before she released it.

"People are just going to talk, you haven't had a girlfriend in high school, so they are going to speculate about that,"

"I don't have time to date, it's too much commitment on top of school and football," Adora grumbled as she crossed her arms.

"I know that, you already do a lot, but most people don't see that and they want to see something juicy," Glimmer said holding the paper against her chest as she sighed dreamily.

"Besides, no one meets their soulmate in high school," Adora said, parroting Catra's statement. Catra looked at her with surprise and Adora glanced at her sheepishly. Catra felt her stomach drop, she's always said that but she didn't want Adora to *believe* her. She wanted Adora to *choose* her.

Adam decided this was the perfect moment to plop down beside Catra on the bench and wrap his arm around her shoulder in a half hug.

"Hey, what are we talking about?" Adam asked curiously and Glimmer turned her attention to him, offering him the paper.

"Adora's love life," Glimmer said simply as Adam looked at the image. Catra was close enough to him to hear his gulp as he looked at Teela. She cut him a glare which made him blush softly.

"This is about the boxing club. What does it have to do with Adora's love life?" Adam asked, dragging his eyes away from the image to hand the paper back to Glimmer. Catra wondered for a moment if she should get a paper and give Adam the other half of the image,

that is what a supportive bestie would do. Her not wanting the picture of Teela anywhere near Adora's picture had nothing to do with it.

"Exactly!" Adora said, pointing to her brother and Catra rolled her eyes.

"Wh- ugh, you two-!" Glimmer stumbled in disbelief.

"You are both unaware idiots," Catra concluded affectionately, and both blondes just grinned at her.

[..]

"I joined the music club" Adam blurted out suddenly as they met up after school. Usually Thursday's they went straight home because they didn't have any clubs. Adora blinked at Adam curiously.

"Oh, that's cool, we can wait for you," Adora offered, a little surprised that Adam hadn't mentioned it. Catra was watching him suspiciously.

"Why?" Catra asked and Adam blushed and cleared his throat.

"I just really want to get into playing the guitar again," Adam said, trying to sound casual but sounding caught. Catra turned her critical gaze on Adora and she looked down at her, feeling like she was also in trouble suddenly.

"What instrument does Teela play?" Catra asked and Adora paused to think about it.

"Uh, I think the violin," Adora said awkwardly and Catra turned back to Adam, leaving Adora to relax

"And you just suddenly wanted to join the music club? After three years of not playing guitar?" Catra asked and Adam nodded.

"Uh, yes?" he said like he was asking a question. Catra sighed loudly and closed her eyes for a moment.

"Ok, fine, do you want us to wait for you?"

"Uhno, that' s ok, Teela offered to drive me home." Adam said, looking red again. Adora had no idea how to read what was going on, so she settled on being confused.

"Ok, fine, but we need to talk about this," Catra said firmly and Adam gulped before he nodded.

"Sure, Ill be home before dinner ," Adam placated and Catra nodded.

"Ok, let's go," Catra said, heading for the door . Adora looked between Adam and Catra before fist bumping her twin and following the brunette. Had Adora just witnessed a fight? She didnt know what else to call the tension between them.

They got to the carpark before Catra swore under her breath and stopped.

"Sorry , I forgot something in my locker, Ill meet you at the car ," Catra said quickly , before Adora could say anything she sprinted back into the school building. Adora shrugged and headed to the car. It was about 10 minutes before Catra came back, putting something into her bag and closing it quickly . She got into the front seat and looked at Adora.

Adora looked back at her, she didnt seem annoyed anymore at least, but she did look pink under Adora's scrutinising gaze.

"Let's go?" Catra said, clutching her bag a little tighter . Adora nodded her head as she glanced at her bag curiously. She wondered what Catra forgot which was making her act protective of her bag.

"Yeah," Adora turned back to the steering wheel and pulled the car out of the parking lot to head home.

It was a rare occasion that Adam didn't come home with them so instead of studying Catra and Adora sat on the floor in her bedroom.

Catra insisted on doing some 'girly stuff' that Adora liked to try out every once in a while. Catra painted her nails for her, which Adora enjoyed the process of watching Catra work but immediately decided she didn't like how it looked and Catra took them off again. She painted her own nails black and Adora admired how it looked so much nicer on her petite hands.

Next Catra curled Adora's hair, her blonde hair was so straight and she always admired Catra's hair so she wanted to try it. Catra spent a good 20 minutes making tight ringlets and teasing it into a nice style before Adora looked at herself in the mirror and scrunched up her nose.

"Let me guess, you don't like it?" Catra asked, leaning on her shoulder playfully. Adora shook her head, the curls bouncing in a fun way, but she hated how it made her look so different. She felt it would look nice, if it was on someone else. "I can straighten it for you or you can take a shower, the curls won't survive that," Catra said softly by her ear and it made Adora shiver.

She couldn't understand why she liked all these things about Catra when she didn't like them on herself at all. Catra was petite and toned, little and cute. Adora was all height, broad shoulders and muscles. She felt a little like a bumbling giant next to her graceful friend sometimes. Adora liked the way she looked and her strong body made her feel proud, but she *really* liked how Catra looked.

Adora felt her face heating up a little as a thought occurred to her. Maybe she didn't like those things about Catra because she was envious of her friend. Maybe she just liked Catra.

Chapter End Notes

The chapter count may change again but we shall see how we go. I'm dead set on a fluffy epilogue and it might be chapter 11.

There's just so much emotion and stupidity to write about. I made this high school drama so complex~

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

> Adora works through some thoughts. Catra has a belated freak out and the twins get up to no good.

Chapter Notes

> I think I've said this every chapter but this ran long and I had to cut stuff out. I am going to cut down a few events from the major plot to keep it in the chapter count. I hope you enjoy the drama ~
>
> EDIT: I added the scenes I cut. I will be ignoring the word count but will try to keep to the chapter count. This chapter got two new scenes added.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Glimmer hummed to herself as Adora approached her locker. Glimmer jumped when she closed her locker door to see the panicked blonde standing there.

"Glimmer , you have to help me," Adora said, her voice a panicked whisper. Glimmer looked concerned and adjusted her books in her arms to free her hand. She put a comforting hand on Adora as high up as she could reach, which was not that high.

"Adora, dont get yourself in a state. Whatever it is, well fix it," Glimmer said and Bow came down from his locker to stand beside Adora.

"Y eah, we've got you buddy , what is it?" He asked curiously and Adora took a calming breath. She leaned closer to the two, so no one could overhear them.

I like Catra," Adora whispered and after a moment Glimmer laughed loudly. Adora looked at her in shock as she recoiled. This was not the reaction she was expecting. Glimmer held her stomach as she bent over and Bow smiled apologetically at Adora. Adora just stared in confusion as she waited for Glimmer to stop.

"Why are you laughing, this is serious!" Adora hissed out and Glimmer stood up as her laughter turned into giggles.

"Adora, you really had me going, you're so funny ," Glimmer said as she finally fell silent. The look of confusion from Adora and the serious 'we support our friends epiphanies' look from Bow made Glimmer frown. "Wait, are you serious?" Glimmer asked in shock and Adora blushed.

"Of course I'm serious," she hissed back "Can you keep your voice down," Adora asked, glancing around. Glimmer now looked at Adora with astonishment.

"Oh my gawd Adora, did you only just figure that out?" Glimmer whispered back harshly and Bow shushed her gently.

"It' s great you've had this realisation, Adora, it must have been difficult to process," Bow of fered a much more reasonable reaction, but Adora focused on Glimmer's rude response.

"What do you mean "only just figured that out"? It happened last night, it's not like I waited to tell you!" Adora whispered back. She tried and failed to keep her voice down. People in the hall started to notice the whispered argument.

"Uh, maybe we should talk about this at lunch" Bow said, noticing the people watching. Adora went on to react to that ridiculous idea but noticed people watching and biting her tongue.

"But" Adora said, blushing, "I have another class with Catra"… Adora said, soft and whiney. Bow put his hand on her shoulder.

"Just act like normal around her , well work it out at lunch. You got this. Game face!" He said, giving her shoulder a squeeze. Adora nodded but pouted. It wasn't long before the bell rang and they had to rush to their classes.

[..]

Catra was leaning on her hand as she watched the teacher talk about their upcoming art project. Adora and Catra shared a twin desk all year in this class which made passing notes easier. But it also meant when they fought, art class became very awkward.

Adora was acting strange today, she was fidgeting in her chair more than usual and her shuffling was distracting Catra. After the third or fourth time she moved in her seat in 5 minutes Catra pulled her notebook towards her and scribbled a quick 'are you ok?' before she pushed it closer to Adora. Catra glanced at Adora's face and she looked a little red. She nodded her head at Catra and took her pen.

'Cramps,' Adora wrote back, her writing was heavy handed, leaving slight dents in the paper, but it was neat and precise. Catra admired that, her own loopy script was out of convenience, and never having time to lift her pen. Catra took the pen back from Adora, her fingers brushing Adora's hand and causing Adora to draw a sharp breath. Catra glanced at her again, and she mouthed a 'sorry' in case she scratched her. But Adora wasn't looking at her anymore, just staring at the desk with her fists in her lap.

Catra scribbled a quick 'pain killers?' on the paper and tried to get Adora to look at it. But she was very focused on burning a hole in the table. Catra huffed and tried to get Adora's attention by touching her thigh under the table. She didn't expect Adora to jolt from the touch and a loud bang sounded as Adora hit the desk with her knee. Catra flinched and looked at the teacher who was now watching them. Mrs Ella looked between the two of them.

"Everything ok?" She asked kindly but she looked a little put out to be interrupted.

"Sorry , my bad," Adora said quickly and the teacher nodded before she went back to her explanation. Catra looked at Adora, feeling embarrassed for both of them. Adora didn't make eye contact but wrote in her notebook 'I'm ok' and Catra just had to believe her . They could talk properly at lunch.

Catra tried to focus on the class, they had a new project to draw their project buddies and Catra was embarrassed to think how refined her end project would be with how often she already drew Adora. She hoped Adora wouldn't be able to tell.

Once class finished Adora grabbed her stuff and disappeared out the door before Catra finished packing her bag. Once Catra made it to the hallway, Adora was walking in the wrong direction for the cafeteria with Bow and Glimmer.

She sighed, usually when they were fighting Catra knew what she did wrong because they would explode. But she had no idea what happened this time. They had a nice night last night and Catra pampered Adora. Did she touch Adora too much? Maybe she treated her as special as she deserved. Does Adora know her feelings for her? Was she too obvious? Did she need to talk to Glimmer and Bow to find a way to let her down easily? Panicked dread settled into her stomach as she watched Adora walk away and a growing feeling of vulnerability laid claim to her chest. Watching her walk away felt like ice in her bones. She wanted to follow her and get answers.

She almost screamed when Adam put his arm around her shoulder but she did jump noticeably .

"Wow, you ok?" Adam asked softly as he pressed a kiss to her cheek to hide it. Catra's eyes were wide when she looked up at him, the panic clear on her face to anyone who knew her well enough.

"What's wrong Cat?" He asked keeping his voice down to keep their discussion as private as possible. Catra's breath was speeding up and the look of realisation bloomed on Adam's face. He knew

Catra's panic attacks very well from their years of friendship, but it had been a very long time since she had one at school. "Shit...come on," he said, pulling her along as he managed to somehow shield Catra from prying eyes and make it look as casual as possible. No one seemed to notice. He pulled her into an empty club room and sat her at one of the desks as her breaths became short and sharp, her chest contracting as she tried to control herself. The self deprecating words filled her mind, telling her she was weak and pathetic. They sounded like Weaver.

"Deep breaths Kitty-Cat," Adam said gently as he crouched beside her and rubbed her arms, breathing slowly with her as he held her gaze. His voice was a deep timber of reassurance, cutting through the shrill words in her mind. It took some time but Catra's breathing finally settled and she let out a large shaky breath. Adam smiled at her reassuringly and Catra gave a weak smile in return.

"Ok," He said as he stood and wrapped her in a hug. Catra melted into a safe, comfortable embrace, letting herself be cared for. He rubbed her back until Catra let out a sniffle and pulled out of his hold.

"Adora," Catra choked on the name a little as she wiped the tears off her cheeks. Her mascara would be ruined but she could deal with that later. Adam frowned slightly but nodded.

"Did you two fight again?" he asked curiously, but not judging. Catra's friendship with Adora had always been passionate. They bounced off each other like a livewire, challenging and competitive, but always coming back together in the end. Catra sniffled again and let out a loud sigh.

"I don't know, I thought we had fun last night and then she was weird when we were studying after you got home and she was weird today in class." Catra said, picking at her jeans as she looked into her lap. She was embarrassed by her reaction.

"But nothing happened? No explosion?" Adam asked, seeming as confused as Catra was. Catra shook her head.

"No, nothing, she just." Catra frowned "She went off with Bow and Glimmer, I dont think they are coming to lunch,"

"Do you want to go to lunch?" Adam asked, looking Catra in the eyes. She looked so sad but she'd had a hell of a week. Even to herself it seemed like a big reaction to Adora acting a little off but really it was a boiling pot of emotions that she just didnt let out. She tried to deal with her feelings about her mother but really she just cried and let Adora hold her. As nice as it was, she probably needed to do more.

"Maybe I should see the school counsellor." Catra said softly and Adam nodded.

"Cant hurt. You might just need to let it all out," Adam said, taking her hand and squeezing. Catra nodded looking resolute but then sighed.

"I can't, I can't talk about Weaver, it might get back to her. I dont need more problems," Catra said, she felt helpless under that roof.

"Cat, you know you can stay with us if Weaver kicks you out, I've told you a million times. If you talk to the counsellor, maybe the school can stop Weaver failing you for no reason," Adam said, his voice pleading, he hated to see Catra hurting. But Catra was stubborn and she wanted to deal with her own issues without bringing others into it. It wasnt long now.

"Maybe you're right." Catra said softly and squeezed Adam's hand. "I'll think about it," she promised and she almost meant it. Adam didnt look convinced but he nodded. He let go of her hand and stood.

"Stay here, Ill get us some lunch. You need the quiet," Adam said smiling and Catra smiled up at him with a nod.

"Thanks Adam, you're the best," she said softly and meant that. He was the best guy she knew. He was going to make the right girl so happy one day. He grinned like a dork and headed out. He closed the door behind him and Catra let out a long sigh before she picked up her bag to look for her mirror. Her makeup was a mess but it didn't take long to get it looking artfully smudged rather than crying over nothing smudged.

It didn't feel like any time at all before the door opened again and she laughed.

"That was quick," Catra said, snapping her mirror closed and looking at the door to see distinctly not Adam. The person before her was slender and tall, with long platinum blonde hair and claw like nails. They had on perfect makeup and wore boyfriend jeans with a wrapped strappy black top. She had never interacted with this person before, but she knew she had seen them around. They were a sophomore, and she thought maybe their name was Dee.

"Oh, excuse me, I thought this was empty," They said as they fanned their faces with a paper they had in their hand. A laptop sat on their other hip casually. Dee looked at Catra like they were analysing her, pausing on her face.

"Yeah, I can leave though, if you need it," Catra offered, not wanting to make it seem like a big deal that she was in here. Dee's smile was sharp and calculating.

"That's the best part about laptops darling, they are portable, I can go elsewhere," they said airily as they glanced down the hall as Adam became visible, holding two lunch trays carefully. "Oh, a romantic lunch for two, I won't get in your way," they said, winking at Catra who blushed. They opened the door wider to let Adam through who thanked them and without another word Dee was gone.

"Who was that?" Adam asked, putting her food before her.

"I think their name is Dee," Catra said, shrugging her shoulders. She noticed Adam had the gossip paper on his tray and she frowned. "Why do you have that dribble?" Catra asked suspiciously .

"Oh, uh, just curiosity ," he said with a shrug. The paper really came out of nowhere last year, the anonymity of it causing nothing but trouble for anyone who ended up in it. Maybe Adora didn't like that she was the focus of that paper right now. Maybe her weird mood had nothing to do with Catra after all.

"Speaking of the paper ," Catra said seriously , and Adam looked at her like he was in trouble. Which he was.

"Music class, what's the deal. Really?" Catra asked firmly , and Adam put food in his mouth as an excuse to not speak. Catra was patient, waiting for his reply while she peeled her orange.

"I just want to try something new , you have debate class and Adora has boxing, I just want to find something I like to do too," he said and Catra nodded, it sounded reasonable.

"And it has nothing to do with Teela?" Catra asked softly as Adam blushed as he tried not to cough up his food.

"Oh, uh, just a happy coincidence," Adam said, shaking his head slightly.

"Right...and you don't like her...right?" Catra asked, she needed to know if Adam had feelings for someone. She wasn't about to stand in the way of his happiness. Adam blushed darker.

"No, I mean, I like her , a lot, she's really cool, but like...not like that," Adam said awkwardly and Catra nodded. "I mean, it would be cool to take someone to the Spring Formal, since it's senior year," Adam said and Catra nodded. She had thought about that too, it would be late enough in the year that Weaver would have very little influence over her grades and maybe Catra could be reassigned to a new

class after her birthday. Weaver couldn't be mad at her if she got dumped.

"Yeah, that makes sense, we can make sure we break up before the dance, you deserve the real experience," Catra said and Adam looked at her with considerate eyes.

"So do you Cat, would you ask anyone?" He asked and Catra snorted.

"No, she'll go with me as a friend, just like every year," Catra said, crossing her arms defensively and Adam sighed dramatically.

"You two are unbelievable," Adam said with an affectionate smile. Catra pointed an orange segment at him.

"Don't start, Adora doesn't like me like that," Catra said firmly, she had never been more certain of anything in her life.

[...]

Adora paced back and forth across the centre of the oval. Bow and Glimmer watched her move in front of them.

"Adora, you need to relax," Glimmer said, picking grass with her fingertips. They hadn't even gone to get their lunches yet when Adora had essentially kidnapped them to talk about this epiphany.

"I can't relax, I like Catra. Like, I really like Catra," Adora said, her harsh whisper sounding like the end of the world.

"What made you realise this?" Bow asked in a calm tone. He was giving her his undivided attention. Adora stopped and faced him as she considered the question.

"Last night Catra was doing my hair and painting my nails," Adora said and Glimmer looked at her hair and nails with confusion. "She undid it all, I didn't like how it looked. But I really like how it looks on Catra a lot," Adora said, biting her lip as she turned pink.

"We get it, Catra's hot. Why did that make you realise you like her?" Glimmer said, rolling her eyes as Adora blushed harder.

"Well I realised I didn't just like those things about Catra, but liked Catra herself," Adora said and Glimmer snorted. Bow put his hand on Glimmer's shoulder to quiet her.

"So you realised you admired her for those things and those feelings were always there?" Bow asked and Adora looked at him with wide eyes. This felt like an accusation but he was kind of right. She always admired Catra. She liked to look at her when she wore something cute, or when she did something different with her hair. She watched her scrunch her nose when she concentrated or bit her pen when she was frustrated. She knew all these little movements Catra made because she saw them, and she liked them.

"Oh my god." Adora said softly, "I've always liked Catra," Adora said softly, unable to believe it. Glimmer threw herself back onto the grass dramatically.

"Oh my god she finally sees it!" Glimmer said loudly and Adora shushed her as she looked around. They were alone but she didn't need this getting into the paper.

"No, this is a good thing," Bow said supportively as Adora groaned in despair. "If you have always felt like this you can just act like you usually do around her right?" Bow offered and Adora frowned. He was right. These feelings were always there and she always acted like this towards Catra. So she could just keep doing what she was doing and it wouldn't make a difference.

"Yeah," Adora said softly, letting out a breath, she could just keep following Catra's lead. She would stop her if she overstepped and Adora took comfort in that knowledge.

"You're right, I should just act like I normally do,"

"Yeah, a complete lovesick puppy! If you keep acting like that towards her, you are going to get hurt," Glimmer said, sitting up to meet Adora's eye. Bow nodded.

"I'm not a lovesick puppy!" Adora objected with a huff as her face went red.

"Yes you are, you both follow Catra around like puppies, before her and Adam started dating half the school thought you and Catra were together!" Glimmer said firmly and Adora's eyes widened.

"W-what?" Adora stumbled looking at Bow, who started to nod.

"Well, yeah, you've always been close. People assume relationships like that and especially after you came out as gay,"

"How did I not hear about this?" Adora asked in shock as she ran her hand through her ponytail and messed it up.

"It was all through the papers, but you three never really paid attention to it," Glimmer said shrugging.

"Why didn't you guys tell me?" Adora asked with a huff.

"Well we thought you were just secretly dating, but after a while we thought it might be embarrassing to bring up" Bow said awkwardly "Especially with Mrs Weaver, having the opinions she has"

Adora crossed her arms and glared silently at the grass.

"You might need to make some distance between you and Catra if you want to get over your feelings for her," Bow said with a smile, trying to steer the conversation back on track.

"She'll know something is up if I disappear on her," Adora said defensively as she looked back at Bow.

"Yeah, you don't need to physically distance yourself necessarily, but emotionally distance, so you have that energy to put into a new

relationship,” Bow said carefully and Adora nodded.

“I’ll think about it, I don’t want her to feel like I’ve stopped caring,” Adora said with a little pout.

“Maybe you can talk to her about it, tell her how you feel and that you need to distance yourself to preserve your friendship?” Bow offered and Glimmer snorted softly.

“Or maybe she feels the same,” Glimmer of fered and Adora frowned.

“Glim, she's with Adam, she definitely doesn’t feel the same,” Adora said firmly, and Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“Sure she is. Can we go get lunch now?” Glimmer asked and Adora nodded.

“Ok, let's go,” Adora said softly as Bow and Glimmer got up. Bow put his hand on her shoulder.

“I’m always here if you need to talk, buddy ,” he said and Adora smiled at him, clasping his shoulder in return.

“Thanks,” she said, following the pair back inside.

[..]

Adora seemed back to normal as they warmed up for the game. The stands were already filling up, the roar of excitement spreading through them for the upcoming battle against the Horde. Catra wasn’t paying extra close attention to Adora. Not at all, she seemed ok though, maybe Catra was just being dramatic.

The cheerleaders went on before the game, doing their dance and exciting the crowd. Catra hated to admit she liked the attention, but her gaze often returned to the players waiting to come onto the field. Catra’s eyes landed on Adora, giving the cheerleaders her full attention. Sometimes Catra could convince herself that Adora was

watching her as her short skirt rode up her thighs and she shook her ass a little provocatively for the crowd. Adam certainly wasn't giving the cheer leaders the same attention Adora was giving, he was talking to the player beside him.

Once they finished their dance Catra headed for the sidelines. The squad passed the football players as they entered the field and Catra picked out her two favourite blondes from the lineup. She wanted to keep tradition and hip check them both for good luck. When Catra approached Adora she didn't seem to be paying attention until she suddenly goosed Catra in the side, causing her to squeal in surprise. Adora laughed at her expense and Catra moved on to find Adam. Adam saw her coming and smirked at her, putting his hands up to do the same so Catra gave him a wide birth with a waggle of her finger to scold him. Adam just laughed at her .

Catra sat with the squad to enjoy the game. Horde games were always hard, because the team was so stretched to try to combat the older school. Catra watched the two Greyskull's carefully because the Horde was known for shady behaviour.

Catra was preparing for their mid-game dance when a commotion broke out on the field. Catra looked up in time to see a Horde players helmet go flying and Adam fucking Greyskull clutching his hand. He looked both in pain and shocked.

"Did he just?" Catra asked and someone confirmed he had punched the player while they were wearing their helmet. Catra wanted to run onto the field to check on him but she could see the refs converging to discuss quickly . Before any resolution could be made, another flash of blonde arrived on the scene. Catra would have been relieved if Adora didn't speak what seemed like two words to her brother and turn around to deck the horde player who was now without his helmet. The player fell flat on his back and soon the field devolved into an all out brawl. Both the Wildcats and Horde players joined the fight to defend their team members. The ref's whistles squealed as the crowd went absolutely wild as the fight only escalated.

Catra was in shock as she looked at the other cheerleaders who had started cheering on the Wildcat players along with the crowd. Catra put her head in her hands, she was going to have words after this.

[..]

The game ended up being cancelled, they would reschedule it now that several members of both teams were injured. Adora was one of them with a pretty nasty black eye which she had a cold pack on and Adam escaped with a scratch on his cheek and a bandage.

Catra couldn't believe them, she could expect this from Adora, sometimes her temper got away from her but Adam would never usually throw a punch. Neither twin would tell Catra anything about what Griz or said. Catra knew Griz or from church, so surely it couldn't have been that bad, but neither of them would budge.

Catra wasn't about to let them get away with this behaviour , they had a plan to go to college together and Catra wasn't going alone just because they couldn't keep it together .

Adora and Adam were both standing by their parents' car. Linda and Dean had come to the game and the twins had already been chewed out by them for their behaviour. But Catra wasn't about to let that stop her.

"What the hell was that Adam, what were you thinking?" Catra asked and Adam had the good sense to look regretful at least.

"Why are you only mad at me? Adora did it too!" he defended as he shuffled his feet awkwardly.

"Adora does shit like this!" Catra hissed, and Adora made an offended hey' but said no more when Catra levelled her with a glare. Catra expected this from Adora, she had been in several fights already this year and she didn't back down from a challenge. She was the punch your feelings out twin and often used brute force to fix

her problems. Adam never got to the point of fighting. Ever. He was always the gentle, level headed one.

"Yeah, well maybe I just wanted to deck him," Adam said, crossing his arms. He winced slightly as his bandaged hand tucked into his arms. He had hurt his hand pretty badly punching a helmet, but nothing was broken. It was lucky.

"Why won't you tell me what he said? Then maybe I'd understand," Catra pushed again.

"Because it doesn't matter, I'll deal with the repercussions of my actions and I'd do it again," Adam said firmly. Catra sighed and threw up her hands.

"Fine, what about you?" Catra asked, looking at Adora who snorted.

"I'm not repeating what that dick said, and I'd happily punch him again," Adora said, crossing her arms. Her knuckles were slightly bloodied from her fight and unbandaged, Catra did not find that hot. Adora's eye was already turning purple but the ice pack she was given had helped with the swelling. Catra sighed loudly.

"Fine," Catra said, giving up and finally getting into the car. She was in the middle with the twins on either side while their parents drove them home. Once home, Linda gave another lecture to Adam and Adora about dealing with their emotions in a healthier way, after which Dean drove Catra home.

Catra didn't want to be in her own house but she was too stubborn to accept the help. She thanked Dean and wished him goodnight before she went into her house. She regretted returning home immediately when the living room light was on and Weaver was on the couch. She watched Catra over the brim of her wine glass.

Catra paused at the doorway knowing that Weaver was waiting for her. She obviously had something to say.

"You shouldn't dance like such a whore at the games, people will think you are easy," Weaver said, she had obviously been home for a while with how her voice slurred. Catra bit her tongue and nodded her head, hoping that was all Weaver wanted to say.

"You should invite your boyfriend to lunch tomorrow, I would like to meet him," Weaver said and drank more wine. Catra held back the dread, Weaver was a master at lying, would she be able to tell that they were faking it?

"You've already met him before, it's Adam Greyskull," Catra reminded her, and Weaver tsked as she frowned.

"Are you talking back to me girl?" Weaver asked as she got to her feet. Catra tried not to slink back away from her mother as she approached her.

"No ma'am," Catra said softly, and Weaver glared down at her.

"Tomorrow," Weaver said firmly.

"For lunch, yes ma'am," Catra finished when Weaver didn't and she seemed content as she returned to the couch.

"Good, now go to bed," Weaver said and even though it was only 8pm Catra made herself scarce. She went to shower quickly and went to her room.

Her heart was racing and she felt stupid for her reaction. Weaver always spoke to her like that. So why was she being such a baby about it right now? She just felt so wound up, so stressed about everything. She sat on the bed, towel drying her damp curls as she considered what to do with herself before bed.

She should try to relax somehow, otherwise it would take hours to fall asleep. She briefly considered sketching, but now that she had an art project that felt like schoolwork. She considered doing some

reading, but she would have to do it under her blankets so Weaver didn't yell at her for not going to bed when she said to.

Catra glanced at her light as she hung her towel up on the back of her desk chair once she had her hair dry enough. She should turn off the light, but what could she do in the dark? If she was in Adora's bed they would whisper about anything and everything. Adora would distract her from her stress and focus on what was important, namely the blonde in front of her.

She could call Adora, but she really should call Adam to warn him about tomorrow. She didn't want to right now , she was still a little annoyed with them both.

Catra's mind wandered to the younger blonde twin, who had apparently punched someone to defend Catra's honour. Or something. Adam had done it too, but the thought of Adora wanting to defend her made her heart flutter like a schoolgirl. She couldn't help how it made her feel warm.

Adora is going to have a real bad shiner for the next few days at least.

Catra hoped it would heal before her birthday next weekend. It came up so quickly and Catra felt unprepared. She had already settled on her costume with the twins and just needed to pick it up from the shop next Saturday . She had the invites printed, thanks to Glimmer using the yearbook printer, so she didn't have to pay for the invites. Linda and Dean would arrange the house and it was the first year they could have alcohol. Technically the twins were already 18 but Catra was the youngest so they didn't have alcohol at their birthday this year. Catra was finally going to be a legal adult with all the perks and responsibilities. Not that she hadn't drank at parties before, and she was sure the Greyskull's knew that. Their "we'll pick you up and not judge if you need help" rule was a life saver more than once.

Catra turned off her light and laid back on her bed. The party planning was making her more stressed so she went back to her

guilty pleasure, thinking about Adora. She felt creepy, Adora didnt even like her like that and Catra was still perving on her.

Catra couldnt deny how sexy Adora looked after the fight though. She had fire in her blue eyes and blood on her knuckles like some MMA fighter. It really got Catra's heart pumping. She felt a little bad for Adora having a black eye but Adora herself didnt seem to care at all. She had come to Catra's defence without a care in the world for her own well-being.

Catra groaned and buried her face in her pillow as she felt her face heating up. No one was around to witness her embarrassment. Adora should not look so good being a stupid delinquent but she just did.

At least Catra had found something to do in the dark to help her relax

[..]

Adam was not happy about the lunch invite but he dressed in his Sunday best and was ready to be every bit the doting boyfriend throughout lunch.

Adam was wearing a white shirt, buttoned all the way up. He was nervously fixing his collar when Catra opened the door . His blue eyes skirted down Catra's clothing as soon as she came into view. He looked even more nervous at the sight of Catra in her church clothes, a modest knee length cream skirt and high necked blouse.

"Oh, jeez," he whispered like he was going to war . Catra rolled her eyes and tried to smile reassuringly as she stepped closer to kiss him on the cheek. She knew Weaver was watching them.

"It'll be fine, dont panic," Catra whispered while she was close to him. He pulled at the collar of his shirt again and Catra pretended to adjust it so he had time to respond.

"T oo late," he said with a soft laugh. Catra rolled her eyes playfully .

"Just act like you normally do. T otally obsessed with me," Catra challenged and Adam finally cracked a playful smile.

"I think you mean Ado-"

"Adam," W eaver appeared in the door with a scowl on her face. "Surely you are aware how doors work, come inside," She scolded and he ducked his head sheepishly. Catra was relieved he did not manage to finish that sentence and pulled him off the doorstep inside the hallway.

"Lunch is ready ," W eaver said, heading into the dinning room. The spread was impressive, roast with all the fixings. Catra had been woken early this morning by Weaver to inform her that she was making lunch for them. She had been at it for hours. Adam practically had stars in his eyes at the sight of the food. He was a simple man.

"T ake a seat," W eaver said, sitting down with her wine and taking a sip. Adam sat down and glanced over at Catra as she sat carefully. She laid a napkin on her lap and smiled at Adam.

"Please help yourself, I made your favorite," Catra said with a fragile looking smile. It wasn't his favorite, he loved all food but he really liked meat, so it was a safe bet. He smiled softly at her, the affection in his expression was undeniable.

"Thanks Cat, you're the best," Adam said earnestly and Catra flushed. She knew it wasn't romantic love, but she loved this dumbass and she knew he felt the same. He started to serve himself as Weaver watched on in silence. Watching the two of them like they were a riddle she needed to crack.

Adam sat down and started eating, Catra did the same but Weaver made no move to eat the food painstakingly provided to her. She sipped her wine and let the silence stretch on.

"I heard about the fight at the game last night," Weaver said, swirling the glass in her hand like some kind of Bond villan. Catra tried not to cough as she breathed in a little too shapely around her food. Adam awkwardly closed his mouth and moved his full fork back to his plate.

"Uh, yes," he said softly.

"Speak up," Weaver scolded and Adam gulped.

"Yes, Ma'am," he said louder and Weaver nodded with satisfaction.

"Good, why did you start the fight?" Weaver asked as she sipped her wine and Adam glanced at Catra. Catra to her credit, had sat forward at the possibility of finding out what actually happened.

"He had said something about Catra," Adam said, keeping his voice even as he looked back at Weaver.

"Oh really. What did he say? This was Grimmor, correct?" Weaver asked and Adam nodded.

"Yes Ma'am. But I would never repeat such vulgar language," Adam said firmly and Catra let out a soft breath. She couldn't help the smile as Adam looked at her, he smiled back.

"Sometimes a situation requires a firm hand. It's good to know you won't hesitate to correct bad behaviour" Weaver said as her eyes slid to Catra. Catra's eyes went wide, was Weaver encouraging Adam to hit her? Adam looked equally horrified at what she was suggesting. He recovered faster than Catra could.

"I've never been one to shy away from defending what's *right*," he said firmly, his tone held no room for argument. Weaver seemed content with this and the remainder of lunch was spent in silence.

Once the meal was complete Adam made an excuse that they had a study group and whisked Catra back to the safety of the Greyskull house.

Catra could breathe again once inside these familiar walls. Adora was laying on the floor in the living room and looked suspiciously like she was sulking. She instantly perked up when they entered the room. Adam turned to Catra as soon as they were inside, he had been strangely silent on the drive over.

"I swear Cat, if she lays another hand on you, I'm reporting her myself," Adam said firmly and Catra rolled her eyes. He had clearly held back his comment until he had his sister as backup against Catra's stubbornness.

"Don't be dramatic, I can handle it," Catra said dismissively , and Adam just looked annoyed. Adora, who was still sitting on the floor looking adorably confused, frowned at Catra's response.

"What happened?" Adora asked, her brow pinched with curiosity and confusion. Her blackeye was still dark but it didn't come up as bad as Catra expected last night.

"Weaver practically told me I could hit Catra if I wanted to," Adam said, rounding on his sister and Adora's eyes widened.

"What!" Adora said, pushing herself up and Catra had to crane her neck to look up at the twins who both stood before her.

"It really wasn't that bad, she was just being purposely ambiguous," Catra defended her abuser like she always did, downplaying her own vulnerabilities to feel in control. Adora was unconvinced and frowned.

"You should stay here tonight, we can have a sleepover," Adora said looking worried and Catra huffed.

"I can't, have church tomorrow ," Catra said, but she rarely could stay at the Greyskull's on the weekend because of her mother's commitment to the big guy.

"I'll take you home in the morning, as early as you want, please?" Adora said and Catra tried to resist the big puppy eyes she was getting from both twins.

"This isn't fair!" Catra complained but couldn't stop the smile on her lips. Adora started to grin. She knew she had won. Catra texted Weaver about staying late to study and will be home in time for church in the morning. Catra couldn't help the nervous excitement that spread through her chest at the chance to sleep in Adora's arms.

[..]

"You're really good at this" Adora said with a little despair in her voice, and Catra looked across the coffee table at the adorable frown of concentration Adora was sporting. They were working on their art homework together, drawing each others faces using the guiding lines they had been taught in class. Adora was struggling, mostly because she wasn't using the guiding lines. Adam was laying on his stomach focused on his own homework.

"I'm just using the lines, you should try it" Catra said, trying to hide her hours of practice drawing Adora's eyes.

"I don't understand where they go," Adora frowned as she looked at the guide again. Catra pushed herself up onto her hands so she could lean over the coffee table to grab the guide she was holding. Adora looked at her like she didn't see her coming, her eyes wide.

"Hold it like this, this part is where the eyes go, then this is the nose" she pointed, holding the guide beside her face to make it more obvious.

"But, your eyes don't fit into that section," Adora pouted and Catra blinked at her.

"What do you mean?" Catra asked

"You have really big eyes," Adora said, looking a little flushed.

"No, I don't!" Catra defended, like it was an insult.

"You totally do," Adam chimed in like his opinion was needed. Catra looked insulted as she sat back and threw the guide at Adora.

"It's not a bad thing, they are really nice, just bigger than the guide" Adora rushed to defend her opinion and Catra fought hard to stop the blush. She was unsuccessful.

"Like an alien," Adam teased and Catra growled as she grabbed a cushion off the couch and hit him with it, causing him to yelp.

[...]

"You need to get out of that outfit," Adora said as she looked in her closet for something for Catra to wear. Catra was sitting on her bed and Adora could not look at her any longer. She showed up from lunch wearing something Adora could only describe as a sexy librarian outfit. Adora had done her best to not look too much at the cute skirt that hugged her hips or the high necked blouse which showed off her petite waist. But there was only so much torture a woman could handle.

"Are you offering an alternative or should I sleep nude?" Catra said playfully and Adora valiently tried to not choke on her own spit as she knocked over a box of photographs in her closet. Once she had finally got her breathing under control she turned to glare at Catra. She knew her face was flushed but Catra was just grinning at her like she had won the lottery. Adora looked away quickly as she took some deep breaths.

"You look weird in those clothes," Adora continued like Catra didn't say anything. Catra huffed from behind her and Adora grabbed one of last years jersey's for Catra to sleep in and a pair of shorts she had left here. Adora didn't hate the clothes Catra was wearing. Catra could wear anything and look amazing. But she didn't look

comfortable and she didnt look like *her* Catra, so Adora didnt like them.

"You said that already. This what Weaver wants me to wear. Im lucky I can wear my own clothes to school," Catra said. Adora turned to her with the clothing in hand and walked closer to the bed. Catra scooted back onto the bed as Adora approached stood on it to be taller than her.

"Thats true, what are you doing?" Adora asked frowning up at Catra, the compression of her eye made her wince slightly. Catra reached out and held her face, looking down at her with such soft eyes. Adora held her breath, unsure if she was dreaming.

"How's your eye?" Catra whispered, this suddenly felt like a mirror of the last time Weaver had hurt Catra. Adora forced herself to open her lungs, swallowing so loudly she was sure the neighbours could hear it. Catra's lip twitched up into a soft smile. "I dont think I ever thanked you for defending my honour and all." Catra whispered. Adora felt a shiver run down her spine at the intimate rasp of her voice. The room felt so warm, tension so thick that her movements felt heavy as she lifted her free hand to help steady Catra on the bed. Holding her waist, platonically.

"I'd do it again," Adora said just as softly , Catra's lips parted slightly as she huffed. Adora snapped her eyes back up to meet blue and gold.

"Does it still hurt?" Catra asked with soft concern. Adora was tempted to say no, it didnt hurt that much anymore. Without her input, she felt her head nod. Catra smiled and Adora needed to stop looking at her mouth. "Want me to kiss it better?" Catra teased, her voice playful but kind of high pitched for her normal tone.

Was she nervous? Adora considered maybe Catra felt bad that Adora got hurt defending her. She smiled at the thought, if this is what Catra needed to feel better about it she would allow it.

She nodded again, watching Catra bite her lip and rock closer. Adora closed her eyes and felt the butterfly soft brush of Catra's plush lips on her eyelid. It felt like a lightning strike down her spine. Somehow this purely platonic care felt like the most erotic thing that Adora had ever experienced. She couldn't breath, she couldn't move. After a moment without another kiss she opened her eyes. Looking at Catra's strangely dark eyes.

"Thank you," Catra said softly and Adora swallowed and nodded.

"Y -you're welcome," she said and Catra smiled but released her faced. Catra grabbed the clothing from Adora's hand and jumped off the bed.

"I'll go change," she said, her voice high as she rushed out of the room. Adora collapsed on the side of the bed, experiencing a headrush from turning the darkest shade of red shes ever been in her life.

"Night Dor," Adam's voice suddenly came from the doorway and Adora sat up too quickly, seeing stars for a second.

"Night!" she squeaked, once her vision cleared she saw Adam giving her a thoughtful look.

"You ok?" Adam asked curiously, and Adora smiled at her brother.

"Yeah, you?" Adora asked back and he nodded, he lifted his bandaged hand and flexed it a bit before he grinned at her.

"Yeah," he said and they shared a cocky grin. Neither remorseful for their actions to defend their friend. Adam repeated his goodnight, walking down the hall. Catra must have come out of the bathroom because Adora heard Adam say it again.

"Thanks for today." Catra's soft voice made it down the hall to Adora.

"Of course," Adam responded and after a moment Catra came back into the room. She looked completely swallowed by the jersey she was wearing, it could be a dress on her. A very short dress.

Catra closed the door and climbed into the bed as Adora rearranged herself into a proper sleeping position. Catra watched and waited patiently while Adora got comfortable before she snuggled into her side. Adora was on her back with Catra laying on her shoulder and she was certain her heart was beating too fast. After a few minutes Adora couldn't get her heart to relax so she rolled into her side. Catra groaned softly at being moved but settled again after some wiggling.

Adora much preferred this position. She tucked Catra under her chin and laid her face against Catra's curls. She subtly breathed in the scene of Catra's hair products and felt her whole body relax into the feeling. Catra wiggled as she gripped the back of Adora's pajamas gently. Adora had to get a grip, this was enough for her. Anything more would just be greedy. She could be happy just having Catra like this.

[..]

Catra was excited to send out her birthday invitations when school started Monday morning. It was her 18th so the whole school was invited. It would be the biggest event of the year, everything would be perfect. Catra was bursting with excitement that she should have known wouldn't last. Everything was fine right up until the first mention of the schools gossip paper.

She snatched Glimmer's copy before she even finished her explanation. It should have been warning enough that Glimmer didn't comment on her rudeness.

On the front page of the paper was a photo of Catra walking with the twins following behind her on either side. Both twins were scuffed from the fight and Catra looked absolutely pissed. The headline caused her stomach to drop.

“Kittens New Guard Dogs”

Chapter End Notes

I've been making comics and art for my spop AU's. If you are interested, you can check them out on Twitter, Tumblr and Instagram @niiiart.

Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

> Adora gets a little more daring and only gets green lights. Catra gets a new nickname she 'hates' and we celebrate her birthday.

Chapter Notes

> I was feeling inspired to write this chapter so quickly after the last. I hope I can do the same with the next one. I hope you enjoy the ride!
>
> This is an imaginary place and the drinking age is 18 like my home country. The warning in the tags is for anyone who is uncomfortable with drinking under the age of 21. No SW trigger warning for this chapter, she's a decent human this time.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was embarrassed to be in the papers, especially for something so stupid as starting a fight and getting their game cancelled. Adora and Adam were both taken into the councillor's office during the day, forced to discuss the reasons for their outbursts. Adora was tight lipped and received detention for not apologising, she'd have to go after school every day this week. Adam being the calmer twin was so much better at getting out of things like this because it was so unlike him. He managed to avoid getting detention somehow.

Adora was in a foul mood all day but tried to keep it in check. Catra was equally angry that Adora had received the brunt of the punishment and still refused to tell her what was said about her. Lunch was a little reprieve, the cheerleading squad prepared to hype up the away game next week and announce Catra's birthday.

Catra walked into the cafeteria in her uniform and almost instantly captured the attention of a pair of blue eyes. The cheerleaders split off to other tables and Catra headed for the middle table, which happened to seat her friends. She ignored the question on Adora' s face as she stepped onto a chair and stood on the table. It was late enough in lunch that most people had finished eating, making space for her to stand. Adam looked at Catra with interest but Adora's undivided attention was captivating.

Catra grinned down at her friends before she started to explain the away game coming up next week to the whole room. They will need as much school spirit as possible to carry them to victory, this week they will be doing bake sales and collecting donations for the team to show support. Catra did a great job bringing the room into a frenzy of excitement and with the help of the other cheerleaders there was a thunderous roar of support for the team. The team to their credit were cheering each other on with all the excitement. Adora' s eyes always looked so blue when she was in game mode, she took on a completely different level of focus and it was nothing less than exciting.

Catra also announced her birthday this coming Friday and invited everyone in the school to join her . That garnered even more excitement than the away game. Once she was finished with her announcements she looked at Adam who was talking to Mermista about her costume for Catra's birthday. Catra was about to get down off the table when she noticed Adora's attention was still on her as she offered her hand to help Catra down. Catra tried not to blush at the attention but she wasn't sure how successful she was. Adora seemed caught up in looking at Catra's uniform and Catra huffed.

"I swear to the gods if you call me short again." Catra threatened and Adora's eyes snapped up to her face with a blush. Adora made a small affronted noise which made Catra grin from getting the upper hand.

"I wasn't!" Adora defended as Catra stepped onto the ground in front of her, craning her neck to look up at her. She didn't release her

hand immediately.

"Oh yeah? What were you thinking?" Catra challenged, tilting her chin up defiantly and curious about the renewed blush on Adora's cheeks.

"Catra! What are you wearing to your party?" Glimmer suddenly appeared beside them causing Adora to jump and drop her hand. Catra startled and shoved Glimmer's shoulder.

"Dont do that!" Catra scolded but Glimmer laughed.

"It's not my fault you werent paying attention!" Glimmer teased and Catra glared to hide her blush.

"I'm not telling you anything about my costume, it's a surprise!" Catra defended and Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"You've been saying that for MONTHS, tell meee, I just dont want to match," Glimmer said and Catra smirked.

"You wouldnt dare wear what I have planned," Catra said and Glimmer squeaked as she blushed. Glimmer turned her attention to Adora who had been quietly watching them.

"Fine, what are you wearing?" Glimmer asked and Adora smiled sheepishly.

"I can't say ," Adora said. The three of them were a set and she wouldnt dare ruin the element of surprise for Catra. Catra' s glare was enough motivation to keep her mouth shut.

"Fine, well, Bow and I are going to be cherubs!" Glimmer said huf fing as she crossed her arms. Adora looked at Catra who just grinned, it wasnt far from their theme but it was dif ferent enough.

"Anywho, I've got to change, see you losers later" Catra said, collecting the other cheerleaders and disappearing to the locker rooms.

[..]

Adora was sitting in the stands waiting for football practice to start when Glimmer did the thing she does so well and just appeared out of nowhere. Adora wasn't startled but only because her mind was so preoccupied thinking about Catra's costume for Friday night. Catra refused to show her at the shop but she had seen it on the hanger and that was enough to think about.

"Wow, you look spaced out," Glimmer said, bouncing on her toes with barely withheld excitement. "Thinking about Catra?" Glimmer teased.

"Yeah," Adora said before blushing at her own admission. "Uh, I mean, just thinking about our costumes. How long it will take to get ready, you know." Adora tried to correct herself and Glimmer grinned brighter.

"Oh really? Still don't want to tell me what we're in for from the birthday girl?" Glimmer teased as she poked Adora's arm.

"Catra would literally kill me if I said anything," Adora said with a frown "Besides, I haven't seen it on her anyway" Adora tried to justify it and Glimmer looked surprised.

"Then what were you thinking about? Catra *not* wearing a costume?" Glimmer teased as she wiggled her eyebrow and Adora turned bright red.

"GLIMMER!" She shrieked and Glimmer cackled like the demon she was. Adora hid her face in her hands as she tried to shake the thoughts away. "I would never do that to Adam,"

"I'm just teasing, but I do have a theory about that," Glimmer said, her voice lowering conspiratorially as she sat down beside her on the bench. Adora lifts her head to look at Glimmer in confusion.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked and Glimmer shushed her as she looked around.

"Keep it down, I don't want anyone to hear," Glimmer said softly and Adora nodded, leaning closer to Glimmer as she spoke.

"I don't think Adam and Catra are really dating," Glimmer said softly, and Adora snorted.

"Glim, this isn't some conspiracy theory, they're dating," Adora scolded and Glimmer shushed her again. Adora rolled her eyes. "Fine, why do you think that?" Adora asked, finally whispering.

"Ok, so hear me out, have you ever seen them kiss on the mouth?" Glimmer asked like she was a PI in a cheesy old detective movie.

"Gross, Glim," Adora said making a face, she didn't want to see that. Even the idea of it made her stomach turn.

"Ok fine. I haven't seen them do anything more than a kiss on the cheek at school, how do they act at home?" Glimmer pressed.

"Like they usually act?" Adora said with a frown as she thought about how distinctly not a couple they acted at home. Catra gave most of her attention to Adora if anything while they were at home. Adora assumed it was because she had made a fuss and Catra was overcompensating, but Adora wasn't going to complain.

"Do they spend time alone at home?" Glimmer asked and Adora shook her head. "So if they aren't kissing at school, or at home and they don't spend time together alone?" Glimmer led.

"People can show love in dif ferent ways, they don't have to make out in the halls to show they care, they've been friends for a long time, maybe they are taking it slow," Adora defended and Glimmer baulked at the accusation.

"I know that! I'm just saying, I never thought Catra was straight, and her being in a relationship with Adam where they don't act like a couple is suspicious to me, ok?" Glimmer said with a huff. "Just look for yourself, though you are really oblivious," Glimmer teased, finally stopping her whispering.

"Hey! No I'm not," Adora defended as Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Adora, girls hit on you all the time and you have no idea unless they specifically ask for a date," Glimmer said, crossing her arms.

"I don't want to assume, what if they are just being nice?" Adora sulked.

"Adora, you're hot, they can be nice AND interested," Glimmer said, rolling her eyes again before a grin came over her face. Adora frowned at her and followed her eye as Catra walked up the steps towards them. Catra was wearing her cheerleading outfit and it appears she just finished her time at the bake sale stall because she had a rainbow vomit cupcake in her hand. "For example." Glimmer said under her breath before she yelled down to Catra "What? I don't get a cupcake?"

Catra snorted "I didn't even know you would be here! Get your own cupcake! Team spirit and all that," Catra said waving her free hand before she stopped in front of them. Adora tried to keep her eyes away from the slit in Catra's uniform skort which had distracted her earlier in the day. It rode up as she walked and showed a generous amount of toned thigh.

"You got one for Adora though!" Glimmer whined and Catra glared.

"Maybe this is my cupcake?" Catra defended.

"Why would you bring a cupcake all the way across school to eat it in front of Adora? Seems cruel," Glimmer sang mockingly and Catra looked like she was going to argue before she sighed and handed Adora the cupcake.

Adora made an excited little ‘yay’ as she took the cupcake and licked some of the frosting off.

“Dont you have other people to bother?” Catra asked Glimmer as she crossed her arms and Glimmer giggled.

“I actually do! Have a good practice,” she said, jumping to her feet and disappearing quickly to cause more chaos.

“Thanks for the cupcake,” Adora said as Catra sat down on the seat Glimmer vacated. Adora moaned with delight as she bit into the cupcake, it was delicious and Adora had been craving something sweet all afternoon.

“Gods, Adora, it's just a cupcake” Catra said, sounding scandalised as her cheeks dusted pink. Adora laughed at Catra’s expense and made another loud moan as she licked some icing off her finger. Catra looked horrified as she turned bright red and looked away. Adora just laughed harder .

“How are you feeling about that article?” Catra asked in a small voice, still refusing to look at Adora as she finished licking the remaining icing off her fingers with glee. Once she was finished she looked around for something to dry her hands and Catra produced a napkin Adora didnt notice she was holding.

“Thanks, I was pretty mad, but I am less upset now ,” Adora said with a shrug.

“Really? Why is that? Im still mad,” Catra said, crossing her arms as well as one leg over the other.

“I dunno,” Adora said, scrunching up the napkin in her hand once she was done with it. “I guess I realised I dont really mind that people know Id punch someone for you,” Adora said with a grin, and Catra looked aghast.

“Adora!” Catra said and hit her in the shoulder as Adora laughed.

"What? It's true, besides it gave me a great new nickname for you," Adora said with a cocky grin. Catra looked confused.

"What?" She asked and Adora leaned closer to whisper to her .

"Kitten," Adora said, looking down at her as Catra turned bright red.

"Absolutely not!" Catra complained, hitting Adora again, but it only made her laugh under the assault.

"Too late, Im keeping it," Adora laughed, jumping up to avoid Catra's hands. Catra did not give up so easily and tried to catch Adora, but she was already running. She knew this game too well. Adora almost ran into Adam in her haste to get down the steps to the field and dodged around him.

"Look out!" She warned through laughter as Catra almost ran into him too.

"Adora what did you do?" Adam asked, laughing as he put his arm out to stop Catra, even if he didnt know which side he was on yet.

"Nothing, Im innocent!" Adora yelled from at least ten feet away .

"Seems unlikely , what happened Cat?" Adam asked, wrapping his arm around Catra's waist as she tried to duck under his arm. "Nope, not till I get answers," he said, lifting her up as she struggled.

"Unfair!" Catra whined as she struggled "She called me that stupid name from the gossip paper!" Catra yelled and Adam put her down.

"What? Kitten?" Adam asked and Catra nodded as she crossed her arms. Adam seemed to be thinking for a moment before he released her.

"You're right, kill her ," Adam said and Catra smiled with evil glee. Adora squeaked and started to run again.

“Adam, you traitor!” Adora yelled but she couldn't stop laughing as she ran from Catra.

[..]

Wednesday was Catra’s actual birthday and Weaver had requested she be home for a birthday dinner. What counted as dinner was Weaver providing take out and allowing Catra to have some wine with her. Catra hated how much the token meant to her, it was a slither of kindness in an otherwise harsh relationship and it made her want to cry.

Weaver even went so far as to tell Catra she was proud of her and touched her cheek so softly like she could only remember her doing a handful of times over her whole life. It felt almost like she was loved by her mother and it felt so overwhelming that she went to her room and cried. She wished this was her norm: having someone to love her so unconditionally, the woman who brought her into the world should love her right?

Catra decided to calm herself by sketching, she just needed an outlet for all these feelings. She opened her sketchbook and the cutout from the paper fell into her lap. She threw away the rest of the paper as soon as the image was free and cut Teela out of it for good measure. Though she did intend to give it to Adam if he wanted it, she didn't throw it away. She looked at the image of Adora, her abs glistening and her hair coming undone. Even her thighs pushed the limits of her jeans. She was the type of inspiration Greek sculptures were made from.

Catra was starting to feel hot, looking at the focus on Adora’s face as the beads of sweat dripped off her strong chin. Catra felt like such a creep, but she couldn't help it. Adora was beautiful, effortlessly sexy and so adorable. She decided to use these observations to her advantage and started to sketch the dips and planes of her desires.

She was so caught up in her head that she almost didn't hear the soft tapping at her window. After the second tapping she jumped in

surprise, her sketchbook falling off the side of the bed on the ground. She looked at her window to see the dumb face of her desires standing on the roof outside her window with a big grin.

Catra went to the window intent on scolding Adora but once the window was open the blonde climbed inside.

"Are you crazy?! You can't be here! Weaver will kill me," Catra said in a panicked whisper as Adora straightened her clothes as she stood straight. She just grinned.

"Then stop being so loud," Adora whispered back, "I told you I forgot your present at home today, I had to bring it, or it would be late," Adora explained as she pulled out a box from her pocket and Catra frowned.

"You could have given it to me tomorrow dummy," Catra said softly, and Adora grinned and shrugged like her climbing into Catra's window wasn't a big deal.

"Open it," Adora urged and Catra moved her eyes to the little box. It was the size of a ring box, maybe a bit bigger. She looked up at Adora suspiciously and Adora's cheeks looked a little pink.

"What? Are you proposing or something?" Catra asked and Adora laughed nervously but didn't comment. Catra pulled off the ribbon and opened the box. As expected it was a ring, but not any ring, it was one she had been looking at months ago, she was completely smitten with it and visited it often. She didn't have the money for it and one day it was gone, so she had put it out of her mind. Tears came to her eyes that Adora had bought it for her. She knew Catra wouldn't accept a random gift so expensive so she waited. It was so touching. Catra looked up at Adora who still looked a little red as she looked at Catra sheepishly.

"Thank you dummy, I love it," she said softly, trying not to choke on her words with the emotion rising up her throat. Adora smiled at her so softly and touched her cheek, not unlike Weaver had done only

hours ago. This felt so different, though this was a touch she could always trust to catch her if she fell. She leaned into the affection.

"You mean so much to me," Adora said softly and Catra looked up at her, her eyes pleading. Please, tell me you want me like I want you. Please.

The moment of intense eye contact was broken by a sound in the hall, it sounded like shuffling and both girls held their breath until Weaver's door clicked closed. Adora lowered her hand from Catra's cheek and smiled at her softly again.

"I should go, happy birthday kitten," Adora said softly and Catra blushed deeply.

"Please dont call me that," Catra groaned softly . Dont act like Im yours.

Adora smiled brighter, her eyes dancing with amusement before she leaned down and kissed Catra on the top of the head.

"Too late," Adora said with barely withheld laughter . Adora bit her lip and held her eyes for a moment. "Bye," she said softly , and Catra pushed through her embarrassment to return the farewell before Adora disappeared out her window into the night.

Catra looked at her sketchbook on the floor which had fallen face down thankfully, but the image of Adora had landed right side up. For once Catra was relieved by Adora's obliviousness.

[..]

Mara arrived with her girlfriend Hope on Thursday night. Adora's parents had kindly offered the house and organised a weekend away on a romantic trip to the city. But they were more than happy to be called if needed. So Adora and Adam's cousin Mara was there to chaperone and tend the bar.

Mara brought her very quiet girlfriend to meet the family too which resulted in a lovely dinner. Catra was always happy to spend time with any Greyskull, it was like their genetics demanded they be loud, kind and so playful. Mara had met Catra once before but they had both been younger so it was good to catch up. After dinner Mara loudly decided that she liked Catra, and that she was good for Mara's bone headed cousins. Adam laughed but Adora just smiled at the proclamation.

After dinner concluded, Mara and Hope retired to their room. Which was the study with a double cot in it, to relax after their long journey . Catra studied with the twins until she had to return home. Only one more day of school until it was time to party.

[..]

At lunch in the cafeteria on Friday, Adora was helping sell their latest fundraising attempt, which was school jerseys with your favourite players' names on the back. They set up a table in the cafeteria with the options laid out. Adora and Adam were competing to see how many shirts they could sell each, which was moronic because both shirts said Greyskull on it. Catra was sitting at the table dealing with the money when a junior came up to the table.

"Which one would you like?" Catra asked curiously as she stood to greet the girl. The curly haired blonde looked between the shirts with a tipped head before she looked at Catra.

"How do I get one like yours?" The girl asked and Catra looked down to realise she had put one of Adam's old jerseys on this morning. They looked different to what they were selling because this was an original from Jr year.

"Uh, it's an original, so we arent seeing those," Catra explained and the girl looked thoughtful.

"Oh, so you have to date one of the players to get those?" She asked, "of a few I guess," the girl continued. Catra frowned, unsure

what she meant by that, but the girl moved on. "I'll take the Mermista one," the girl said, and Catra folded it up and took the money .

"Thanks for your support," Catra said with a smile and the girl smiled back before she left. Adora popped up beside her once the girl was gone.

"Was that one of mine?" Adora asked if there was any way to tell who was winning. Catra shoved Adora's shoulder.

"No dummy , it was Mermista's, if you wanted to have a competition we should have printed two Greyskull jerseys!" Catra said in frustration.

"Nah, no need to waste the money , I know I'm winning," Adora said, grinning like an idiot before she walked off to harass more people into buying apparel.

[..]

Adora sat fidgeting in a chair as Glimmer did her makeup, Adora was anxious to get moving. Glimmer had done Catra' s make-up first and when she came into the room to help Adora she had stars in her eyes. Adora desperately wanted to see what Catra's outfit looked like and it made her vibrate with excitement.

"This is going to take ten times longer if you don't stop moving," Glimmer scolded her again and she clenched her hands to try to stay still.

"I can't help it, this is taking forever!" Adora whined for the third time at least. Glimmer hit her on the nose with a powder brush to scold her.

"It's been like ten minutes, tops," Glimmer said and Adora sighed loudly. There was a soft knock on the door and Glimmer frowned. "Who is it?" She asked suspiciously .

"It's Adam, the birthday girl is getting impatient," Adam said with a laugh in his voice. "OW ," he yelped, clearly the birthday girl was also there. Adora started fidgeting again, unable to hold on to her burning energy any longer.

"W ell she can just wait, I am creating art!" Glimmer retorted, putting her hands on Adora's shoulders to try to hold Adora still. "Actually , Adam can you come hold your sister still so I can actually work!" Glimmer yelled and the door clicked open. Adora could see the shadow of Catra in the door and it made her want to look but the door was quickly closed as Adam came over in his all white suit and feathery angel wings, topped with a halo. Adora was wearing something similar, a tailored white suit with the same white wings and halo. The only unusual thing about the outfit was the black chains and collars around their necks, which Catra had insisted on to complete her outfit.

Adam stood behind Adora and put his hands on her shoulders.

"What's up sis?" he asked curiously as Glimmer worked.

"I'm just excited for the party ," Adora excused and tried to settle under the grounding weight on her shoulders. She took some deep breaths, what she really wanted was to see Catra's outfit, and to die a gay death.

Finally Adora is finished and she's allowed to look at her outfit as a whole. She had her hair down and styled but nothing fancy, she looked nice with the basic makeup Glimmer did but she mostly wants to know what Catra thinks.

After confirming that she liked it with Glimmer, she disappeared out the door, apparently ready to dress herself in Adora's room now that her obligations were complete. People had started arriving downstairs and Adora knew Catra wanted to make an entrance.

Adora spoke to Adam as she waited and when the door to the room clicked open she felt wholly unprepared to see Catra's outfit. She

knew in theory what to expect, but she was not prepared at all for what she saw. Catra had decided to be a devil, which was why she had two chained angels as her pets. Adora wasnt the most creative when it came to group costumes so she was happy with whatever was suggested. Plus she's got to wear a really comfy suit all night, win win.

Catra, however, might run the risk of getting cold or maybe even a wardrobe malfunction. She wore tight red leather pants with black ribbons corset up her legs and black ankle boots. Her upper half was covered only with a red leather crop top and a black leather jacket over the top. She had a devil tail trailing behind her and devil horns atop her head. Her hair was done in big beautiful curls and Glimmer had done her makeup perfectly. She had a smokey eye with sharp eyeliner and deep red lipstick. She looked amazing, and Adora didnt know how long she stared without saying anything.

A sharp sound kickstarted Adora’s brain, it was a whistle coming from Catra.

"Damn Dor , you look good in white," Catra said with a smirk that should not look so sexy , but it was completely unfair to subject Adora’s gay brain to these images.

"Y ou told me I looked like a preacher," Adam whined petulantly .

"Y eah, well you cant pull it of f," Catra said playfully .

"W ere twins!" Adam said with a huf f as he crossed his arms.

"Which makes it even weirder that you can't pull it of f," Catra continued and Adora watched the interaction out of curiosity. Glimmer's words niggling at the back of her head.

[..]

The party was in full swing, their entrance was everything Catra had wanted and the twins looked to die for. Adora had caught many an

eye and it did not sit well in Catra's gut to have so many girls fawning over her Adora.

Catra was having fun, she loved to be the centre of attention, getting happy birthdays and random presents from people she barely knew. Adam had been reasonably attentive until Teela arrived and has since been playing Ping pong with her for at least forty minutes now. Catra needed a breather but it was too cold outside for her outfit so she found a dark corner to sulk a little out of the limelight for a few minutes.

Catra had left Adora in the kitchen where she had been challenged to tie a cherry stem with her tongue and Catra just couldn't watch the girls giggling while she tried. Adora never turned down a challenge after all.

Catra had a drink in her hand and looked around the room quietly as she let her mind wander. She saw a flash of purple pigtails for only a moment before they were gone. She didn't know Entrapta well, but she didn't think parties were really her thing. She hoped the eccentric girl was having fun at least.

"Hey ," someone leaned on the wall beside Catra and she turned, expecting Adora but finding Adora.

"Hey ," Catra said, a little surprised, she had obviously ditched her groupies as they went to watch the heated ping pong tournament.

"You alright?" Adora asked, and Catra shrugged. The action made Adora turn her body towards Catra and frown. "What's wrong?" she asked softly, glancing around like she was trying to work it out herself.

"I just needed a breather ," Catra lied and Adora perked up, she had a little to drink so her reactions were a little slow. With Mara manning the bar, no one was going to be trashed tonight, which was a relief.

"We can go outside?" Adora offered and Catra laughed.

"I'm not really dressed for October weather ,"Catra motioned and Adora's eyes followed the motion of her hand.

"T rue,"she said, biting her lip as she seemed to be thinking. "I can keep you warm though,"Adora said softly , and Catra choked on her drink a little. She covered her mouth and coughed into her hand until she recovered. Adora giggling like a moron all the time.

"Adora!"she coughed but couldn't help the laugh at the blonde's amused grin.

"Fine, what about we go to my room? It won't be cold there?"Adora said with a smile and Catra considered the question while Adora moved. She put her hand on the wall beside Catra as she blocked Catra's view of the room with her body and wings. Catra immediately felt more at ease as the room slipped away and Adora's attentive eyes watched her.

"Actually , I think I'm fine right here,"Catra said, her tone a little husky as she sipped her drink to quench her suddenly dry mouth. Adora smiled her charming smile and her hand flexed on the wall as Adora leaned down, grabbing something hanging at Catra's side.

"I like your tail,"Adora commented, swinging the end in a circle before poking Catra with the sharp point.

"Hey! That's for my use only"Catra scolded and Adora just grinned at her, ready to poke her again. Catra giggled and grabbed the appendage to poke Adora hard in the stomach. She obviously flexed because her poke was unsuccessful.

"Stop showing of f!"Catra teased with a playful glare.

"Y ou like it,"Adora said and Catra almost choked again. Adora was clearly feeling brave tonight and Catra could not handle this undivided attention. She was already in love, she couldn't fall any harder than she already had.

"Maybe I do," Catra purred back as she carefully grabbed the chain hanging from Adora's collar. Adora's cheeks turned pink as she grinned her cocky smile that drove Catra up the wall.

"ADORA!" Adam's voice yelled over the music and Adora jumped. She looked so startled and guilty that Catra's heart dropped. She turned to Adam who was walking over, he seemed a little sweaty from the ping pong game but happy nonetheless.

"We should do the thing," Adam said, tapping his nose, and Adora stared at him in confusion. He cleared his throat "The, uh, birthday thing?" he tried to prompt and even Catra knew he meant a cake now. Adora paled.

"Oh! Right!" she said quickly disappearing with the other angel. Catra let out a long sigh, she was playing with fire now and she was going to get burnt. She looked across the room to see a pink cherub giving her a suspicious look and Catra had to blink a few times before she realised it was Glimmer. Bow was standing beside her and they were whispering conspiratorially as they watched Catra. Catra really hoped that they didn't just see all of that with Adora.

Catra didn't know it yet, but the headlines for Monday morning were already written and the photo evidence was captured.

The biggest party of the year had its very own scandal, written in black and white the title read "Mixing up your Angels."

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! I hope you enjoyed ~

A few of these scenes are tempting me to draw them, but we shall see. If you would like to see my art you can find me on @moniiart on Tumblr, Twitter and Instagram. <3

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

Lots of hugs, some apologies and Catra ups her cardio.

Chapter Notes

We are so close to the end now. I did remove the chapter count but I think it will still be 10-12 chapters. We shall see how we go. This chapter is a chonky one. I hope you enjoy .

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had been up for a while now, she was just holding Catra as she slept peacefully. Adora watched her breath gently and her eyebrows scrunch in concentration for whatever dream she was having. Catra wiggled to get more comfortable and buried her face further into Adora's chest. Adora adjusted to get settled in the new position but felt Catra's arms tighten around her to hold her still. She must be waking up.

Adora was pretty proud of herself for keeping a lid on her emotions while having a few drinks last night. She didnt let herself have too many because she would ramble about anything if she got drunk. She didnt want to ramble about her newly discovered feelings for Catra. But last night really cemented them in her mind, she even considered it might be more than just a crush. She was drawn to Catra like she was the centre of her universe.

Catra groaned softly into her shirt and tightened her grip again. Adora grinned into her hair on top of her head.

"Morning Kitten,"Adora said, her voice sounding deeper in the mornings and she tried to clear her throat to make it sound normal. Catra's eyes snapped open at the nickname and Adora had to stop her grin as she glared up at Adora.

"Dont call me that,"Catra scolded as she hit Adora in the bicep in retaliation. Catra would die before she admitted she liked the nickname, but her rosy cheeks told a different story.

"Dont hit me,"Adora rebutted as she gripped Catra tighter to push her into bed. Catra made a sound at the action that was between a gasp and groan. Adora immediately released her as her own face coloured.

"Sorry ,"she said, and Catra hid her blushing face in the pillows as she rolled onto her stomach.

"Sleep,"Catra muttered and Adora huf fed. She didnt want to sleep, it was time to do things.

"Come on Cat. Its almost midday , we should get up and make everyone breakfast,"Adora whined as she shook Catra lightly . Catra grumbled but didnt move so Adora reluctantly settled beside her again. She guessed she could be happy with more cuddles. She wrapped her arms around Catra again and pulled her closer. Catra seemed delighted and snuggled into Adora's arms again.

Cuddles were not on the menu this morning however as the door opened abruptly and Mara was standing there. Adora looked at her in surprise over the top of Catra's head, cradling her when she jumped at the sudden noise.

"Mara, dont you know how to knock?" Adora asked with a frown. Mara snorted.

"Moring to you too grumpy , why would I knock?" she asked with a playful smile and Adora huffed.

"T o not startle people?" Adora grumbled and Mara laughed.

"I guess so, ready to make breakfast?" Mara asked and Adora perked up at the mention of food. She could be convinced by pancakes to get out of bed.

"Have fun," Catra shot over her shoulder at Mara and snuggled into the pillows more. Adora wasnt having that. She rocked Catra annoyingly.

"Come on Catraaa, you have to get up eventually ," she whined and Catra glared at her over the pillow her face was smooshed into.

"Dor , let the girl sleep, come help me make food for all these friends of yours," Mara said and rolled her eyes. Adora huf fed.

"Fine," she said, pouting when Catra looked at her .

"Thank you!" Catra said over her shoulder to Mara before disappearing into the blankets and pillows again.

Mara had a weirdly knowing look on her face as Adora carefully crawled over Catra to get out of bed and had to pull on some shorts to wear downstairs.

Catra hated the cold so Adora had elected to put the heat on in her room to keep her comfortable, but it meant Adora overheated at night so she dressed in just her singlet and underwear .

Adora dressed and followed Mara out of the room. They passed the living room on their way to the kitchen and Adora could see her friends sleeping on piles of pillows and blankets.

Silently they both set to work in the kitchen. Adora carefully collected items to start making breakfast: bacon, eggs, flour, milk. She put them all on the counter while Mara got the bowls and heated the pan for the bacon. They were silently working until the first pancake hit the hot skillet. While they waited, Mara turned to Adora with a determined look in her eyes that always spelled trouble.

"Dor , what are you doing?" Mara asked and Adora looked up from where she was cracking eggs into a bowl and frowned.

"Uh, cracking eggs?" Adora asked, confused.

"No, no that, what are you doing with Catra?" Mara asked and Adora's eyes widened and she blushed. She ducked her head to look at the eggs again, cracking another.

"W -what do you mean?" Adora asked as she tried to fight her blush.

"Y ou were wrapped around her like an octopus Dor" Mara said in a slightly scolding tone that reminded her of her mother.

"W e are always like that," Adora defended. She didn't know why she felt so caught at this accusation but she knew she was red. She could feel it in the cheeks as Mara looked at her critically.

"I was watching you two last night if I didn't know any better I would think you and Catra were dating rather than her and Adam," Mara said as her eyes narrowed at Adora.

"Dont be silly Mara!She' s my best friend, and I would never do that to Adam,"Adora said, her resolve causing her to glare at Mara' s smirking face.

"Interesting that you didnt say you didnt like her like that,"

"I dont like her like that!Besides, she is straight so it wouldnt matter even if I did!"Adora whispered harshly at Mara who just laughed.

"Sure, she is,"Mara rolled her eyes and turned back to flip the pancake. Adora scowled at the back of her head but returned to cracking eggs. They were silent for a long while before Mara turned back to Adora and she held her breath.

"Y ou know we would always support you, right Dor? I know you havent brought a girl home before, but if you did, we would all be happy for you,"Mara said and Adora released her breath with an affectionate smile at her cousin.

"I know Mara, thanks. I just havent found someone who I like like that."Adora said and Mara nodded her head silently . Some movement could be heard as people groaned to life in the living room.

[..]

Catra was unprepared for her gift from the Greyskulls. She was told to cover her eyes while Dean got it out of the shed and when she finally laid her eyes on the vintage motorcycle that Dean had spent months fixing she couldnt help but squeal with unbridled excitement. She could have cried but she spent her energy bouncing around and gushing about the beautiful gift she was given.

"Now , before you're allowed on that thing, you have to take classes to be safe, all three of you have to. I won't have the twins on that and put you in danger," Linda said firmly and the three of them nodded. Adam looked equally excited for the bike, he had also wanted one of his own but it was easier to give both kids a car than get two bikes.

"Really , thank you so much. I love it," Catra said so filled with emotion and love for these two people who acted more like her parents than her own mother.

"We wanted to do it, it will help you be more independent and you won't have to rely on Weaver or the twins to get around," Dean said with a grin.

"Speaking of Weaver...can I leave it here for now? I should probably bring it up with her before she sees it." Catra said suddenly nervous to have that conversation with her mother.

"Of course dear , well booked a lession during the break, so no joy rides until then. If you need help talking to your mum, just let us know ok?" Linda offered and Catra nodded.

"Yeah, thank you," Catra said with a grin and looked at her watch. "I should probably get going," Catra said reluctantly.

"I'll drive you home, since you got so many presents," Adam offered with a grin and Catra nodded. She hugged everyone before packing the car and taking the short drive home.

"I hate lying to them," Catra said softly, and Adam sighed and nodded his head.

"Me too, its really hard with Adora too." Adam said with a frown and glanced at Catra. "Are...are you sure nothing's going on there?" Adam asked and Catra blushed and looked out her window.

"I have no idea what you are talking about," Catra crossed her arms stubbornly.

"Would you tell me if things changed?" Adam asked as he parked outside.

"Of course," Catra lied. She was getting really good at lying these days. "But nothings going to change," Catra said stubbornly, and Adam nodded his head.

"Ok, do you need help bringing stuf f in?" Adam asked and Catra shook her head.

"No, Im ok," Catra said, mostly she didnt want W eaver to freak out at him for coming inside. She collected all her things carefully and struggled inside. Weaver had already gone to bed.

[..]

It was nearly freezing outside but the church was always warm and toasty. It was great for Catra who was wearing a skirt that dug into her waist and a blouse which was too thin for the weather. She was barely able to keep her eyes open as the pastor droned on and on about the renewal of the home and reducing clutter to purify the soul. He was talking about worldly possessions being what corrupts the mind and turns us into self indulgent sinners. She was listening enough incase Weaver quizzed her later, but it was boring. Weaver seemed incredibly interested in the sermon but she was always like that.

[..]

On Monday morning Catra was in a panic. Her alarm didnt go of f and she was late to get a ride with Weaver so as the great mother she was, she left without her. Catra threw on whatever she could find that was clean. Jeans, jersey, jacket and threw her hair into a messy ponytail before she grabbed her things and rushed to the Greyskulls to get a ride with them.

"You look cute," Adora commented. Catra was flushed and sweaty and not mentally prepared for Adora's compliments this morning so she huffed and ignored her as she jumped in the car.

They left it to the last minute to leave so all three of them were very nearly late for school. Catra was sitting in her first period seat as she tried to get her breathing under control when she heard some of her classmates whispering.

She thought they might be talking about her the way they kept glancing over but she might be paranoid. She glared at them regardless and they promptly stopped whispering.

Between classes Glimmer appeared as if summoning a demon and whispered quickly with Adora and waving the stupid gossip paper at her. Adora took the paper and looked pale before Glimmer dashed off in a burst of hellish glitter.

Adora wasn't in her next class so she had to wait and see what that was about. Third period Adora rushed up to Catra and sat beside her.

"Have you seen it?" Adora asked, a little panicked. Catra's confused face prompted her to continue.

"The paper ," Adora clarified and Catra snorted.

"Why would I read that?" Catra hated that paper for how it was treating Adora and apparently they werent done with her yet.

"What now?" Catra asked suspiciously and Adora handed her the gossip paper. Adora looked guilty.

Catra looked down at the paper and once again Adora was on the front page, and Catra was with her. Adora looking so good in her suit with Catra pulling on her leash. Catra blushed at the heat she could see in just the image. The title "Mixing up your Angels" was regretfully very clever. Catra felt a sinking dread as she realised she had fucked up.

Even oblivious Adora would be able to see her feelings clear as day in this photo.

Catra scanned the story and instead of it being completely unrelated to the image like the previous one, this one sounded like an exposé. The article claimed that the team was bound to struggle this season if two of their best players were fighting over the same position. Catra couldnt calm her blush but took a few deep breaths. She looked up at Adora who still looked guilty and Catra couldnt decipher any other emotion on her face.

"You know this is bullshit right?" Catra asked and Adora looked a little hurt before she nodded slowly.

"People believe it though," Adora said and Catra huffed. She was right. The truth didn't matter, this is printed and thats what people would believe.

"Fuck." Catra said softly before she put her head in her hands, trying to think how to undo this. She needed to make sure Weaver didn't see this, or believe it. She needed a plan. She barely had the mental capacity to focus on her class while her mind was going in circles worrying about what Weaver would do if she found out the truth.

Adora continued to glance at Catra but she was quiet during class and lets Catra think.

[..]

Catra continued her unusually quiet after Adora showed her the paper. Adora had considered not showing her so she wouldn't worry but she didn't like the idea of keeping something like that from her. It was already clear as day the way Adora felt about Catra and now the whole school knew. Catra said the article was bullshit but she must have seen Adora's feelings for her too. No one could read her like Catra could.

They were sitting at lunch with Catra between her and Adam like usual. He had been trying to cheer her up but it wasnt really working.

Glimmer arrived like a grenade at the table as she sat across from Catra with a frown.

"Isnt that Adora's number on that Jersey?" Glimmer asked and Adora looked surprised and looked at Catra's outfit. She looked adorable with her tight jeans and the bagy jersey but Glimmer was right, that was Adora's number, not Adam's. Catra looked like a caged animal as she was immediately defensive. Today was probably a bad day to antagonise her.

"So?" Catra bit back immediately and Glimmer bristled in response as she rose to the challenge.

"So? It's interesting that you are wearing your boyfriend's sister's shirt," Glimmer rebutted and Catra glared at her .

"Not that its any of your business, like, at ALL. But I got dressed in a hurry today." Catra snapped

"So you just decided you wanted Adora's number on your back?" Glimmer asked, her voice slightly mocking to grate at Catra's nerves.

"I've had it for years, it's not like its new!" Catra vollied back at her as she stood and her chair screeched. Catra glanced around to see other students nearby watching the interaction and their whole table of friends eaves-dropping.

"I'm just saying, its [illegible] interesting" Glimmer said standing up as well, noting that she quite made it to Catra's height.

"Chill out Glim," Adora snapped in Catra's defence, she was always the more reactive twin and she wasn't about to watch Glimmer attack Catra. Especially when she was already stressed.

"Lay off her Glim," Adam said with a frown, getting with the programme just a little late. He seemed shocked into silence at the sudden heat between the usually amicable hotheads.

"God, shes got you both so well trained," Glimmer mocked and rolled her eyes. She didn't really look like she believed those words even as she was saying it. Adora felt the sting, she would do anything for Catra and that wasn't a bad thing. At least she didn't think so. Catra had picked up her tray to leave but instead slammed it down on the table.

"You know what, fuck you," Catra snapped, leaving her tray behind as stormed out of the room. Adora got to her feet to follow but Adam stood and put his hand on her shoulder.

I better go,” he said with an almost sad smile, and Adora nodded. That made sense. He was her boyfriend after all. Adora sat down as Adam followed after Catra.

Adora sat for a moment before she turned her eyes to Glimmer with a glare.

“What the hell was that?” Adora asked and Glimmer huf fed.

“They're faking it and I'm going to prove it,” Glimmer whispered harshly and Adora stood up again to lean over the table to Glimmer. Glimmer had the sense to lean away from Adora’s towering form while she looked so pissed.

“What does it matter to you?” Adora asked in a low tone, it really had no impact on Glimmer's life and if they were faking, what did it matter anyway?

“Because they are hurting you! They're lying to you,” Glimmer stage whispered, and Adora startled.

“No they aren't,” Adora said and Glimmer shook her head.

“They are, and I'm going to prove it to you. Y oull see, I'm just looking out for you,” Glimmer said and Adora glared.

"What was the point of upsetting her?" Adora asked as she stood up straight again. Glimmer looked a little regretful.

"Well I wasn't trying to upset her so much. She's just so defensive about being accused of being close to you," Glimmer said "I'm proving my point. This is all some stupid act. I just don't know why. I mean she's wearing your jersey for gods sake,"

"She always wears them, even before Adam and her started dating, she's been stealing them for years," Adora crossed her arms and glared. "Even if she wasn't straight, It's not cool to out people before they are ready, leave it alone," Glimmer looked horrified at the accusation.

"I'm not outting her! I would never! I am just proving they aren't actually a couple. She clearly likes someone else. You'll see," Glimmer said and Adora huffed.

She elected to ignore Glimmer for the remainder of lunch. She saw Adam at her next class but he said he couldn't find Catra. She didn't come to their next class together either and Adora was worried.

[..]

Adora looked for Catra between classes but had no luck finding her in any of her hiding spots. She hoped she was alright, sending her a text and receiving a response to ensure she was ok.

Adora 3:20PM

Ok?

Catra 3:21PM

Ok

Adora knew it wasn't much but at least she confirmed that she was alright for now. Adora had to see the counsellor after school but before practice and her boxing club so she headed for the school office.

She sat waiting to be called by the counsellor Mrs Ella, a different one to the Art teacher. Adora heard they were married, since they looked nothing alike, but kids also talk and no one had confirmed it for her.

"Adora Greyskull, come on in," Mrs Ella asked, and Adora joined her in her room. "Take a seat," the woman said, her grey hair in a short crop with darker skin. She was sure she was a lesbian when she first saw her.

Adora took a seat and crossed her arms. She was usually a good kid but something about being scolded for defending Catra's honour put a bitter taste in her mouth.

"How are you feeling today"?

"I'm fine Mrs Ella"

"I told you last time, please call me, Nets"Nets said and Adora nodded without making eye contact. She was being difficult.

"I'm fine, Nets"Adora adjusted her answer and Nets nodded as she looked at Adora with interest.

"Are you ready to apologise"?Nets asked and Adora frowned, looking at her with a scowl.

"I have nothing to apologise for!"Adora defended and Nets shook her head a little.

"I disagree, you should apologise for letting your anger get the better of you, even if you believe you did it for a good reason,"

"I DID do it for a good reason,"

"Because your friend was accused of having lose morals"?

"Because my BEST friend was insulted by some pig who thought he had any right to say her name,"Adora practically growled and Nets raised her eyebrows at her before making a note.

"Tell me about your home life,"Nets said and Adora stumbled before frowning.

"My home life?Why"?Adora asked, suspicious of the woman's angle.

"I'd like to understand you better , tell me about your home life,"Nets said kindly and Adora sighed as she accepted her fate.

"I live with my parents and twin brother ,"

"Yes, Adam. Did you know he apologised for his actions"?Nets asked as she watched Adora and Adora frowned.

"Y es, I know," She said firmly . He would have apologised, he didnt punch people and he was guilty after he acted like that.

"Why do you think he did that?" Nets asked and Adora shrugged.

"I dont know ,"

"Do you think he cared less?" Nets asked and a little voice in Adora' s head said "yes" before she even considered the question.

"No, he's just not as protective as I am," Adora said crossing her arms and leaning away from the desk between them.

"So you are protecting Catra? What are you protecting her from?" Nets asked and Adora frowned.

"Anyone who dared to hurt her , emotionally or physically," Adora said like it was the most obvious thing in the world. She would do anything for Catra, why does that matter here?

"Has anyone ever tried to hurt her before this incident?" Nets asked and Adore sucked in a quick breath as she realised she might have said too much. She clamped her mouth shut and Nets noticed immediately. She nodded her head as she made a note on her notepad.

"What is her home life like?" Nets asked gently .

"You'd have to ask her ," Adora snipped back.

"Do you think that would be best?" Nets asked, and Adore glared with a tight lip as she stayed silent. "You're a good friend, you know that. I know it's hard to be silent when you see injustice. Catra is lucky to have a friend like you looking out for her," Nets continued and Adora felt a warm bloom at the praise. She remained silent regardless. "I know you might not believe me, but I am only interested in helping you. I don't want something like this to end up on your record," Adora considered this for a moment and thought of Catra's situation.

"...If I did have a friend, not Catra, with trouble at home, what could I do to help them?" Adora asked slowly , hoping not to point to a spotlight on Catra.

"Well I would love to have a chance to speak to them. If they are able to be open about it and give evidence of the trouble, we could raise an investigation." Nets said slowly and Adora nodded.

"What if they don't talk about it?"

"That makes it harder . If we cant confirm information from a first hand account we can raise a wellness check. If they find nothing of concern on that visit they won't check again. Has your friend told you why they dont want to raise this trouble?" Nets asked, and Adora chewed her lip as she considered something close enough to the truth that she could say.

"She, uh, they dont want their mum finding out. It could make things worse."Adora said it would be the worst thing if Catra reported Weaver and her mum found out. Who knows what that woman was capable of when she was angry.

"Is there somewhere else they could stay for the investigation?" Nets asked and Adora perked up.

"Y es, they could stay with me,"Adora said quickly and Nets nodded with a considerate look in her eyes.

"Do you think your friend would like to talk to me?" Nets asked and Adora shrugged.

"They said they wouldnt, they are over 18 now too, if that changes things,"Adora said unfolding her arms finally as she looked for a solution.

"Depending on the trouble, it wouldnt include child protection services, but it would require the police,"Nets said carefully .

Adora nodded her head slowly as she considered what to say. She knew Catra had been through so much and Adora was jeopardising their future university options by being an idiot. If she had something on her record she might not get into their university. She would hate to go somewhere without Catra and Adam when they were going to share an apartment.

"I'm sorry ," Adora said with conviction and Nets nodded her head.

"What are you sorry for?"

"I'm sorry I hit Griz or . I should have controlled my emotions. He shouldnt have said what he did, but I shouldnt have struck him," she said with certainty and Nets smiled.

"I'm glad to hear that Adora. I won't need to put this on your record,"

"Thank you. Can I go? I have practice,"

"Sure," Adora got to her feet. "And Greyskull, dont hit anyone else, I dont want to see you in here again unless you need me,"

"I'll do my best,"

"T ell your friend to talk to me, I'd love to listen, even if nothing comes of it."Nets said as she leaned back in her chair .

"I will, thanks,"Adora left the room and pulled the door closed behind her before she headed towards the front office. She could hear raised voices as she re-entered the main room and frowned.

"Miss W eaver, please keep your voice down"the receptionist scolded.

"I am!I just need to transfer into another class,"Catra' s panicked voice made Adora pick up her steps.

"I told you I cant do that unless we have a documented issue to report. If you dont want to speak to me, I can organise an appointment with the counsellor. Its Confidential so she won't tell us anything unless it's a valid reason,"The woman said carefully .

"I cant do that,"Catra said stubbornly and the woman sighed.

"W ell, I am sorry, I cant help you without the appropriate paperwork," the woman said regretfully.

Catra was glaring at the floor as Adora approached. Catra glanced up and noticed Adora before looking almost shy.

"Ready for practice?" She asked instead of asking if Catra was ok. She seemed relieved not to be asked. She looked at the receptionist.

"Y eah, thanks for your time," she said politely before following Adora out of the room. Adora knew school wasnt the right place to talk to Catra about everything, so she kept it light. Catra had changed into her cheer outfit already so she was in a tiny skirt and top that showed part of her midriff that was too distracting for Adora.

"I took notes for you," Adora mentioned idly , and Catra scoffed.

"Thanks, Ill need you to translate them for me," Catra teased lightly as Adora knocked her shoulder against her.

"Hey , my writing has gotten a lot better than it used to be," Adora defended and Catra laughed softly.

"Y eah, its evolved from eligible to barely legible" Catra teased and Adora smiled.

"Still an improvement," Adora defends and Catra laughs. It didnt take them long to get to the oval and Adora stopped Catra a little way from the gathering cheer squad to talk.

"You ok?" She asked softly and Catra's two toned eyes looked so soft as she nodded.

"Yeah, Im going to drill the hell out of Glimmer until she's so sore she cant walk but Im ok," Catra said glancing over at the sparkly cheerleader talking to Sean.

"Somehow that sounds so dirty ," Adora said with a laugh, and Catra blushed as she scoffed.

"She wishes," Catra defended and Adora pulled her into a hug.

"I'm glad you're ok," Adora whispered and Catra hugged her back as the nearby cheerleaders "oooo"ed like it was something much worse than a hug.

Catra pulled away at the sound, looking ashamed before she shoved Adora's shoulder.

"Get going, dummy ," Catra said and Adora laughed as she released her and ran off to the locker room to change.

[..]

Catra was true to her word and made Glimmer do her drills three times more than everyone else. At the end of practice she was not surprised to have Glimmer huffing up to her.

"I get it if you're pissed but you could just talk about it like a normal person," Glimmer said getting in Catra' s face straight away. Catra, not to be outdone, leaned closer rather than away. She wasnt at all surprised by the pink dusting that appeared on the sparkly girls cheeks.

"You should listen to your own advice, Sparkles" Catra said in a low threatening tone. She could see Glimmer gulp as she put distance between them as she glanced down.

"Like you would be honest with me if I did," Glimmer defended as she made eye contact again.

"So you think calling me a liar in public is the way to get me to be honest with you?" Catra asked as she glared.

"It was worth a try ," Glimmer said with a shrug which annoyed Catra further.

"I cant believe you arent going to apologise for your actions, why do you care so much about my relationship?" Catra asked, using the few inches she has on Glimmer to lean over her. Glimmer blushed darker which caused Catra to smirk. "Are you hoping Im gay so you

can leave Bow?" Catra asked in a low tone and Glimmer made a small squeaking noise as she stepped away .

"No! I don't care, I only care that you are hurting Adora. If you aren't interested, you need to back off and let her find someone who is," Glimmer said with a hard glare and Catra felt her stomach turn to knots.

"That isn't your call, Adora and I can make that decision for ourselves," Catra snapped as she stepped closer again as Glimmer retreated a step.

"You're going to hurt her , you know how she feels about you. If you are just in it for the attention then you should get that from your boyfriend," Glimmer said with a glare and Catra was confused. Was she supposed to know how Adora felt about her?

"What do you mean?" Catra asked, the heat leaving her voice and Glimmer looked equally confused.

"Oh, my ga-"

"CA TRA!" Adam's voice cut Glimmer off and Catra looked up at the blond man running over to greet her. Catra looked back to where Glimmer was and realised she was gone. Catra sighed. She would track her down and strangle the information out of her if she had to.

"Hey , Teela invited us to come watch Adora's first match up in her club, want to go?" Adam asked and Catra looked over at Adora who was talking to Teela over by the edge of the field. Adora was laughing at something and covered in sweat. She hadn't changed by why would she when she was going to sweat some more.

"Yes," Catra said looking at Adora and almost missed the excited smile Adam gave her. "Something you need to tell me?" Catra asked and Adam laughed awkwardly before he rubbed the back of his neck.

"No, I'm good, lets go" He said and Catra followed him.

[..]

Catra had time to quickly shower and change so she wouldn't freeze to death in her tiny skirt and Adam did the same before they joined the Boxing club. There wasn't many people here but Catra noticed a few familiar faces. She noticed one blonde guy who looked far too slender to be punching people and wondered what he was doing here. He seemed to just be watching and offering support to two people. That made sense. They sat on the benches with the blond. Entraptra was walking around the room curiously but didn't settle near anyone.

Watching Adora move, sweat and hit people was a delightful way to end a very stressful day. Adam seemed to be enjoying himself as he

watched the fights but noticeably perked up with interest as Teela entered the ring.

Catra watched Adora as she watched Teela and she didnt seem to be watching her with anything more than friendly curiosity.

After the matches were done and the club was over, Adam talked to Teela when Catra went to talk to Adora, who was wiping sweat off her face with a towel.

"Who knew you were so good at punching people," Catra said playfully, and Adora snorted.

"Grizzlor ," she said, her cocky smile becoming visible as she removed the towel from her flushed face. Catra laughed.

"T rue, he had better shiner than you at church," Catra said playfully swatting Adora's arm. The dummy just flexed so her attack did nothing.

"I didnt know he went to your church, not a very Catholic thing to say," Adora said with a frown as Catra leaned closer .

"Oh, and what was that?" she tried to get the information and Adora looked like she almost gave it to her before glaring at her.

"Nice try ,"

"Damn, you caught me," Catra said and it came out maybe a little flirty. She couldn't help how Glimmer's words went around in her head on loop. She really needed to find out what she meant.

"Ready to go?" Teela said holding the equipment from the club and they all left together. Dropping things off in the club room, they walked with Teela to the parking lot. Teela and Adam were in a deep conversation which was now delaying them finally getting out of the cold.

Catra had her arms around herself as she trembled. She really wished she had a thicker jacket. Adam enjoyed his conversation with Teela so much that Catra didn't have it in her to separate them. Seeing her friend so happy really made her happy.

"Teela, are you busy after this?" Catra interrupted their conversation and Teela looked surprised.

"Uh, no, mums on the night shift," Teela said and Catra wondered what her mother did for a job. She nodded.

"Would you like to come study with us? We usually study at the Greyskull house after school," Catra offered and Adora snorted at

her for offering their house.

"Yeah, Im sure mum wont mind," Adam said with probably too much excitement. Teela smiled at him in a way that made Catra's stomach swoop. She looked at him the way Catra looked at Adora.

"Yeah, I would really like that," Teela said and Adam grinned.

"Great, give Linda some warning, Im not waiting for you to finish your conversation to get warm so ride with Teela," Catra said and Adam smiled at the instruction and nodded his head. Catra spun on her heel to head straight to the car.

"See you at home!" Catra said getting into the car when Adora unlocked it.

[..]

Once they were on the road Adora glanced over at Catra multiple times. Catra was slouched in her chair with her arms crossed like she was sulking. Maybe she was upset about Adam being so chatty with Teela again.

"You ok?" Adora asked softly and Catra smiled.

"Yeah, dummy, Im just freezing and it's been a long day ," Catra offered at the end. It felt like today was a whole week and she only shared half of Catra's drama today.

"At least we get to go away this weekend," Adora said thinking of the away game and the hotel room she got to share with Catra.

"Its not a holiday , it's an away game, we arent going to get time to sight-see," Catra snarked, as she hated away games. She didnt like all the sound from busy hotels when she was trying to sleep.

"A change in scenery is nice. Not to mention sharing a room with the best roommate in the world,"

"Oh did they change the rules on boys and girls sharing? Do I get to share it with Adam now?" Catra asked playfully , and it only wounded Adora's pride a little. Adora didnt turn down the normal road to get home and she saw the exact moment Catra noticed the missed turn.

"Har har , poor you, being away from your boyfriend for a night," Adora said, trying to sound playful, but even to her own ears it sounded a little bitter.

"I have literally not slept in his room since I was 15 when you and I were fighting," Catra reminded her , and Adora snorted. Adora made

it very clear she preferred Catra to stay with her if she was going to be staying over and Catra always tried to placate her.

"True, I guess you're used to sharing with me," Adora said with a shrug as they passed the turn for the long way home and headed towards the local hills.

"Ok, where are we going?" Catra asked curiously and Adora shrugged again. She was feeling a little selfish with Catra's attention tonight and for once she had an excuse to take what she wanted without seeming like a jerk.

"I just dont want to go home just yet," Adora said and Catra smirked.

"So you just decided to kidnap me?" Catra asked and Adora snorted.

"Want me to let you out and you can walk home?" She asked, glancing over at her and Catra put her hands in front of the heating.

"Absolutely not,"

"Good, so stop whining," Adora snipped and Catra made a sound which almost sounded like a whine.

"Fine, something on your mind?" She asked instead.

"Yeah, I wanted to talk to you and Adam about my counsellors appointment but I didnt want to do it in front of Teela," Adora said, it wasnt a lie, but it wasnt the whole truth. She wanted to talk about Weaver and she would never do that in front of someone else.

"Sorry about that, I should have asked first," Catra sounded slightly guilty.

"No, its fine, she's cool," Adora confirmed and Catra shrugged.

"Yeah, I didnt want to stand in the cold anymore while Adam talked about music," Catra said trying to play it off.

"Sure, its not because you like her or anything,"

"No, I dont like her ,"

"Well that sucks, I like her," Adora said as she pulled over at the lookout over Brightmoon and Catra scoffed. She looked at Adora critically but said nothing else. "I know its cold, but can we get out? You can borrow my jacket?" Adora asked and Catra nodded.

"Fine, but if I get cold, its your responsibility ," Catra threatened and Adora smiled as she reached into the back of the car for her jacket.

"Deal," she said of fering it to Catra. She was more than happy to cuddle Catra warm once she got too cold. She got out of the car and walked around the front. Catra climbed onto the hood where it was warmest and sat there to wrap the jacket around herself. She was just a little taller than Adora now and seemed to be enjoying looking down at her as she looked out at the city lights.

"What happened at the of fice?" Adora asked softly and Catra frowned.

"What happened at the Counsellors?" She asked back and Adora rolled her eyes as she started to walk back and forth in front of the car.

Catra watched her walk and huffed.

"Y ou saw most of it, they won't move me unless I talk to the Counceller,"

"And will you?" Adora asked as she glanced over and Catra scof fed.

"Why would I? They cant do anything, Im over 18," She said leaning back a little onto her hands.

"Maybe you can go straight to the police. You should find out your options, you cant keep living there," Adora defended. Her whole day felt like it was spent defending Catra and trying to work out what was going on.

"Why are you so fired up about this again? She's been chill since Ive been with Adam, besides the virgin thing she hasnt done anything crazy," Catra said and Adora nodded her head. That was true.

"You're right, but she shouldnt be able to get away with this. She shouldnt be anywhere near kids," Adora said as she stopped and stepped closer to Catra who moved her knees to allow Adora as close as she wanted without a second thought. "You deserve to be safe in your own home," Adora said softly, and Catra glared at her.

"Im not a child. Tell me about what happened with the counsellor," Catra said firmly, and Adora knew a subject change when she saw one.

"I apologised, so there won't be a mark on my record,"

"Wow, Im impressed, why the change of heart?"

"I don't know , I guess I realised I was putting our plans in jeopardy by being stubborn,"Adora said putting her hands on Catra' s knees gently when she noticed her shaking slightly.

"You are correct, Im glad you apologised,"

"I only apologised for hitting him, Id still do it again,"Adora said stubbornly and Catra laughed.

"You're an idiot,"

"I know ,"She said with a grin and Catra bit her lip.

"Do you believe what Glimmer said at lunch?"Catra asked softly . She looked so small and Adora was reminder of her anger towards Glimmer. She was trying to help but doing it the wrong way. It was none of her business.

"No,"Adora said firmly and Catra smiled a little.

"Why not?"

"Because I dont think you would lie to me," Adora said resolutely , she believed that with her entire being. Catra was a no bullshit person, she never lied to save someones feelings and she would never lie to Adora.

[..]

Adora's words were meant to be comforting but Catra felt like an ice knife through her heart. She tried to hold back the guilt that welled up in her but tears sprang to her eyes regardless.

"Adora I'm sorry." Catra said, her tears sliding down her cheeks. Adora frowned as she moved closer and wiping her tears away.

"Why are you sorry?" Adora asked as she looked into her teary eyes. Catra felt like her throat was closing and she just couldnt seem to get the words out. Adora was being so patient and gentle with her. Stroking her curls away from her face as she waited for Catra to explain. Never rushing her .

"For being such a mess" Catra sobbed softly and Adora bundled her into her arms firmly. Catra burrowed into her neck and gripped her shirt tightly.

"Hey , you're not a mess, I like you just the way you are," Adora said softly and it made Catra cry harder. She was a mess, she was lying to Adora and everyone just to make her mother happy . Weaver would never be happy, she should just move in with the Greyskulls and let Weaver try to bring her down with her. She deserved it and Adora deserved better than her.

"I just feel so hopeless," Catra sobbed into Adora's shoulder. It was almost impossible to hear the words against her neck. Adora rubbed her back and held her tight as she listened. "She's never going to care and there is nothing I can do, I just want to be free of her," Catra continued to blubber like a baby.

"You deserve better, kitten. You are so smart and you don't need her. We will do everything we can to help you get away from her and never look back," Adora whispered into her hair and Catra tried to suppress the blooming warmth that came from the stupid petname Adora had chosen.

"I don't know what to do," she sobbed,

"You'll work it out and whatever you need, day or night, I'll be there," Adora said softly and Catra shivered as her warm breath passed her ear. Adora held her closer for a little longer before Catra settled from sobbing to just tears.

After she starts to sniffle Adora takes her chin in her hand and gently lifts her face away from its hiding hole. When their eyes meet Adora's blue eyes are so soft and Catra can't help but think it's just for her.

"It will be ok," Adora said with such confidence that Catra wants to believe her with every fiber of her being.

Catra had no memory of what happened next but Adora was right there, giving her everything she ever wanted and all Catra could do was take too much. Be too much.

Catra kissed Adora and it was everything she had ever dreamed. Adora's lips were soft and perfect. It took a moment before Adora realised what was happening and even returned the kiss. It was just enough time for Catra to realise this was wrong. This was everything she ever wanted, and everything she couldn't have. Catra pulled away and Adora looked dazed with her eyes still closed.

"Fuck," Catra cursed and pushed Adora away . Adora's arms fell away from her without resistance as Catra slid off the hood with building panic. "Fuck, fuck, fuck" she said quickly and Adora had seemed to realise Catra's panic as she prepared to run.

"Wait, Catra. It's ok, it doesn't have to mean anything," Adora tired to tell her and Catra held in a sob at those words as they devastated her. Of course it didn't mean anything, because Adora didn't love her. Didn't want her . Catra's lungs started to heave to prepare for the inevitable fight or flight response.

She did what she always did and she ran.

Chapter End Notes

Annnnnd that is the last time Catra is going to run away from a situation. Isn't that exciting?

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

Something old

Chapter Notes

I'm tentatively putting a 13 chapter estimate on this fic. As long as no more chapters hit 10k we are set to finish with 13 being the epilogue.

I'm planning a seqel for Be my Cheerleader but I'll be focusing on my other AU's for a little while before I start that. I just really like the twins and Catra's friendships and SW has to get what's coming to her. :D

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was sitting on the hood of her car with her head clutched in her hands. She kissed Catra. Well, Catra kissed her, but she doesnt think that the specifics mattered. Catra was vulnerable and Adora shouldnt have let this happen. This was her fault.

She sighed angrily, allowing herself a moment of weakness to reflect. It was amazing. Her lips were still tingling from the brief touch and her head was foggy. She could admit to herself that she didnt want it to end. But she had to remind herself that Catra thought it was a mistake.

Catra looked so scared after she realised what had happened. Adora foolishly tried to convince her that this didnt have to mean anything

between them. It turned out to be a failed attempt to stop Catra from running so that they could talk about it.

Adora gripped her head tighter, pulling her blonde hair from its ponytail in the process. It meant too much to Adora just to kiss her best friend. She couldnt deny it anymore that she loved her . Just a stupid lesbian pining for her straight best friend who also happened to be dating her brother. It was so sad. It's so pathetic.

Would Catra think Adora took advantage of her vulnerable state to kiss her? It was hard to deny how Adora leaned into the kiss once she realised what was happening. The idea of pulling away never even occurred to her. Some friend she was.

Her stomach tightened in knots so hard that she might be sick. She betrayed Adam in the worst way possible. She disregarded his relationship and kissed his girlfriend. She would be lucky if he ever spoke to her again. The idea of being abandoned by her two best friends was heart wrenching. She needed to come clean, this was too big a burden to carry but she needed to speak to Catra first. This was her relationship and she should have a chance to talk to Adam first if she wanted to. Adora could do that for her at least.

Adora checked the time on her phone as her leg bounced against the front of the car. This wasnt the first time Catra had run from this particular lookout and Adora knew it took about 20 minutes to make it home. She would drive past her house on the way home to drop off her bag with Weaver and to make sure she got home safe. She wouldnt push her tonight but they needed to talk about this before she blurted something out to Adam.

[..]

Catra got home in record time. Her panic seemed to have been spent on running and prevented a full blown meltdown. She panted as she walked up the steps to her house, she reached for her keys and realised for the first time that she didnt have her bag. Which meant she also didnt have her keys, or her phone. She only had Adora's jacket keeping her warm. Weaver was going to have a field day with this one.

Catra knocked on the door and Weaver answered, frowning at her.

"Where are your keys?" Weaver asked and Catra looked down as she stepped into the house.

"I left them at the Greyskulls, and I had a fight with Adora,"

"Good, she's too good for you," Catra flinched at the comment. An ever-present reminder that she didnt deserve comfort when she was hurt. Weaver closed the door and walked back into the living room to watch TV. She didnt appear to be drinking, which was surprising to say the least.

"Dont make a lot of noise," Her mother reminded her serenely, and Catra paused in the doorway to consider if Weaver was on

something stronger. She decided to just go to her room and keep it down as she was told. Hopefully Adora would drop her bag off or she can get it at school. Maybe it would be better to just leave the country. She was just messing up everything here anyway . She could leave Adam and Adora to find love and connection without her weighing them down.

She walked down the hall to her room as she considered what she could do with Adora's jacket to get it back to her without talking. Adora will want to talk, she wasnt the best at it, but she tried. Catra opened her door and flicked on the lights for her bedroom and froze at the sight.

Everything was gone. Well, not everything. Everything that meant anything to Catra was gone. All her personal items. She quickly checked her dresser, closet and desk. She only found her school supplies and her church clothes. She held her breath as she looked into the back of her bedside table drawer, trying to find the ring Adora gave her. If Adora is not speaking to her again she would like to at least have the ring as a reminder, but she couldnt find it anywhere.

She tried to hold on to her sob as she attempted to calm herself. She might be overreacting, maybe Weaver just put all her things in storage. Maybe she could get it back if she didnt react. If W eaver thought she was being good, maybe she could earn it back. She took off Adora's jacket and quickly tidied herself up. She had to look presentable for Weaver if she was going to grovel.

She looked in the mirror, seeing nothing but a mistake as she forced a glass smile at her reflection and quietly made her way downstairs. Weaver was sitting on the couch watching the tv but turned when she heard Catra coming into the living room.

"Mother , can I ask about my room?" Catra asked, trying to be as polite as possible to get Weaver to cooperate.

"Of course, I have cleaned out the house of personal possessions as suggested by our pastor," W eaver said motioning to the bare shelves in the living room. Catra forced a smile.

"That makes sense, did you store them or donate them?" She asked softly and Weaver seemed pleased with her apparent approval.

"I donated them, and there are plenty of people more in need than us," W eaver said, getting to her feet and walking closer. Catra stubbornly stood her ground despite how her mother's looming form made her want to shy away.

"Dont you feel freer , child?" she asked as she softly touched Catra' s cheek. Catra tried to resist but the small comfort that her mother offered was like a single drop of water in the desert. She needed it, giving into the small comfort that she never deserved. She was ruining her own life so royally, all on her own. "I do," Catra agreed, trying to stop the tears from welling in her eyes. "Thank you mother ," she said and Weaver released her cheek.

"You're welcome," she said before walking back to the couch and retaking her seat. Catra silently slinked away. Returning to her now empty room she closed the door. She leaned back against the cold wood and slowly slid down until she was on the ground in the foetal position.

That was fine. She was never meant to have nice things anyway. She didn't deserve nice presents, or friends or even Adora. She would ruin them all anyway.

[...]

Adora arrived at the Weaver house with Catra's bag and knocked on the door. Weaver answered as she expected and Adora offered her the bag.

"Hi Mrs Weaver, Catra forgot her bag," Adora said, not offering any information to explain why she had it. Weaver took the bag silently as she watched Adora.

"You should stay away from Catra, if you know what's good for you," Weaver said and Adora felt her heart plummet. She didn't want to stay away from Catra. She wanted to help her and hold her and make her feel loved because she deserved it.

Weaver didn't care about Catra, Adora reminded herself, so this wasn't a warning for Catra's sake.

"I'm not going to do that," Adora said firmly, even as her insides felt like ice for talking back to a parent. Weaver frowned and her desire to be liked made her want to apologise immediately. But she wasn't sorry, so she kept her mouth shut.

"All she does is distract you, you could do so much more if you separated yourself from her and found god," Weaver said and Adora frowned. She wasn't going to talk about this.

"I have to go," Adora said awkwardly and quickly left. Weaver didn't seem bothered and closed the door.

[...]

Adora was barely in the door of the house when Adam perked up from where he was sitting on the living room floor with Teela as they studied.

"What took so long? Where's Catra? Did you guys have a fight?" Adam asked with a frown as Teela tried to politely not listen to their conversation.

"Yes, a fight, that's what happened. We fought and I took her home. She's home. I'm going to go to bed. I don't feel well." Adora rambled

and Adam looked at her with confused curiosity before Adora rushed up the stairs.

"Is she ok?" Adora heard Teela ask softly.

"I have no idea," Adam responded, sounding perplexed. Adora closed her door and hid under her blankets. She needed to work out what she was going to say to Catra tomorrow. She reached out from under her blankets to grab a notebook. She will make a list.

[..]

Catra woke up sitting against the door of her room still balled up to protect her heart. Her neck and back hurt from the awkward position while her face was puffy from crying. It seemed late, or maybe it was early. She didn't know which.

She uncurled herself and stumbled closer to her bed. She didn't know the time without her phone. It was too late to shower without waking Weaver so she changed into the only pyjamas she had left and decided she needed to wash her face at least.

She opened her door and found her bag leaning against it and it tumbled to the floor. Adora must have brought it back. The idea of her being so considerate filled Catra with guilt and dread. She pulled out her phone. It was three in the morning and there was a text from Adora.

Dummy: 10:03PM

We need to talk about this.

Catra looked at the message and her stomach tightened uncomfortably. She didnt want to talk about this. She didnt want to mention this ever again. She had kissed Adora and Adora had told her, plain and simple, that she did not feel the same way. She had done the one thing she was never meant to do. She had finally ruined everything. Like the good little screwup she was.

Catra put her phone down on her bed and went to wash her face. She set her alarms for school and curled into a ball under her blankets to try to force her body to sleep.

When she woke up again she felt almost feverish as she tried to push herself up in bed. She was severely dehydrated so she went to the bathroom to drink from the tap and get ready for school.

Weaver was in a good mood again today, clearly delighted by following her pastor's instructions. She would no doubt brag about how free and sinless she was the next time they went to church. The following week was cancelled for repairs so Weaver would have to wait two weeks to boast about giving away all her daughter's possessions.

Catra was quietly in the front seat on the drive to school as she tried to make plans for her day. She wouldn't be able to miss any more classes without the school telling Weaver, so she would need to just avoid being alone with Adora where she could try to talk about this.

She could do this. She was a much better liar than Adora was, so she just had to make sure the idiot didn't say anything incriminating in front of Adam. She can handle damage control.

[..]

Adora was a nervous wreck, she knew she was acting weird but she seemed to have completely forgotten what "acting normal" looked like. Adam had asked her several times if she was ok and after a blundering reply she had wisely decided that not speaking was a far better option.

The silent car ride to school grated on her nerves because Adam was watching her curiously, like he was trying to decipher what was going on. Adora tried to be a blank slate but knew she was twitchy.

"What did you and Catra fight about?" Adam asked curiously as they pulled into the school parking lot. Adora found a park quickly, pretending to concentrate.

"Oh, looks like we're here, don't want to be late. We can talk about this later," Adora said quickly as she got up and locked the car

before Adam even closed his door.

"Adora, come on, talk to me," he said running to catch up, and Adora just shook her head quickly and sent him a pleading look. He sighed and nodded. "Ok, fine, but you have to tell me when we get home," he said sternly and she nodded without speaking and went to her locker to get her books. Not speaking was clearly working.

"Excuse me," she said to the woman standing in front of Catra's locker as she stepped around her to get to her own. The woman looked up and Adora was shocked to see that it *was* Catra. Catra in a skirt. Catra in a skirt and a frilly blouse and cardigan. Was she wearing heels? Adora looked her up and down slowly as she could feel the heat of Catra's glare. As she reached her eyes she could see the challenge Catra had in her eyes, daring Adora to say anything about her clothing. She looked like she was going to church.

"M-morning," Adora stumbled, were Catra's lips always that pink? *Was she staring? Oh no.*

"You look so weird," Adam said, stepping up to kiss Catra on the cheek. He clearly missed the glare that told him to shut up about it. Catra turned her glare on him now.

"Weavers on a new bender and she got rid of all my clothes besides the ones I use for church," Catra said with clear disdain. Adora was a little distracted now that she wasn't being glared at. Catra's blouse

was slightly lower than her cheer uniform and Adora could see a collection of freckles on her collarbone she had never noticed before.

"Yikes, these clothes don't look anything like you," Adam said with a laugh, like it was some silly joke.

"That's how Weaver likes it, the least me, I can be," Catra said bitterly, and Adam snorted before giving her a squeeze.

"She's wrong, you're awesome. Let's get to Lit," he said, pulling her down the hall with his hand on her waist. Adora was fine with this, she was only slightly jealous. Silent, she could stop talking for one day right? Adora watched Catra getting dragged down the hall as her kitten heels clicked on the floor. Some students were staring and whispering, it was weird to see Catra like this. Catra looked even smaller in these clothes than she did last night. It was like she was afraid to take up any space at all.

Adora took her seat beside Catra at the front of the class and saw Weaver frown at her. Adora tried to ignore the glare from her teacher and went back to perfecting her plan to get Catra alone. She didn't know how long she could stop herself from bursting before they could get a chance to talk.

[...]

"Swap rooms with me," Glimmer said with conviction, and Catra blinked at her. She did not need Sparkles being annoyed today, she was already ready to bite someone's head off. Her shoes hurt, her shirt was too thin and she was freezing in this skirt. She was ready to kill.

"No, Im not bunking with Mermista. We would kill each other," Catra said, glancing at Mermista who smirked down the lunch table.

"Yeah we would, kitty," Mermista said and Catra glared at her. Seriously considering if she could take Mermista. She could probably hold her own in a verbal lashing but she didnt stand a chance if the football player decided to throw down.

"Dont call me that," she scolded regardless. She felt like her agency was continuing to be stripped from her over the last 24 hours, but she could fight to not be called stupid nicknames by meathead jocks.

"Only blondie can call you that, right?" Mermista said in a bored tone as Catra blushed. She did not need to think about Adora right now. She had already replayed the slow gaze she had received from the blonde this morning every hour leading up till this moment. She wanted to know if Adora liked this clothing, did she like it when Catra wasnt herself too? She didnt seem to hate them the way Catra did.

"Come onnn," Glimmer whined and Catra clenched her jaw. "I want to bunk with Adora at an away game just once before we graduate. I

want to do makeovers!" Glimmer said with pleading eyes and clear enthusiasm to makeover the blonde.

"One, you could just have a normal sleepover with her , not at a school thing, two, she doesnt like makeovers," Catra said counting her fingers. Already tired of defending her place as Adora's best friend to her second best friend.

"She doesnt like *you* makeovers, Im sure I can find something she likes. Maybe your style isnt gay enough for her ," Glimmer said playfully, and Catra scowled at her. She wanted to bite back but what could she really say? She wasnt openly gay so she wisely kept her mouth shut.

"Who' s not gay enough for Catra?" Adam asked as he sat down with his lunch on her left.

"That is **not** what she said," Catra glared and Adam grinned as if he knew that. He was being a real pain today but she was pretty sure he was trying to cheer her up with his stupidity. Usually that would work but when her whole life is on fire it takes a little more than that to make her smile.

"Hey Cat, can I talk to you?" Adora asked from behind her , and Catra put her shoulders up defensively.

"No," She didn't even spare a glance at Adora. She still heard Adora's soft sigh which filled her to the brim with guilt.

"Oh! Adora, convince Catra to swap rooms with me so we can have a sleepover," Glimmer said, changing her tactic and jumping to the blonde. Catra watched Adora looking awkward as she rubbed the back of her neck from the corner of her eye.

"Uh, no" she said unconvincingly . Catra was surprisingly relieved that Adora didn't want to change rooms either . Maybe their kiss wasn't as world ending as Catra thought it was. Maybe they could ignore her stupid feelings and just go back to being best friends. Then Catra could die alone like she was always meant to.

"Come onnn. You two have sleepovers all the time. I want to do makeovers," Glimmer whined again, using the same excuse.

"We can have a sleepover whenever you want too, Glim, but not at the away game. Do a makeover with Mermista," Adora said and Mermista snorted.

"Absolutely not, you can't improve on perfection," Mermista drawled, waving her hand dismissively. Glimmer nodded her head in agreement as she clasped her hands together and turned back to Adora.

"Exactly , let me help you Adora," Glimmer whined and Adora snorted.

"I'm not opposed to it, I just don't want to change rooms," Adora said defensively. Catra tried to hide the smile that grew on her face. Adora wanted to stay with Catra, even if they were weird right now. It was a familiar comfort to them both in an unfamiliar place.

"Why not?" Glimmer demanded as she huffed.

"Because, I don't want to deal with your snoring," Adora said and Glimmer gasped like this was the worst insult imaginable.

"Ooo," Mermista deadpanned, watching the exchange with renewed interest.

"I don't snore!" Glimmer huffed, looking offended.

"You might! I don't know! I know what to expect with Catra, so drop it," Adora defended, her voice raising as it became much more firm and Glimmer grumbled.

"Fine" Glimmer huffed and Adora finally went to collect her lunch. Catra watched her leave and ensured that when Adora returned that Catra was long gone.

[..]

Adora was getting tired of this cat and mouse game she had been playing all day. She had tried several times to talk to Catra, even asking at lunch so it didnt interrupt their classes. She was nice, polite and so patient every time. She was giving Catra space but she was chasing her. Her anxiety was only creeping higher as the day went on.

Her last attempt to speak to Catra after their last class was denied so Adora did something very uncharacteristic. She was filled with so much frustration at Catra's repeated denial and simply grabbed her by the arm. Catra looked so shocked that she didnt fight Adora when she was pushed into an empty classroom with the door locked behind them.

"What the fuck Dor ,"Catra snapped once she recovered from her shock and twisted out of Adora's hold.

"W e need to talk about this,"Adora said firmly , her heart going a mile a minute as she tried to hold onto her wits. She didnt want to manhandle Catra like that, and losing control like that scared her a little. She leaned back against the door of the classroom to pin her hands behind her back as a safety precaution.

Catra huffed and rubbed her arm and Adora felt guilty for being too rough. She knew she was high strung, and she wasnt trying to hurt

Catra, but she just needed to come clean to Adam so she could breathe again. She felt like she was a hair away from a panic attack since this all started.

"I'm sorry if I hurt you. I didn't mean to. It's not fair to just ignore me when I want to fix the problem," Adora said more gently this time as she tried to relax her racing heart.

"There is no problem. It's like you said, it didn't mean anything, so there isn't an issue." Catra said as she crossed her arms defensively, her voice sounding raw. Was Catra as stressed about this as Adora was? Of course she was, this was Catra's relationship that Adora was ruining. There was really only one logical way forward.

"We need to tell Adam," Adora said and Catra's eyes widened in panic.

"What! No, we can't tell him," Catra said firmly.

"He deserves to know," and Adora didn't want to keep this from him. There was no logical reason to lie to Adam about this. He was understanding and he knew they were close. He would understand Catra being confused about her sexuality or looking for comfort. Adora felt so guilty that she didn't just take Catra home to Adam. She should have released how upset she really was.

"It meant nothing and if you tell him he will just break up with me, is that what you want?" Catra asked. A guilty part of Adora *did* want that. She hated that Adam was with Catra. It was stupid because even if Catra was single she didn't want Adora that way anyway.

"No, Cat. I just want you to be happy. I don't want to make your life harder. I just can't keep a secret like this from him" Adora said, stepping closer to Catra to try to convince her that she was being honest. Catra glared up at her, looking small and afraid and it pulled on Adora's heart strings. She needed to convince Catra before she crumbled like a house of cards.

"Why not! He keeps secrets from you. Please don't tell him." Catra spoke a little frantically as she begged. Adora felt her gut twist at the idea that Adam was keeping things from her, or didn't trust her to take something well. She didn't like to keep secrets from him, but if he wanted to keep secrets from her, then she couldn't stop him.

"That's his choice, and this is mine. I want to tell him," Adora said stubbornly and Catra made a noise that almost sounded like a growl.

"You are so stubborn when you think you are doing the right thing! It didn't mean anything and it will never happen again, so there is no need to say anything," Catra argued and Adora's stomach swooped at the confirmation. She nodded her head solemnly. "If you want me to be happy, that will make me happy," Catra begged softly, seeing that Adora's resolve was cracking.

Catra’s eyes were big and shining with tears. She looked so afraid and Adora couldnt convince herself to do something she knew would hurt Catra in the process. It was Adora’s fault after all, she made this mess. Adora let out a long breath and nodded her head.

“Ok, I won't tell him,” Adora agreed and Catra looked so relieved she almost cried. She stepped closer to wrap her arms around Adora in a grateful hug. Adora returned the embrace, cocooning her in her arms protectively as she pulled Catra close. She was a terrible liar, this was a terrible idea. Her only hope to successfully keep this secret was to avoid talking about it with Adam. She hid her face is Catra’s hair as she held her a little longer.

She could do this.

For Catra.

[..]

Catra was barely inside the Grayskull house when she started explaining what W eaver had done the night before. Catra was so depressed that all her lovely birthday gifts were gone.

“I cant believe her , I should have left them here. She's been so weird lately.” Catra said in frustration as she pulled her things out of her bag. Adam and Adora were watching her attentively but not

commenting. Catra was on a roll and they knew better than to interrupt.

"All your old jerseys that I stole, they are all gone!" Catra said sadly and Adam gasped.

"She admitted it" Adam whispered and Adora snickered. This was very serious but it had also been almost five years of Catra adamantly denying stealing their clothing. The cat is out of the bag apparently.

"My ring!" She said with a pout at Adora who smiled softly .

"I'll get you another one," Adora of fered and Catra huffed, it wasn't the point. She wanted her stuff back. It was stupid to be so attached, but it was her stuff and she thought she had a say in what happened to it. What a stupid thing to believe.

"You got her a ring?" Adam asked Adora curiously and the other blonde flushed.

"I -yeah, so?" she asked, sounding defensive, and Adam just shrugged.

"I am just surprised, I got her really nice tequila that she has to share with us or Ill cry ," Adam said looking at Catra with a challenging gaze. Catra snorted.

"Well that's gone too, so I guess I cant share it," Catra said, opening her book and silence falling around them. Catra was still angry but getting it off her chest had helped.

"Maybe we could check the local donation places, you know we would be happy to help you buy your stuff back," Adora offered and Catra smiled.

"Yeah, it's for a good cause too. So we should try," Adam agreed and Catra smiled a little wider. She was so lucky to have such supportive friends.

[..]

Catra left at 9PM that night as usual and Adam turned to Adora immediately.

"So, you guys are ok now?" he asked, clearly worried, and Adora refused to meet his eye. She could feel the swell of guilt and shuffled in her seat.

"Yeah, we talked about it. It's fine" she said, which was true. She stared at her homework pages and erased something she didn't need, just to have something to do. She couldn't seem to look Adam in the eyes right now.

"Ok good, and there's nothing else I should know about?" Adam asked, clearly curious what had happened but not wanting to pry. Maybe he should pry. Didn't he care?

"N-no, nothing else." Adora stumbled as her gut turned uncomfortably. She hated lying to him. Somehow it almost felt worse than when she and Catra fought. Almost.

"Ok, good. Want to play some Mario Kart?" Adam asked and Adora smiled.

"Yeah!" She agreed and put her homework away just to enjoy her time with her brother.

[..]

Catra arrived home after a long day on Wednesday. She dragged her feet and was ready to fall into bed, but she needed to get her homework done so she was able to enjoy her time away with her friends on the weekend. She adjusted her backpack on her shoulder as she turned on the lights. It was only nine but there was no sign of Weaver downstairs.

Catra frowned but headed for the stairs to get back to studying. She walked past the archway to the dining room and paused. The dining table was missing. Weaver was really taking this advice to the extreme.

They barely used the dining table so it wouldnt be missed but it was still odd. Catra walked to her room, turning on and off the lights as she went. She could hear Weavers whispering prayers before bed and hurried into her room. She did not want to deal with her right now if she could help it.

[..]

Adora had to actively remind herself to keep eye contact with Catra when she spoke. It wasnt ok for her to watch her mouth and every time it happened she felt a spike of embarrassment and shame fill her.

If she thought it was hard to focus before the kiss, she had been mistaken, because now her focus was almost non-existent.

She had managed to convince herself by Thursday that she didnt need to tell Adam because it wasnt her secret. She was keeping a secret for Catra and it was Catra’s choice when she wanted to share it. Once she had made this realisation she could almost act normal again.

Making eye contact with Adora? Check. Staring over whole sentences? Check. Staring at Catra's soft lips? Eh, working on it.

Glimmer in all her magical glory appeared out of nowhere near Adora's locker after school. She already had Catra's wrist tightly clamped in her hand. Catra looked a mix between shocked and concerned so it put Adora on edge.

Glimmer was on a mission, it would seem. Adora finished closing her bag and shut her locker. She turned to Glimmer and smiled.

"Hey Glimmer , how are you?" Adora tried for casualness but Catra's clearly startled expression was doing a number on her nerves. Did something happen?

"No time for that, let's go!" Glimmer demanded and grabbed Adora to yank her down the hallway. Adora stumbled, she knew she could probably stop Glimmer if she really wanted to. She was much bigger and stronger and if she stopped walking there wasn't much that the five foot woman could do about it.

But Catra was coming, so it couldn't be too bad, right?

“Glimmer , where are we going?” Catra hissed as they got outside and Glimmer proceeded to drag both girls to her pink jeep and force them into the back seat together. Catra flopped into Adora and blushed as she scrambled to get off her.

“Sorry ,” She muttered as she tried to get her hair back under control. Adora blushed but only nodded. She was certain that if she said anything it would be something stupid like “you can sit in my lap anyday” or worse, just stare at her mouth like a moron with only one brain cell.

Glimmer got into the front seat and pulled out of the school parking lot with very little consideration for the road rules. Adora quickly buckled herself in and Catra did the same.

“Are we being kidnapped?” Catra asked as she crossed her arms and huffed. Adora laughed and Glimmer just snorted.

“Obviously ,” Glimmer agreed and Adora chuckled again. There was worse fates than hanging out with her two best friends. Catra and Glimmer rarely tolerated each other long enough for outings. Glimmer must have been feeling in a giving mood.

Adora decided to sit back and wait to find out where they were going. They were heading for the other side of town so it must be something special.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Something new

Chapter Notes

This is the second half of chapter 9 because it was a 1 1k le chonk. Enjoy the double update!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra jumped down from the jeep as they arrived at their location. It was a donation store that saved money for the homeless through their sales. She looked at Glimmer a little gobsmacked.

"A little birdy told me your stuf f ended up here," Glimmer said, preening under her own excellence. Catra couldn't fault her , this was amazing. She tried to hold back the prickling in her eyes under the kind gesture.

"Thanks," Catra forced out and Glimmer smiled softly at her . Adora stepped out of the car behind them and groaned loudly.

"Shopping?! I thought there would be food," Adora pouted like a child and Catra giggled as Adora stuck out her full lower lip. Catra's attention snagged on it and she felt a thrill run down her spine.

"Right, let's go. W e can get food after," Glimmer grabbed them both again and dragged them into the shop. Adora was putting on quite a show but Catra was well aware that she didn't hate shopping as much as she wanted people to think.

The three of them walked around the shop, finding things that were definitely Catra's. She was much pickier with her belongings the second time. Just picking up things that really held meaning to her.

Glimmer was looking through the racks of clothing while Adora was quietly looking at the jewellery like an incredibly suspicious woman.

Catra snuck up on Adora and leaned over the cabinet.

"Find anything?" Catra asked a little louder than necessary , making Adora jump. Adora glared at her .

"No, nothing," Adora said, looking away . Adora was a terrible liar, but Catra let her have her secrets. She secretly hoped Adora had found the ring to surprise her a second time.

"That's a bummer , I really miss that ring," Catra said theatrically as she pouted and rested her hand on her cheek.

"You should join me in the drama club, you're a natural," Glimmer said with a smirk as she approached with two jerseys in her hand. Catra perked up.

"Did you find some?" Catra asked and Glimmer nodded.

"I couldn't find any of Adam's, he's kind of a normal size for a guy, but I found two of Adora's. One of her home game ones from junior year and an away game one from last year," Glimmer said looking at the jerseys before Catra grabbed them.

"Hey! Don't snatch," Glimmer scolded.

"You're the best," Catra said excitedly, relieved to have at least Adora's jerseys back. Catra kissed Glimmer aggressively on the cheek and Glimmer whined petulantly.

"Gross!" Glimmer said but her blushing cheeks told another story. Catra giggled and went to the clothes racks to look around. She found a few other items of hers which filled her with relief. This was a good outing. She really owed it to Glimmer.

"So," Glimmer started to her right and Catra looked up at her leading tone. Adora was across the store talking to one of the staff and Catra realised far too late. *Oh, this is a trap*

"I take it back," Catra said looking back at the clothing as Glimmer squawked in protest. "What are you up to?" Catra asked, giving Catra a suspicious look. Glimmer huffed and crossed her arms.

"I'm not up to anything!" Glimmer whisper shouted and it was all the confirmation Catra needed that she didn't want Adora to hear this conversation.

"Fine, go on," Catra said and put the clothing she found together with the rest of her collection.

"Is Adora ok?" Glimmer asked, looking at a sparkly top on the rack. Catra glanced over to the blonde who was still talking to the staff member and frowned.

"Yeah, I think so. Why?" Catra said with not much confidence. Was she missing something?

"She's just been really spacy all week. Like how she gets when you two are fighting, but you guys are good, right?" Glimmer asked curiously as she looked Catra in the eye. Catra tried to hide her shame at the interrogation.

"Yeah. We are. We're good." Catra tried to swallow the lump in her throat as Glimmer hummed in consideration. Adora's heavy footsteps alerted them both to her return and the subject was quickly dropped.

[..]

Adora was at the dinner table with her family,which included Catra. She was shoving food into her mouth like she hadnt eaten in days but really she just wanted to beat Adam for a second helping.

"Catra, how's W eaver?" Adora' s mum asked and Adora almost breathed in mash potato. She coughed, managing to cover her mouth as her Dad hit her on the back.

"Breath, girl!" he joked and Adora chugged some water to help her recover. Catra was shifting uncomfortably as she bit her pink lower lip. *Oh, I dont look*

"Um, she's ok, I think. She's kind of on a weird minimalism kick at the moment" Catra said, shrugging her shoulders.

"What do you mean dear?" Linda asked and Adora watched the conversation like it was a ping pong game.

"Sheuh.. She got rid of all our personal stuf f and the dining table" Catra said with a frown and Adora's parents exchanged a confused look.

"Did she get rid of all your belongings?" Linda asked curiously and Catra nodded.

"Yeah, I just have my school stuff and church clothes," Catra said with disgust as she flicked the collar of the high neck blouse she was wearing. It was the furthest thing from Catra's style that it could be.

"I'm sorry dear. It's making me cold just looking at you! How about I take us shopping this weekend? You can keep some clothes here just in case," Linda offered and Adora made a face. "How does that sound?" Linda asked and looked between the two girls. Catra looked ecstatic and Adora stopped to think about it. She could enjoy shopping if she got to watch Catra trying on cute outfits.

"Sounds good," Adora agreed and Catra beamed as Adora shoved more mash potato into her mouth.

[...]

The bus was full with people with both the football team and the cheerleading squad cramped onto one bus for the drive. They had been sectioned into pairs for seating and sleeping arrangements so Adora was sitting on the aisle seat while Catra sat enjoying the sun in the window seat.

Catra was so tired. She had to get up early on a Saturday so she had plans to nap for as much of the journey as she could. Adora

would make a sturdy pillow and keep her from falling off her chair or something.

She yawned and Adora smiled at her which only made her heart race. They were waiting for the last of the stragglers before finally setting off. Catra had bundled up in her new jacket that Linda had bought her. She loved shopping with Adora, she could read the blonde's face like an open book until she found something to make her blush. Catra got a few outfits that were cute and functional for school but the leather jacket had made Adora' s jaw drop, so she had to get it.

Adora was fidgeting in her seat to get comfortable and Adam turned in his seat to talk to them. His roomie was Bow so it was nice to have him to talk to on the trip.

"Are they still waiting for Sean?" Adam asked Adora and she nodded. She had been watching the trip supervisors closely for any instructions like a good girl scout.

"He's always late, he probably set fire to that stupid muscle car he has," Mermista said drolly behind them and Glimmer snorted.

"That thing is a fire hazard, it shoots sparks out the exhaust!" Glimmer said and Catra smirked.

"Sean is a hazard, it's not the car's fault," Catra said, looking between the chairs to see Glimmer who just stuck her tongue out at her.

Catra had been trying to be nicer to Glimmer since she helped her out but she couldn't ignore how Glimmer seemed to hover . She always seemed to be nearby while Catra was with Adora at school.

It took another ten minutes before Sean arrived on the bus to booing from the team which only caused him to start telling his epic tale while he sat in his chair.

Catra was already snuggled into Adora's shoulder to nap by the time he arrived and barely flinched at the loud reception. Adora was playing a game on her phone so she didn't move too much and disturb Catra. It was very considerate.

"Is she asleep already?" Adam asked in a whisper and Adora moved a little.

"I think so, or close to it at least," Adora whispered back.

"Are you feeling ready for the game? The horde is hard to beat on their home turf," Adam said softly and Adora snorted.

"I'm not worried, we got this," Adora said in a cocky tone. Catra slowly lulled into sleep under the whispered conversation of her two favourite people.

[..]

Victory! They won. Adora kicked the winning goal and the team converged on her before she even had time to understand. It was over! They won.

Adora was crushed under the weight of her team's excitement. Distantly she could hear the excitement of the crowd and the screaming chants of the cheerleaders. Adora managed to peek out of her team hug to see Catra doing her best to make the most noise she could. Their eyes met and Adora's stomach flipped as Catra mouthed her "congratulations" to her .

Adora felt her face heat with a blush and returned her attention back to her team and their celebrations.

After the game they showered and celebrated with pizza and Adora even splurged and got a beer to toast with those of her team who were of drinking age.

The night went on before the exhaustion finally caught up with the team, full of food and drinks they were ready to retire. The team had

booked almost a whole level of hotel rooms and Adora walked with her friends to their rooms before her and Catra retired to their room.

Alone.

Adora was feeling weirdly nervous, she was buzzing with a soft cloudy feeling in her head as she changed into her pyjamas while Catra changed in the bathroom. She climbed into one of the single beds they had pushed together while she waited for Catra to come out.

[..]

Catra was so nervous, she shouldn't have had that beer. She couldn't seem to shake the fluffy feeling in her head that made her want to cuddle the hell out of her friends. Her main focus being Adora.

Everyone was nervous in the lead up to the game and seeing the team so relaxed after winning was like an endorphins rush to her brain. She was so proud of them all and she is sure she screamed so loudly she almost lost her voice.

She loved how carefree and happy Adora got after achieving something she thought was impossible. She was so cocky and playful and it was so very hot. Catra had been standing in her pyjamas for over a minute now. The idea of going back to Adora in

the other room and sharing the joint bed which they pushed together in their giggly excitement filled her with butterflies.

How was she going to keep it together when all she wanted was to bury herself safely in Adora's chest and soak in all her cocky attention?

Maybe Glimmer was right and Catra should have swapped with her, she knew for a fact that she would never attempt to snuggle Mermista. She took some deep breaths and decided to just bite the bullet and knock on the door.

"I'm decent," Adora called in response, and Catra let herself into the room again with a snort.

"That's a lie," Catra said, trying to sound casual. Adora snorted in response and the sight of her in bed with the blankets turned down for Catra on her side of the bed filled her with warmth. She climbed under the blankets and settled to face Adora.

Adora rolled to face her as she settled in after the light was turned off. The slight rise of the joint mattresses between them felt like a great mountain range they had to cross.

Adora was watching Catra with curious eyes, like she was trying to work out some important mystery. Catra was freezing on her side of

the bed and her need to be warm was sufficient motivation to cross the gap between the beds.

Catra awkwardly crawled. Once Adora realised she was coming over she lifted her blankets and shuffled back to make room for her. Catra carefully flopped into Adora's open arms and snuggled into her insanely warm body.

"It's freezing in that bed," Catra muttered into Adora's chest and she felt her chuckle.

"Mines nice and warm," she said like it wasn't completely her doing. Catra snorted.

"Duh, because you're a heater, I'm not putting up with being cold all night," Catra grumbled and Adora's hand gently rubbed up and down her back to warm her.

"You don't need an excuse you know," Adora said close to her ear, and Catra felt completely called out. She looked up at Adora's face and her eyes were closed. There was barely any light in the room except from under the door from the hallway. She could only just make out her outline. As Catra stared at Adora's peaceful face her blue eyes opened and looked back at Catra.

"It's not an excuse," Catra denied and Adora smiled almost patiently.

I know , I just mean, if you thought you needed one,"Adora said as her hand distracted Catra by running slowly up and down her back. It made her want to shiver at the soft contact.

"You're my best friend Catra, Im always here for you,"Adora said softly "Whatever you need,"Adora assured and Catra felt her hands bunch into Adora's sleep shirt without her input. She was looking at Adora's lips now and she heard Adora's breath hitch softly.

"Same,"she forced out, swallowing thickly as her brain seemed to leave the building. She wiggled, suddenly feeling uncomfortable in her own skin as she moved closer to Adora. Was Adora moving closer too? She glanced up at Adora' s eyes and they were so dark as she watched Catra's mouth in return. She was so focused and all Catra wanted to do was kiss her stupid.

Catra couldnt tell if she was projecting her desire to kiss Adora on the blonde, but she looked just as enchanted by the idea. The first soft, warm press of their lips was breathtaking and everything Catra wanted. It set her soul on fire and she burned so hot she didnt need these covers to keep her warm. All she needed was Adora.

Catra tried not to groan at the contact when Adora's hands tightened around her waist and she was pulled impossibly closer. There was no denying it this time. Adora was kissing her back with a passion Catra hadnt given her time to show in their last kiss. Catra pulled at Adora's collar like she could get the blonde any closer and Adora leaned into her body.

When they finally parted for air they barely moved apart. Breathing the same air as they recovered from the experience. Adora’s eyes were still closed so Catra took the opportunity to admire the soft flush on Adora’s cheeks. All Catra wanted was to kiss her again, her hands tangled in Adora’s shirt pulling her closer again. Adora came without much coaxing and just before they collided again Catra knew she had to say something.

"This doesnt mean anything," Catra whispered and Adora pulled back to make eye contact. Her eyes widened slightly and she bit her lip like she was thinking. She looked carefully at Catra’s face and she tried to make it a blank slate so it wouldnt tell her secrets.

Adora’s eyes softened a little as she seemed to accept those words. She leaned closer to Catra and she gasped softly.

"Ok," Adora said resolutely, and Catra slid her hands up to cup her face before she dragged her in for another passionate kiss.

[..]

Catra was relieved when she was dropped home by the bus. She only had a few hours before the victory party at Glimmer's house. Catra living at almost the end of the dropoff meant the twins and Catra were the last to be dropped off.

Catra waved to the twins before she left the bus and went to the house. It was dark and silent as she had come to expect lately. She let herself in and headed for the stairs.

She usually wouldnt bother to look around but she glanced into the living room and noticed the TV and couch were missing. Catra paused and stared at the blank room. The paint was a different colour behind where the couch had been pressed to the wall for the last 10 years.

She felt a sinking hollowness enter her chest. It was a strange feeling, like a part of her was being given away without her permission. It wasnt even just the stuff being gone, it was that her mother didnt care to tell her at all. Her opinion mattered so little to the woman that the thought never even crossed her mind.

Catra stepped into the living room and touched the bright paint unaffected by the sun damage afflicting the rest of the room. It was almost pretty to see the shadows of the missing items on the walls, to see the room bare and ready for something new.

She went upstairs, unable to tell if her mother was even home. It was Saturday afternoon so she might still be out running errands. Catra rushed through getting her things together to go get ready at the Greyskulls.

[..]

Catra was getting ready in Adora's room while the twins waited downstairs for her to finish. Adora was rocking on her feet and laughed a little dryly.

"Man, I need a drink," Adora said softly and Adam laughed.

"I can be the deso driver if you wanna have a couple, I dont mind. I still feel a bit dicey after drinking too much after the game," Adam offered as he picked some lint off his dress jacket. His jacket was from a nicer suit but he wore a dark t-shirt underneath to dress it down. He wore dark blue jeans and sneakers to finish off the look. He looked nice, but a little dressed up for a party.

Adora was wearing her letterman, a white t-shirt and light blue jeans with some rips down the front. It was comfortable on the outside to counteract the knots in her stomach.

If she thought she had it bad after kissing Catra once, making out with her in a bed with some light petting was never going to leave her brain in this lifetime.

Catra came downstairs and Adora had to refrain from openly ogling her. She wore tight black jeans with rips down her thighs and a tight red turtleneck with a diamond cutout on the chest. Over the top Catra was wearing her leather jacket that had Adora blushing in the store when she first tried it on. There was something so hot about that jacket. It would suit Catra' s new bike so well.

"Ready , let's go!" Catra said, bouncing of f the last step into the hallway.

"Y ou look nice," Adam commented as he led them out to the car . Catra rolled her eyes and grinned.

"Thanks, babe," Catra said mockingly and Adam made a face at her . Adora tried to ignore them and got in the back seat to let Catra sit up front while Adam drove them to Glimmers.

As soon as Adora arrived at the party she split from Adam and Catra. She needed some space from temptation so she went to find Glimmer and Bow in the already full party.

Glimmer yelled loudly as soon as she saw Adora, clearly a few drinks in already. Adora was keen to catch up and quickly accepted the liquid of fered to her. It smelt like sugar syrup and vodka but she drank it despite the horrible taste.

Bow arrived a moment later with another drink and offered it to Adora. She sipped this one. Bow was clearly more sober than Glimmer and his concoction tasted nice.

"That game was so good, I cant believe we won against the Horde on their home turf!" Bow said, with a victorious noise. Adam came into the kitchen and returned the sound before high five Bow. Glimmer rolled her eyes.

"Men, come dance with me!" Glimmer pleaded and Adora shook her head.

"I need at least three more of these before that' s gonna happen," Adora said and Glimmer grinned wickedly.

Adora should have realised that she had gone too hard to fast right out of the gate but she really didnt care at that point when Glimmer and her were dancing on the makeshift dance floor in the middle of her living room. Her furniture was all pushed back against the walls to make the space and the flashing lights and big speakers were all she needed to get lost in the rhythm.

She was barely conscious of Glimmer saying she was going to get them more drinks and slip off the dance floor. Adora could see Mermista to her right dancing with Sean and other couples pairing off when the music changed.

Adora suddenly felt embarrassed to be alone on the dancefloor and was preparing to leave when a warm body pushed up against her.

She looked down in surprise and Catra grinned up at her. The sight of her was almost sobering. She needed to not be near Catra while intoxicated or she was going to do something stupid like kiss her , or pin her to a wall or something. Adora's nervous laugh captured Catra's attention and she looked up in confusion.

"Want to get a drink?" Adora asked, trying to put some distance between their bodies. Catra was too close and her skin felt like fire. She was sure her fluster was obvious since she felt bright red. She had ditched her jacket long ago but she was still burning up.

"Don't you want to dance with me?" Catra asked with a pout and Adora's full attention moved to her mouth. This was bad, so bad. She could barely remember why she shouldn't kiss Catra and it was horrifying to feel so out of control.

"Maybe later, I need some air," Adora said, quickly ducking away. She walked past Glimmer when she came back out of the kitchen two drinks. Glimmer yelled after her but Adora ignored her. She went out the back door to the patio. She leaned on the bannister and took a few breaths. It was freezing out here but it helped to sober her up plenty.

She closed her eyes to take a few breaths before leaning on her forearms on the railing and resting her forehead against her arms.

She couldn't keep doing this. She needed to come clean about her feelings. She couldn't keep kissing Catra knowing it meant nothing and Adam didn't know. Adora promised Catra that she wouldn't tell Adam about the kiss, but she could tell him about her feelings. At least he would know, and she could tell Catra and try to distance herself to get over it. She couldn't cut her out without telling her. It wasn't fair.

"It's freezing out here," Catra's soft voice came from behind her. Adora pushed herself upright to turn to face her.

"It's not so bad," Adora said, crossing her arms over her disagreeing nipples before Catra noticed. Not that she would be looking, of course. Catra rolled her eyes and handed Adora her jacket.

"Thanks," Adora said, uncrossing her arms and taking the jacket. Catra's eyes flicked down as Adora covered herself and her body warmed under the gaze.

"You should go back inside," Adora said, leaning back against the railing as she found a pot plant to stare at to avoid eye contact.

"You should stop avoiding me," Catra responded and stepped closer. Adora glared at the poor little succulent and huffed.

"I'm not avoiding you," Adora lied. She had been quite obviously leaving conversations and entire rooms as soon as Catra arrived all evening. She needed to avoid her right now because her self control could only take so much. With such vivid memories of Catra's lips in her mind and the feeling of her body burnt into her hands she just couldn't keep herself in check.

"Then come dance with me," Catra asked, raising one eyebrow in the cutest expression in existence. Adora swallowed loudly, wishing she had grabbed that drink from Glimmer on her way past.

"Please Catra I...need you to stay away," Adora said, her voice cracking with desperation. She didn't know why she chose those words to communicate her distress but the hurt look that flashed across Catra's eyes was painful.

"Why? Just tell me what I did to make you angry with me?" Catra said, looking up at Adora with big worried eyes and Adora cracked so easily under the pressure.

"I'm not angry with you, Catra. I've just been drinking, and if you don't leave me alone right now I'm going to kiss you," Adora said, her honesty too raw.

Catra gasped and stared like a deer in a headlight. She doesn't leave immediately so Adora's drunk brain decides to reach for her. Maybe one kiss would be ok, they were alone here. Her hand touches Catra's hip gently and it startles the brunette into action.

Catra quickly departs, leaving through the door back into the house. Adora let out a long sigh as she slouched like her heart was deflating. Everything was hurting. She knew what she had to do. She had to take steps to fortify and protect her heart, before she lost it for good.

[..]

The rest of the party was a big blur. She remembers going back inside and chugging the drain cleaner concoction that Glimmer gave her. After that point she only remembered a few things. Dancing under the lights, Glimmer singing to the music and dancing with Catra. Adora was pretty sure she was dancing with them but she was transfixed by the movement of Catra' s hips to the music. She remembers Adam taking them home with Catra cuddled up to her side in the back seat after fighting Adora to put on her seat belt. Catra helped her into bed and Adora remembered trying to undress in front of the brunette.

She groaned in embarrassment as she snuggled into her pillows. She suddenly noticed she wasnt alone in her bed and looked over her shoulder to see who was spooning her. She was never the little spoon. She was surprised to see Catra sleeping with her face squished against Adora' s shoulder blade and her blood running hot.

She was so hung over and was coming to consciousness as she realised she wasnt wearing her pyjamas either . She was wearing her underwear and sports bra. Catra's arm was around her torso and her palm laid flat against Adora's bare abs. She needed to get out of this position quickly and get some water before she died.

She wiggled and Catra groaned softly in protest before tightening her arm around her waist. Adora moved again and Catra mumbled against her back. Adora paused to try to hear her.

"Stop moving, you're not allowed to lay on your back or you might die," Catra grumbled softly , clearly half asleep still.

"I'm awake, I just need water ," Adora whispered back, her blush burning her cheeks painfully.

"Oh," Catra said softly and rolled onto her back to release Adora. Adora sat up, holding the blankets against her chest. She was feeling weirdly self conscious after her actions the night before.

Admitting to Catra that she wanted to kiss her, trying to undress in front of her. Not to mention the things she didn't remember.

"What's the time?" Adora asked and Catra rolled over. She was wearing one of Adora's shirts but Adora could see a glimpse of her bare legs under the blankets.

"Uhh, Eleven" Catra said, rubbing her eyes.

"It's Sunday!" Adora said with shock and Catra rolled onto her back again.

"Yeah dummy," Catra said affectionately as she stretched. Adora tried not to focus on the way her back arched or the peaks of her chest in Adora's shirt.

"You don't have to go to church?" Adora asked, stupefied. She looked away quickly when Catra cracked her eyes open. Catra chuckled softly.

"They are doing some kind of renovation so they aren't having mass this week," Catra said with a shrug. Adora peaked at her again from the corner of her eye to see Catra had closed hers again.

"So, you planned to stay over?" Adora asked and Catra nodded.

"Yeah, didn't Adam tell you?" Catra asked, wiggling around to find a more comfortable spot. "Lay down or get up, you're letting the heat out of the blankets," Catra complained and Adora scrambled to her feet. Somehow not stepping on Catra in her haste.

Adora did forget her level of undress though and blushed as Catra's eyes ranked over her body before closing again.

"Maybe put some clothes on before you go get water," Catra said with a playful smirk on her lips as she settled back into bed.

"Uh, good, yes, I can do that. Uhh," Adora said looking around like she forgot where her clothes lived. Catra was ignoring her now to get

more sleep and Adora pulled on track pants and a hoodie to go down to the kitchen and get some water.

As she arrived in the kitchen her mum was there unpacking the things she got from the farmers market and smiling brightly at her daughter.

"She lives!" Her mum said with delight and Adora ducked her head in embarrassment.

"W as I really that bad?" Adora asked and Linda chuckled.

"Y ou were fine pumpkin, you just worried Catra. Y ou should pace yourself better," Linda reminded her and Adora nodded. She went to the fridge and got out a cold bottle of water. She chugged it until it gave her a brain freeze and suf fered for a few seconds before it passed.

"Sorry Mum, it was just a relief to have that game over with, we can go to the semi-finals now," Adora said with a shy smile and Linda grabbed her by the face to plant a wet kiss on her forehead.

"I trust you baby , but make sure you look out for yourself, you cant always trust the people around you. You're going to university next year and I want to know you are safe," Linda said and Adora nodded.

"Y ou're right, Ill be more careful. I'm gonna get some more sleep," Adora said and Linda grinned and handed her a few strawberries to take with her.

"Good, Ill make something cheesy for dinner ," Linda promised and Adora grinned.

"Y ou're the best, mum," Adora said and Linda beamed.

"I know , now scoot," Linda said waving her hands, and Adora returned to her room. She shared the strawberries with a sleepy

Catra and drank her water before snuggling down to get some proper sleep.

[..]

It took until Tuesday before Adora had a chance to get Adam on his own. They didn't have practice and Catra had her debate club. They had talked about going for a run to burn off the energy but Adora wanted something easier so they could talk. So they were just walking around the track.

"I need to tell you something," Adora started once there was a lul in the conversation. Adam looked at her, his eyes searching for reason.

"Sure, Dor . You can tell me anything," he reassured and Adora smiled. It didn't put her racing heart at ease but it was reassuring nonetheless. Adora nodded and tried to get her thoughts together.

"I don't expect anything to happen from this. I'm not trying to overstep, or anything. I just need to get it off my chest. I'm going to tell Catra too, I just didn't want to tell you both at once," Adora started explaining, avoiding the subject as her brother waited patiently for her to continue.

"Dor , just tell me, it' s ok." Adam reassured her . She wondered for a moment if he knew or did he think she was going to admit to something else?

"Ok, here goes." Adora said and silence fell between them. Y ou could hear a pin drop. Adora stopped and Adam stopped a few steps ahead and turned to face her. "I've got a crush on Catra" Adora chickened out and watered down her feelings as self preservation. "No, it' s worse. I'm in love with Catra," Adora said earnestly , she looked so guilty and Adam looked pale.

"I know you are dating and I'm not trying to change that, it's just stupid feelings. Ill do whatever I can to fix it so it doesn't af fect your

relationship. Ill talk to Catra about it later so she knows I need space and I cant hang around her as mu-"

"W e arent dating," Adam said softly . His eyes were wide and he looked sick. He looked almost guilty. Adora's stomach dropped. Did they break up and she just didnt notice? Is that why Catra kissed her?

"What do you mean?" Adora asked, with a confused scrunch to her brow.

"W e were fake dating because of Weaver," Adam said quickly , shuffling his feet as Adora's confused frown turned into a glare.

"What about W eaver?" Adora asked and Adam cleared his throat.

"She was being awful to Catra about not dating so she said she was dating someone and she trusted me to not be sleazy about it while pretending to be dating so we just pretended," Adam tried to explain she didnt hear it.

"And you didnt tell me?" Adora asked in a low tone. She felt betrayed and her rage was growing quickly . Adam was starting to look worried.

"W e wanted to tell you but you can't keep a secret and Weaver had to believe it!" Adam said.

Adora opened her mouth to respond but saw movement on the other side of the track. Catra and Glimmer were coming out from their club meeting and Adora glared at her best friend as they approached.

Adora changed her focus and headed straight towards the new arrivals. Adam tried to grab her to stop her leaving without a resolution but Adora yanked her arm away from his hold and stormed over to Glimmer and Catra.

Catra looked concerned, glancing between Adora and Adam but Adora wasn't focusing on her. She couldn't even look at her right now. She felt like such an idiot.

"Glimmer, can I have a ride?" Adora asked and Glimmer looked confused before she glanced at Catra. Adora ignored her.

"Uh, sure. I'm parked at the back," Glimmer said slowly and Adora started to walk towards the back of the school. She couldn't think straight but she was proud of herself for not blowing up immediately. She managed to leave the situation before she said something she might regret. *Progress.*

She was so angry and she needed to process this and calm down. She just couldn't believe they had lied to her.

Chapter End Notes

Thanks so much for reading!

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Something Borrowed

Chapter Notes

We are almost there everyone!Are we ready?

I promised myself I wouldn't post my other AU's until this one wraps up so I am dead set to finish it SOON. The next chapter is half done already, so let's goooooooo

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra watched Glimmer and Adora walk away with a sinking feeling in her stomach. Adora looked angry and Catra didn't know what could have gotten her so worked up. Adam walked up to her and Catra turned her attention to him with a confused frown.

"Is Adora ok?" Catra asked with concern and Adam flinched with guilt. Catra's heart was racing as he opened his mouth to explain.

"Uh, not really. I told her ," Adam said slowly , and Catra needed a moment to process *that* . What did he mean when he told her? Told her what? *Oh…*

"WHAT!" Catra practically yelled before she slapped her hand over her mouth and looked around the oval. They were alone in the cold field as the evening lights turned on around them. She tried to keep herself under control because they didn't need someone snapping a photo of them and calling it a lovers tiff.

"Yeah," Adam said and Catra glared at him, feeling a justified level of fury at his blunder.

"Why did you tell her?" Catra asked and Adam let out a long sigh as he looked away. He appeared to be thinking for a moment before he squared his shoulders and looked back at Catra.

"It was for a good reason. I swear ," Adam said and Catra continued to glare but he didn't break. There must have been a *very* good reason for him not to crumble.

"What was the reason?" Catra asked and Adam looked away again as he frowned.

"I can't tell you, but it was a really good reason!" Adam said softly and Catra laughed a little bitterly. She was angry but more than anything she was hurt.

"I can't believe you told her ," Catra said, feeling a little betrayed that he didn't even tell her before he did it.

"Cat, I'm sorry ok? I shouldn't have said it without talking to you, but maybe this is a good thing?" Adam said, taking Catra' s hand and squeezing it. Catra hated how such a small gesture made her feel better.

"How is this a good thing?" Catra asked, feeling a little desperate as Adam shrugged.

"Well now everyone can explore their feelings," Adam said cryptically, and Catra scoffed at the suggestion. If he wanted to call this whole thing off he could have just told her and never let Adora know.

"Do you have feelings you want to explore?" Catra asked and Adam blushed a little as he looked skyward shyly.

"I might, but I meant you and Adora," Adam said and Catra scof fed at the absurdity of that statement.

"For the last time, Adora doesn't feel that way about me!" Catra snapped and Adam smiled at her like she was a toddler learning to walk.

"I never believed that for a second, but I definitely don't believe it now," Adam said firmly and Catra looked at him with wide eyes. Her stomach dropped to her feet and exploded in butterflies. Her body was apparently in a disagreement of what was the appropriate reaction to those words. Was that what Adora had said to him to make him break?

"Wwhat?" Catra asked softly and Adam squeezed her hand without a word. "How much have I fucked everything up?" Catra asked in despair as she thought of how angry Adora looked. Adora was that angry at *her* .

"She' s mad, but she'll get over it. I'm sure she will, she cares about you," Adam said firmly , pulling her into a tight hug. Catra came willingly, snuggling into his familiar embrace as she tried to calm her racing mind.

"She cares about you too," Catra reassured softly into his shoulder , and Adam chuckled softly.

"Y eah, but she's my twin. She stuck with me," Adam said softly and Catra felt her stomach sink. She had never considered that her place in Adora's life was not a sure thing before. She couldn't let this stupid plan to get Weaver to leave her alone destroy their friendship. She needed Adora and she was determined to not give her up without a fight. Even if she lost, she would never forgive herself for not trying.

"She' s stuck with me too," Catra said firmly , and Adam chuckled again as he gave her an affectionate squeeze.

"I'm glad to hear that," Adam said softly into her hair .

"I think we should break up," Catra said and Adam pulled away a little to look down at her.

"Are you sure?" Adam asked and Catra nodded. Her problems weren't gone when it came to Weaver but she was done trying to make that miserable alcoholic happy.

"Yeah, screw Weaver, if she wants to try to fail me I'll tell the school. I'm not letting her ruin my life anymore." Catra said firmly and Adam smiled proudly at her.

"You're so strong Cat," he said with awe, "We will be here to support you every step of the way," Adam said and Catra smiled. She needed to talk to Adora and clear the air, but she could do this. She just had to do things one step at a time. *Easy*.

[..]

"Adora, where are we going?" Glimmer asked as she drove out of the school parking lot and onto the main road.

"Can we go to your house?" Adora asked curtly and Glimmer nodded.

"Of course but what's going on?" Glimmer asked as she turned towards her house.

Adora could see Glimmer shooting her worried looks as Adora slouched in her seat with her arms crossed and her shoulders up.

She was seething and she didn't know how to communicate that to anyone so her body language would have to do. Her mind was going around in circles, applying the new information to old situations and she was a mix of angry and embarrassed that this new information changed *everything*.

Adora was so angry, this was her brother, her god damn twin who had lied to her. She felt so betrayed, he had been keeping something so important from her for months. But she couldn't believe her twin would agree to keep this from her! He should have told her. She

could keep a secret just fine, she had been keeping the secret of how she felt about Catra from her forever.

She had acted like such a lovesick puppy around Catra and Catra wasn't even dating Adam! She was jealous, needy and even a little possessive. Catra must have been able to see how pathetic Adora's crush was and just let her go on making a fool of herself. She never thought Catra could be so cruel. Actually, that wasn't true, Catra could be cruel but Adora had never received that treatment. Catra could be a bitch when she wanted to be, mostly spending that energy on other girls who bothered Adora, whether they were actually bothering her or not. Adora felt blindsided.

Her stomach dropped as she realised something important. Catra and Adam weren't a couple. The perceived safety blanket that Catra was in love with Adam while she 'explored' her sexuality was gone. She was probably still straight but there was no way she didn't realise how Adora was pining for her. She was just her loser lesbian best friend who couldn't take no for an answer . Who took advantage of her...

She slammed her head back into the headrest and groaned in embarrassment. She squeezed her eyes shut as she willed the words past her lips so someone else could understand her turmoil.

"Catra wasn't really dating Adam when I kissed her . Now, she knows how I feel about her!" Adora said, covering her face with her hands as she let out a frustrated sigh. Maybe her anger was just hiding her embarrassment. No, she was definitely still angry.

"Wait! You kissed Catra?" Glimmer asked in complete shock. The car jolted quickly and Glimmer laid on the horn for a moment as she cursed under her breath. Adora briefly wondered if her life was in danger with Glimmer at the wheel but decided that death wouldn't be so bad if she didn't have to deal with these emotions.

"She must have told me it didn't mean anything the second time because she knew I was so attached. This is so embarrassing,"

Adora continued as Glimmer pulled onto her quiet street to park out the front of her house. Glimmer's parents had too many cars so Glimmer needed to park on the street instead of in their huge garage.

"Wait! Second time? ADORA!? Please back up and start again. What on earth is happening?" Glimmer asked, aggressively putting the car in the park and turning to Adora with an accusatory scowl. Adora looked ahead without acknowledging her for a long time. Her heart settled into its new life in her stomach as she took a deep breath.

"You were right, Glim. They were lying" Adora said softly and tried to stop the stinging in her eyes as tears welled. She didn't want to cry, she was pissed, wasn't she?

"I was right about wha- NO, you're kidding me? They were faking it?" Glimmer asked in shock. She couldn't seem to get her face to understand the situation as she tried to look smug and supportive at the same time. Adora sighed and looked out the window just so she didn't have to watch Glimmer struggle.

"Yeah... they lied to me," Adora said as she tried to blink away the tears.

"Adora, I am so sorry," Glimmer said and her voice sounded sincere. Adora looked over at her and could see Glimmer was concerned. She didn't look happy about being right at least.

"Yeah" Adora said softly and sniffled as some tears fell from her eyes. Glimmer grabbed her hand in both hers and looked into her eyes with determination.

"We need a best friend's sleepover, I'm calling Bow," Glimmer said. She convinced Adora out of the car and into the house.

The only time Adora ever had a best friend sleepover with Bow and Glimmer was one time when she was 13 and Catra had lost her mind at the prospect of not being invited to the event. To be fair the

whole reason for the sleepover was because Catra and Adora had kissed at a different sleepover because of a game of spin the bottle and Adora's gay little heart exploded. She had been out ever since and she now realised she should have seen the signs sooner.

Adora was forced inside and onto the couch in the den with blankets to bury her pain and Glimmer called Bow to request he bring ice cream and something else just in case.

Adora was a little numb to it all by now and she tried to blink back her tears again but she was unsuccessful as she felt them slide down her cheeks. She tried to stop her chest from constricting painfully but she buried her face into the blankets to hide.

She felt so betrayed but she felt so vulnerable too, like Catra knew everything and was just using Adora to explore her own feelings. She felt so hurt that her feelings didnt matter to the two people who were her whole world. She hated how much Adam was her other half but apparently that feeling was one sided. He knew her every will and weakness, he knew this would hurt her and he did it anyway. It hurt.

Adora scrunched the blankets against her face and felt someone sit beside her on the couch. She looked up and saw the concerned eyes of Glimmer. She hated how she wished they were Catra's eyes. She wanted Catra to hold her and explain everything, make everything ok. But she knew with her emotions running high she was more likely to kiss the brunette than listen to her. She couldnt expose herself further .

"How are you doing?" Glimmer asked as she of fered a tub of rocky road ice cream that she had in the freezer . It wasnt Adora' s favourite but it was a sugar hit that she needed. She took the tub and put a huge scoop of ice cream into her mouth.

"Fine." Adora muttered and scooped more ice cream into her mouth. Glimmer was watching her with sympathy but it was only

making her feel worse. She looked into the tub of ice cream as more tears welled in her eyes.

"Tell me why you thought it was fake," Adora asked and Glimmer was silent, so Adora looked at her. She looked guilty before she looked away.

"Tell me about when you kissed Catra first,"

Adora pouted and shifted in the blankets. A blush came to her cheeks as she thought of their first kiss on the hood of her car.

"The first time was at the lookout. Catra was in a mood so I took her there to talk because Teela was at the house to study. We kissed, and she ran off."

"Ok, did you kiss her or did she kiss you?"

"Umsh..e kissed me, I think"…

"Ok, and she ran of f, you said you did it more than once?" Glimmer asked, and Adora felt herself turn bright red at the thought of their heavy makeout session after the away game.

"I-it" Adora cleared her throat "It was at the away game in our room. I think I kissed her that time," Adora said so softly it was almost impossible to hear. But Glimmer's ears were trained to hear drama so she clicked her tongue at the information.

"Ok, so you've both initiated one kiss each," Glimmer said and Adora was silent as she tried to keep her blush under control. "Right?" Glimmer asked suspiciously and Adora scooped more ice cream into her mouth so she didn't have to respond.

"Hey fam, what's up?" Bow said walking into the room with a bottle of vodka and three pints of icecream in various flavours. Adora realised now what the other item Glimmer asked for over the phone was. Adora's mouth was still full so Glimmer helpfully replied for her.

“Adora kissed Catra twice and I’m trying to get the details, Adam and Catra were fake dating so you owe me a milkshake,” Glimmer threw over her shoulder and Bow looked confused and sympathetic. He exchanged the ice cream Adora was holding with her favourite flavour and Adora ate more as her cheeks finally settled and she sulked.

“I’ll get some glasses,” Glimmer said, quickly jumping up to get glasses for the vodka.

“And something to mix with please, juice or something,” Bow asked, knowing Glimmer’s cocktails were terrible. Glimmer waved her hand as if she heard him and disappeared.

“How are you feeling,” Bow asked, sitting down beside Adora and putting his arm around her. Adora didn’t realise how much she needed a hug until she was getting one. She felt herself take a shaky breath and tears rolled down her cheeks.

“This sucks,” Adora said softly, and Bow nodded his head as they sat in silence until Glimmer came back into the room with orange juice and cordial with glasses.

“Let me do that,” Bow offered to intervene in Glimmer's concoction, and Glimmer swapped with Bow to sit with Adora.

“So, you kissed twice,” Glimmer said, her interrogation resuming. Adora lifted the blankets over her hand to cover her face as she attempted to hide. She didn’t need this right now. She was having a crisis.

“Adora, if you’ve kissed twice you shouldn’t look so guilty, they weren’t even dating for real!” Glimmer exclaimed and Adora turned red against her will. “Adora, how many times did you kiss?” Glimmer asked and Adora looked at Bow for help. He was focused on his task but he was clearly listening. No help there.

"A few times, at the away game." Adora said softly and Glimmer scowled.

"So you make out and just ignore it?" Glimmer asked and Adora tried not to choke on ice cream.

"I thought she was just experimenting," Adora said, a little ashamed. Glimmer snorted.

"Adora, I love you, but you don't experiment with other people while in a relationship," Glimmer scolded and Adora nodded. She knew that.

"She said it didn't mean anything." Adora tried to excuse even though the words made her heart twist painfully.

"That's stupid, why are you both like this?" Glimmer asked with frustration.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked, insulted by the accusation.

"Oblivious! She's had the hots for you since you grew boobs, why can't you see that?" Glimmer asked, clearly frustrated. Bow put his hand on Glimmer's shoulder to silence her and handed everyone a drink.

"It's not easy to see when it's happening to you, I didn't know Glimmer liked me even after she told me, I thought she meant as friends," Bow said with a chuckle as he settled more comfortably on the carpet with his drink.

"See?! That's not clear! Catra has told me she likes me plenty of times," Adora said clearly frustrated and Glimmer looked at her with surprise.

"How did she say it?" Glimmer asked, looking almost concerned about this level of ridiculousness.

"I don't remember exactly , but she's said it before over the years, saying she likes me and I tell her back, because I do like her. She's my best friend," Adora said, raising her voice a little. Glimmer looked at her with a stone cold face before she turned to Bow.

"Is it too late to be Catra's bestie? I feel like she needs me the more I'm hearing," Glimmer asked Bow , hopefully joking.

"Hey! I need you, Catra has Adam," Adora said sulking and Glimmer looked at her incredulously.

"You're telling me Catra has told you multiple times that she *likes* you over the years and she's faced rejection with a smile?" Glimmer asked and Adora blushed.

"She didn't mean it like that," Adora defended and Glimmer scowled.

"How do you know? Did you ask her?" Glimmer asked and Adora ducked her head with embarrassment. Glimmer rolled her eyes and let out a long sigh.

"I gotta make a call," Glimmer said leaving the room, and Bow joined Adora back on the couch to put his arm around her while she ate ice cream.

[..]

Catra was sitting on the floor in the Greyskull house while Adam was in the kitchen talking to his parents about what had happened. They had gotten a call from Adora to say she was staying at the Moon's tonight so Catra was freaking out a little bit. She couldn't focus on her studies at all as she tapped her pen against a blank page and she fidgeted to get comfortable.

Catra heard her phone vibrate and looked down at the screen, hoping it would be Adora calling to talk. To her disappointment and almost relief, it was Glimmer. Glimmer could tell Catra if Adora was ok without her possibly starting an argument. She answered quickly .

"Hey Glim," Catra said as she tried to hide her nerves. What if Glimmer told her Adora never wanted to speak to her again? She really needed to talk to her.

"Hey , I dont have much time before Adora realises what Im doing, so, like, shut up and listen ok?" Glimmer said in an almost nice voice and Catra bit back her snarky response.

"Ok," Catra said softly , and Glimmer continued.

"Adora explained what happened and I just want you to knowI see you, ok? I get it, so what's the plan?" Glimmer asked and Catra almost burst into tears as she heard those words. Glimmer and her had never been close to a blonde barrier between them to fight over, but the feeling seen for whom she was an indescribably liberating feeling.

"Thanks' Glim," Catra croaked out and heard a smile in Glimmer's voice.

"Y ou got it bestie, so what's the plan?" Glimmer asked and Catra laughed as she sniffled.

"I just need to talk to her ," Catra said softly and Glimmer snorted,

"Obviously , Bow and I can help with that, where would be best?" Glimmer asked, clearly planning something elaborate.

"I mean, if she could just come home when Im at her house that would be enough," Catra said softly and Glimmer hummed.

"Ok, so she won't be back tonight before your curfew so how about tomorrow? W e can offer to take her to get food and bring her to you," Glimmer offered and Catra nodded. Food was always a sure way to get Adora's attention. She ate way too much to be so hot. Catra blushed at her own thoughts but it felt less taboo to think that way as the lies were cleared from the air.

Could Adora really forgive her and let her pour her heart out? She just needed her to know . She knew it was unlikely that Adora felt the same way, maybe she was physically attracted to her, but she had better options than someone like Catra.

"That'll work. Thanks for helping Glim," Catra said softly and Glimmer huffed.

"Just make sure I'm the maid of honour at your wedding," Glimmer said and Catra blushed as the images came to mind of what it would be like to marry Adora. God she wanted that so badly. To make that blonde idiot happy for the rest of their lives.

"Gotta go, talk tomorrow!" Glimmer said quickly and hung up. Catra let out a long sigh as she tried to release some of the tension in her body. It felt good to let people help her for a change. Maybe this wasn't so bad.

[..]

Glimmer entered the room again and Adora had eaten half her ice cream while talking to Bow about the details Glimmer left out. Bow had a much more sympathetic ear but he wanted her to talk to Catra.

You know what's the ultimate revenge?" Glimmer asked with a twinkle of delight in her eyes. Adora looked at her with confusion and glanced at Bow who gave her a shrug.

"What?" Adora asked, curious what Glimmer thought was worth the excitement.

"A makeover! Make her see what she's missing!" Glimmer said and Adora's stomach swooped at the idea of making Catra desire her.

"I don't know." She said, her cheeks colouring as she thought of the shy hands she had experienced at the away game, becoming more adventurous.

"Come onnn, we always talked about you embracing your gay more!" Glimmer begged and Adora was unfortunately full of milk, sugar and vodka with a weak will.

"That's true... What would we do?" Adora asked, unsure.

"Let me show you," Glimmer said, grabbing out her laptop to show Adora her ideas. She parked herself on Bow's lap as she showed Adora haircuts and outfits and 'vibes' she thought would suit her .

[..]

The night was cold as Catra walked back home. Adam had offered to drop her off because the days were getting shorter and it was already dark outside but Catra wanted to think while she walked.

She passed the playground between their houses and paused for a moment to look at the swing set and other eqipment. She had clear memories of hot summer days running around that park. Eating ice cream and throwing water balloons. The hot sweaty summer days end with sleepovers in the living room of the Greyskull house parked under the air conditioner to stay cool.

She missed those simpler days of just being friends with Adam and Adora, before her heart decided she had found the one and would have no other. Catra was eight when it happened. Adora was everything: her first kiss, her first crush, her first love. But more importantly she was her best friend, and she wasnt willing to give up that title for anyone.

Tomorrow she would bare her heart to Adora and they would find a way for Catra to get over these feelings so Adora could be happy and find her dream girl. Catra could handle loving Adora from a distance if it meant keeping her in her life, but Adam was right. She had to tell her.

Catra continued home, the street her house was on didnt have many street lights but some of the houses still had lights on. It wasnt

unusual that her own house was dark, she wasnt late home but Weaver was often in bed when she got home lately.

Catra went up the steps to her door and unlocked it. The inside was cold like Weaver hadnt bothered to turn the heating on. Catra had been too anxious at dinner to eat much so she turned on the lights to grab a snack to make her studying easier.

The dining table was still missing, no surprise there. It was a miracle they had one to begin with since they never used it. It was probably a status thing that Weaver insisted on, in case people came over it would make them look like a normal family.

Catra turned the light on to the kitchen and took in the sight before her. On the floor of the kitchen were several black garbage bags filled to bursting with something and on the counter was the school supplies she had left in her room. What she could only assume was the last of her possessions was a note with Weaver's house keys on top.

A knot settled into her stomach as she stepped forward to read the note.

Catra,

Leave your keys for the realtor.

Catra looked at the note before she looked at the keys she still had in her hand. On that keyring were her keys to Weaver's house and the Greyskull keys. She frowned with confusion and looked around the house.

Her heart was beating quickly in her chest as she put her backpack down on the ground and ran up the stairs. She didnt try to keep quiet like she usually would. She got to Weaver's door and swung it open with too much force as it slammed against the wall. The room was bare.

Not a single item was left, not a bed or a forgotten earring. It was just...empty. Catra walked to her room, opening the doors on her way to look inside the rooms. Empty. Empty...empty.

She looked at her room with a settling despair in her chest. Weaver left. Left her, without a word. Was she so worthless to the woman that she couldn't even spare her a parting sentiment?

Catra had mixed feelings as her eyes burned and tears flowed down her cheeks. She was free, but this was a slap in the face. She didn't have a job, she couldn't support herself. She would have to be a burden on her friends, or the Greyskull's more specifically. Adora hated her right now so she shouldn't invade her space. Especially since she would have to give her so much more space once she confessed. Gods, maybe she should tell Glimmer to cancel the whole idea. She couldn't confess right now and ends up homeless.

She took a deep breath and walked back downstairs to her only belongings. She pulled out her phone and dialed Adam.

He answered on the second ring with a chuckle in his voice. "Get lost?" he asked playfully and Catra just cracked. She started to sob uncontrollably and Adam went straight into panic mode.

"Cat, are you ok?" Adam asked, and she could hear him pushing his chair back and getting up, clearly planning to come get her. Catra fell to her knees and put her free hand on the cold floor to hold herself up.

"Help." Catra sobbed and she could hear Adam running down the stairs.

"I'm on my way Cat, just hang on," he said soothingly and further away from the phone he yelled out. "Ma! I'm going to get Cat!" He yelled and Catra heard Linda call back from further away. "Keep talking to me Cat, are you safe?" he asked. W eaver was one day away from being a psycho so his question was valid. He probably thought she had tried to hurt Catra.

Catra sniffled to try to get herself under control and heard Adam getting in the car and starting it.

"W eaver" Catra started.

"T ell me what happened. Did she hurt you?" he asked, his voice cold at the idea. Catra breathed out a soft laugh. He was so protective and it made her realise that Teela was a lucky girl to have captured his affection. Catra would have to have a word with her to make sure she wasnt going to mess him around.

"No, she' s gone," Catra said softly , and Adam was silent for a long moment. The sound of the car is the only thing filling the silence.

"Likedead?" Adam asked with concern and Catra laughed a bit louder this time.

"No, I dont think so, she fucking left," Catra said and Adam was silent again before Catra could hear the sound of a car coming down her street and parking outside.

"I'll be right in," he said quickly , with a slam of the car door and some quick steps up the stairs he let himself inside. "Cat?" he called and Catra called back to him. He came into the room to see her things around her as she sat on the floor. "Cat" he said so softly as he got down on his knees with her to wrap her in a hug. Catra leaned into his embrace and sobbed.

She felt so worthless and pathetic and she just needed to cry right now. Adam seemed to realise this and just held her silently . After a few minutes sitting in an uncomfortable position he gave in to the need to move. Pulling Catra with him into a more comfortable spot for them both. He ran his hand down her back and rocked her a little just like Linda would do when Catra was smaller and upset.

She let it all out, Adam was a safe space and he would take care of her while she fell apart and put herself back together. It felt like she cried for hours but really she had no concept of time anymore. She

sniffled as she seemed to have no tears left to cry and lifted her head to look at Adam.

"Come on, let's get you home," he said gently and Catra nodded. He was right, this place was never her home, this was just a house. An old cold house that never held any love for her. It was something borrowed from a horrible woman who barely tolerated Catra no matter what she did to try to win Weaver's love. The Greyskull house had been her home for as long as she could remember and it was so full of love.

"Ok," Catra said softly , and Adam helped her get up and followed suit.

"Ok, we can probably do this in two trips do you feel up to helping?" Adam asked and Catra nodded, she wasn't useless. "Good, you take the school stuff and I'll get the bags," he said and Catra nodded as they went to work.

It took three loads in the end and Catra stood at the door looking inside as Adam finished packing the car. The house was cold and quiet, it wasn't usual but it was unnerving. This will be the last time she will ever set foot here. With her keys left on the counter in the kitchen for the realtor, Catra pulled the door closed with a loud click of the locks.

She let out a breath as she wondered if she would ever see Weaver again. At least she could finally let this part of her life go, leaving the bad memories in this old house to torment the spiders.

Catra took another deep breath and walked down the stairs to meet Adam at the car. Maybe this was the best outcome she could ask for, but even if it wasn't there was no going back now .

Chapter End Notes

If you want to find me, I'm on Tumblr, Instagram and Twitter @nniiart.

I have 6 other AU's that are patiently waiting for my attention, but there's plenty of art to see if you're interested.

Thanks so much for reading!I appreciate all your lovely comments and kudos <3

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Something Blue

Chapter Notes

We are so close now. The next chapter may be very long, so it might take me a minute.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora walked into Lit a few minutes late for the bell feeling guilty. She was a little hung over and her stomach hurt from eating so much ice cream the night before. She had prepared herself to get chewed out by Weaver in front of the class when she realised Glimmer was going to be late for the first period. Apparently she didnt have to worry as the woman at the front of the class was not Mrs Weaver. The woman smiled at Adora kindly and she looked back with a confused smile. She appeared to be a substitute teacher based on her outfit of bright colours and flower patterns wrapped around the hem of her skirt. Adora ducked her head with embarrassment and took her seat silently.

Adora noticed immediately that Catra was missing from her desk to the left of hers and frowned in confusion at Adam. He looked stressed and tired but all it did was make Adora annoyed. She should be the one who looked upset, not him. Adora looked at Catra's desk with concern prickling inside her chest.

She was still angry at her brother and Catra but she didnt want anything bad to happen to the brunette. She tried to focus on the class after she decided she could find out from Adam after it was over.

As soon as class concluded Adora got up and went to Adam's desk while he packed his bag. Adora put her hand on the top of his desk to lean over him.

"You're an ass," she said bluntly, and he looked up at her with guilty eyes, but there was a small smile on his face.

"Yeah, I know," he said softly, and Adora huffed. "I'm sorry, I should have told you," Adam said, getting to his feet to come level with Adora.

"Yeah, you should have," Adora punched his arm softly and he smiled a little more brightly.

"It won't happen again," Adam promised and Adora rolled her eyes at him. She couldn't stay mad at him. She was still hurt but she did unfortunately understand better after the long drunken conversations she had the night before. She could vaguely remember Glimmer taking her phone away because Adora wanted to call Catra and demand answers, and maybe kisses. It was all a little hazy.

"It better not," Adora said, walking out of the class behind him. Once she stepped up beside him again in the hallway, Adora glanced over at him. "Where's Catra?" She asked softly.

"Something happened last night and Catra wasn't ready to come to school," Adam said and Adora frowned.

"You said no more secrets," Adora scolded and he glared at her.

"I kept yours," he snapped back, and Adora blushed, but her frown was still present.

"Fine, can you tell me anything?" Adora grumbled and Adam untensed his shoulders.

"Weaver skipped town, Catra's pretty upset about it," Adam said softly and Adora gaped at him.

"You're kidding!" she asked. It was a shock. Weaver was the worst, but she never thought she would just up and leave like that.

"I wish I was," Adam said softly. "Cat called me crying and, gods, Dor, I thought she hurt her," Adam said with a frown and Adora's stomach tightened at the thought of Weaver laying another hand on Catra.

"I'm sorry I wasn't there," Adora said with guilt and Adam waved his hand.

"I understand. You were uh, are? upset," Adam said dismissively and Adora nodded. She was upset and she needed the space but Catra was hurt in the meantime and all it did was fill her with guilt.

"Is she ok?" Adora asked softly as they got to their next class.

"She will be," Adam said with a soft smile, and Adora nodded. They headed into class, Adora with a heavy weight on her chest. She still felt like she needed space but she wanted so badly to go home and just hold Catra, to make it all ok again, if she were allowed.

[..]

Catra was laying in Adora's bed, she didn't come home the night before so Dean and Linda elected to use the available room rather than rearranging the study to allow the cot to be set up. She would move into the study tonight because she was sure Adora wouldn't want anything to do with her.

Even if she got the stones to admit her feelings to Adora she would still be mad about the lies and Catra wouldn't force her presence on her. She didn't want to make her uncomfortable, she had done that enough already.

Catra kissed Adora and now Adora knew she wasn't with Adam. She must have thought Catra was just using her and being a total creep.

Catra buried her face into Adora’s pillow. It still smelt like her and the scent was soothing on her nerves.

She wasn't entirely sure what time it was but the sun was up and she knew everyone went to school and work hours ago.

Catra’s phone vibrated on the bedside table and she scrambled to reach it quickly. She almost fell out of the bed when she saw the caller ID. It wasn't Adora, but Glimmer.

"Hey Glim," Catra answered, trying not to seem disappointed.

"Hey, noticed you weren't in class," Glimmer said in a peppy tone. The sounds of the cafeteria was in the background and Catra moved the phone away from her ear slightly to deal with the noise.

"Aw, you worried about me?" Catra teased, she could handle this surface level teasing they had always done. She just couldn't handle if Glimmer asked her how she was doing, she knew she would probably cry.

"Pshh, no, I just don't want to have to take notes for you if you're gonna be out all day," Glimmer said, a rustling sound coming from her end and the sound of walking.

"Uh huh, you don't have to take notes for me, I can get them from the teacher or something," Catra said, her inner Weaver voice telling her she shouldn't be a burden.

"Nah, it's chill we have a substitute in Lit and she let us read for the second half of class," Glimmer said, the sound from the cafeteria getting quieter.

"That's cool, subs always let you get away with everything" Catra said conversationally as she picked at a loose thread on Adora’s blankets.

"T rue. Is Weaver home sick too?" Glimmer asked and Catra took in a sharp breath at the question. She bit her lip to consider it. It was all going to come out soon anyway, nothing happened around this town without people noticing.

"Uh, not quite... can you keep this to yourself?" Catra asked softly .

"Y eah, I'm a vault" Glimmer confirmed and Catra snorted, that was not true at all. "Fine, I'm not a vault but I can keep a secret," Glimmer said, her voice getting lower as the sound of a door shutting came through the phone. Catra wondered where Glimmer had gone for this conversation but it didn't matter .

"Fine, I'm trusting you. W eaver skipped town," Catra said and Glimmer gasped dramatically.

"Y ou're kidding! What happened?"

"No idea, she just left a note for me to leave my keys, no forwarding address or anything." Catra said, shrugging like it wasn't causing tears to well in her eyes at the ever present reminder of being abandoned.

"Dude, I'm so sorry ," Glimmer said sympathetically .

"Thanks... how' s Adora? Do you think she will still talk to me?" Catra asked, her week couldn't get any worse so she was still considering talking about her feelings. She might as well rip the bandage off while everything was going to hell anyway.

"Oh yeah, she will. She tried to call you last night but she was super drunk so I stopped her," Glimmer said and Catra blinked in confusion.

"What? Why was she drunk?" Catra asked, it was a school night and Adora wasn't really that interested in alcohol so it seemed like unusual behaviour.

"She was pretty upset before she explained what was happening and we talked about it. I think she understands now, but obviously she still needs to hear it from you," Glimmer said and Catra nodded.

"Thanks Glim, I'm staying with the Greyskulls so whenever she gets home I can talk to her. Please don't tell her about Weaver. I'm sure Adam will tell her something but I want her to hear it from me," Catra asked and Glimmer sighed.

"Alright, I'll keep it quiet, let me know if you need any help ok?" Glimmer offered.

"Thanks, Glim,"

"It's ok, I gotta go, bye" Glimmer suddenly hung up as a voice near her started talking. Catra wasn't sure who it was but it didn't matter right now. She flopped back into Adora's bed and snuggled into the pillows. She had been thinking about what she needed to tell Adora all day but it felt like so much. Hopefully Adora would hear her out. She could be so stubborn when she thought she was right.

[..]

Adora scratched at the short hair at the back of her head. The fine hairs were itchy from the cut but she found running her hand over the shorter hair soothing.

She had agreed with Glimmer's makeover ideas and wasn't about to back out now. She liked the idea of the undercut she suggested. The bottom half of her head was now buzzed short and it made her ponytail much lighter which stopped pulling on the skin of her forehead.

Glimmer and Bow were walking around the shop picking up clothing for Adora while she trailed behind them in her jeans, t-shirt and letterman jacket. She wasn't paying much attention to what they were grabbing since she agreed to play along but she had noticed a

few more than the usual girls checking her out since her haircut. Maybe Glimmer had a point, she could stand to look gayer.

"Right! Let's go to the changing room," Glimmer said with excitement and Adora sighed theatrically before she followed. Glimmer was ignoring her fake complaints anyway.

Glimmer gave her the clothing to try on and she was starting to realise she probably should have paid more attention. Adora picked up a skirt that she didn't see put in the pile and held it to her hips.

She couldn't remember the last time she wore a skirt. It looked more like something Catra would wear. Adora undressed and put together one of the outfits Glimmer clearly planned. She put on the skirt, pulling it down as far as it would go over her legs. It felt like a slight breeze would cause her to flash people and she did not appreciate that. She put on a crop top and stepped out of the change room with her socks still on.

"Hmm," Glimmer said, looking at the outfit. "What do you think?"

"I don't like the skirt much, but the top is nice," Adora said looking at her abs. The skirt wasn't bad, it just made her self conscious. Maybe it was something she should experiment more with.

"That's fair, you look great but I get it if you don't want the skirt, yes to the top though!" Bow agreed and Adora nodded before she went back into the change room.

She ended up with a new red jacket which wasn't her letterman, a couple of pairs of jeans with rips in them, a new pair of converse shoes and an assortment of tops. She did end up buying a skirt, it was about mid thigh and tight. It looked nice and it was far less likely to flash people accidentally so it was a good place to start. Some of the clothes she got she could even wear to school without getting dress-coded. Which was a bonus.

[..]

Adora came home after dinner with Glimmer and Bow at the mall and went to her bedroom to deposit her new clothing.

She was pulling the tags off her haul when she heard a knock on the door. She called out for them to come in and her mum entered. Adora was relieved it wasnt Catra or Adam, she would like a little breathing room before she tried to talk to Catra.

"Hey Pumpkin, ohh, new look?" Linda asked as she closed the door and walked over to sit on the bed.

"Yeah, trying something new," Adora said, running her hand over her undercut at the back of her head for the millionth time that afternoon.

"It suits you, and new clothes too?" Linda asked, picking up one of the tops. She looked a little confused where the rest of it was but didnt comment as she folded it and put it back on the bed.

"It was Glimmer's idea," Adora excused, putting down her clothing to sit beside her mum. She let out a sigh before she leaned her head onto her mum's shoulder and Linda wrapped her arm around her.

"Are you ok pumpkin?" Linda asked as she pulled Adora closer gently.

"I'm fine." Adora lied as she felt her eyes sting as tears threatened to surface.

"Adam told us what happened." Linda started slowly and Adora lifted her head quickly to look at her mother.

"What?! What did he tell you?" she asked, confused why he would tell their parents. It was best they knew the truth but how much did he say?

"Just that he and Catra were pretending to date because of Weaver." Linda said gently pulling Adora closer again to rock her.

"And you're ok with this?" Adora grumbled as she allowed her mum to comfort her.

"Y ou're all adults so we are just here to guide you and help if you ask. Im not here to judge their decisions. Catra' s been through alot and Weaver was horrible to her." Adora frowned, snuggling into her mothers arms as she sighed. She felt like a little girl again, even though she was taller than her mother now.

"Y eah... he was." Adora said softly as she thought of what Adam had told her about Catra's night last night. She had been through so much already and Weaver apparently had one last way planned to screw her over. "Is she here?" Adora asked shyly and Linda nodded.

"Y eah, we set up the study so she wouldnt disturb you," Linda said and Adora nodded. Just down the hall Catra was on that terrible fold out cot instead of comfortably in Adora's bed. The guilt settled heavy on her shoulders. "What's really got you blue, Pumpkin?" Linda asked, rubbing Adora's back like she used to when she was sick. It was a soothing and familiar motion which helped her relax her tense shoulders.

"I... dont know , Im just so... angry , and hurt, and frustrated..." Adora said, her chest tightening with every word. Linda hummed and rocked her like a baby as she listened.

"Which one is the biggest feeling right now?" Linda asked softly and Adora thought about her response.

"I'm frustrated... It felt like Catra and I were finally back to normal after Adam and her started dating." Adora said feeling her cheeks warm at the thought of certain things which werent so normal for them. Things she could never have again if she wanted to ensure they didnt destroy their friendship over muddled emotions.

"Hmm, so you are upset that they disrupted the way things are meant to be?" Linda asked gently and Adora nodded against her shoulder. "What do you think things are meant to be like?" Linda

asked and Adora had to think again. The silence stretched on as her mind went in circles. She wanted to kiss Catra and hold her, she wanted whatever Catra would give her.

"Being close to Catra," Adora said softly and Linda nodded.

"Are you mad at your brother?" Linda asked and Adora didn't think before she shook her head. She had come to terms with her brother's involvement. She knew Catra was often the driving force so if Adam kept this from Adora then it was for Catra's sake.

"No," She said softly and Linda hummed.

"So you are frustrated with Catra?" Linda asked and Adora felt her stomach swoop. She was, but she wasn't. She was frustrated with Catra because of something she couldn't control. Adora wanted her to be hers but she would never be.

"No I don't think it's her fault that I'm frustrated." Adora said softly as her cheeks coloured. Linda hummed.

"You're doing so well pumpkin," Linda praised and Adora leaned more into her comfort. Her mother knew how hard emotional stuff was for her. Adam was a natural but Adora always struggled. Linda was an ever patient teacher. "Tell me why you are frustrated with Catra," Linda asked patiently .

"She can't help it." Adora said softly and Linda rocked her again, getting a rhythm that soothed Adora.

"That might be the case, but tell me anyway ," Linda prompted and Adora let out a breath she had been holding. She felt almost like she was in a trance. She was safe in her mothers arms and she knew from many previous experiences that she would guide her through this.

"She's straight," Adora admitted, hiding her face in her mothers shoulder as she heard the woman let out a soft chuckle. Linda

hummed and continued to rock her six foot baby gently .

"Have you asked her?" Linda asked softly and Adora paused again to consider her question.

"N-no" Adora admitted, a little ashamed. Linda pushed her hair behind her ear and continued her soft rocking.

"Maybe you should ask her ," Linda said softly and Adora lifted her head off her shoulder to look at her. She felt a little silly to have never thought to ask Catra her sexuality . She had always assumed if she was anything but straight she would tell Adora. But maybe she hadn't told her because Adora had never asked. She blushed as she felt ashamed.

"Maybe I should" Adora said softly as she looked away to think. Linda cupped her face and put a big kiss on her cheek as she smiled.

"Communication is always the answer , even if you hear something you don't like, it's always better to know than to wonder ," Linda said, her blue eyes piercing Adora's matching set. Adora let out a long sigh before she nodded like a child being told to go to bed.

"You're right, do you think it's too late now?" Adora asked softly and Linda's eyes sparkled as she smiled.

"It's never too late darling, I'm sure she will be happy to talk to you," Linda said softly and kissed Adora's nose which made her scrunch her face. Linda laughed.

"Love you Pumpkin," She said firmly and Adora smiled.

"Love you too mum," Adora said and Linda looked satisfied. She let Adora go and stood.

"Dad and I will be just down the hall if you need us," Linda said and Adora nodded sheepishly before her mother left.

Adora decided to wash off the day and get into her pyjamas before she faced Catra. She needed to think of what to say to not make a total fool of herself. She washed off the short itchy hair and left her hair down to dry before gathering her courage to go to the study.

[..]

Catra was sitting on the double cot in the study that Linda and Dean had set up for her. She had gotten ready for bed a while ago and miraculously managed to be normal over dinner and conversation, right up until she was alone. Everyone meant well but the sympathetic looks were slowly eating away at her pride. She didnt want Weaver to define her anymore than she already did but this was her new reality. She sat on the cot she was given with her head in her hands as she sobbed silently. She didnt know what else to do but let the sadness out. She had to move through the feelings because there was no way around them from here.

She didnt hold much love for her mother but she was still her mother. She was the one person in the world who was meant to love her unconditionally, and she couldnt even manage that. Was Catra so unlovable that Weaver felt nothing for her? She might not have loved her but she did give her shelter and food, even clothing to keep up appearances. She had to have cared at least a little right?

She felt almost hollow in the absence of her mothers expectations. She was gutted, left empty in the wake of the personality her mother had forced on her. Who was she now? Did she even know? Was she even gay? Or was that a rebellion against her mother? The one person Weaver didnt want Catra to ruin, of course she had to love her. She was nothing without her mothers expectations. She had a whole world of expectations on her now and all she had to do was live. It felt daunting.

She didnt even have Adora to navigate the great unknown with her because she had expertly ruined that too. She was just so lost and so alone. She had leaned too hard on Adam already and she didn't want to push him away too. She wasnt his problem to deal with and

she didnt want to stop him from his own feelings for Teela by being a burden. He clearly liked her and she never wanted to be responsible for him not getting the love he deserved.

She was sobbing so hard by this point she was dizzy with the effort to hold her sobs inside her chest that she didnt hear the soft knock on the door. The knock repeated and Catra's headshot up. She didn't want anyone to see her like this, she didnt want the pity so she held her breath and tried to stay silent enough that they would think she was asleep with the light on.

"Catra?" Adora's soft voice came through the door and Catra couldnt keep her sob silent anymore. Adora clearly heard as she opened the door and stepped inside. She looked worried as she closed the door behind her and approached the cot.

Catra tried to move away to the other side of the small bed to keep her distance. It was a small attempt at self preservation because she knew she would do something stupid if Adora got too close.

"You ok?" Adora whispered this time before she sat at the other end of the cot gingerly. Catra shook her head without thinking and hid her face in her hands again. Her eyes hurt from crying and she knew she looked a mess. What a horrible thing to witness. She couldnt bring herself to speak so she just stayed quiet as she sobbed.

"Catra?" Adora's voice sounded strained but closer. Catra felt the movement on the cot and glanced up at the blonde. She was much closer than she had been and Catra wanted to wither away. She couldnt look at her. "Cat?" Adora's voice sounded unsure and Catra did that to her. She made her question their friendship by lying to her. She made herself insecure by kissing and flirting and being a mess. "Can I touch you?" Adora asked softly and without her input Catra was nodding.

She felt Adora wrap her arms around her in a protective cocoon and her body responded immediately. She could feel herself melt into the embrace and she buried her teary face into the crook of Adora's

neck. Adora's hand started a steady rhythm up and down her spine and Catra relaxed further .

"It's ok," Adora said softly and Catra could almost believe her . She was so raw and scared. If Adora chose to reject her she didn't think she would ever recover. She felt her chest split with a sob and Adora shushed her gently.

"You're ok," Adora said softly and Catra sniffled. She managed to get her tears under control to croak out something that sounded like words.

"I'm sorry ," Catra said, her voice sounding hoarse, and Adora rocked her gently as she nodded her head.

"It's ok," Adora said softly as it filled Catra with a fire inside her instead. She didn't suffer all this time for Adora to deem this ok. This whole situation had been fucked up since the start. None of this was ok.

"N-no, it's not," Catra said, pulling back and looking up at Adora. They weren't that far away but it was enough for Catra to see Adora's whole face. Adora looked confused, as usual.

"You abandoned me and I needed you," Catra said with a croak and Adora frowned with confusion before it morphed into a frown.

"You lied to me," Adora said, her voice low and a little cold. Adora was angry, rightfully angry but it didn't take away Catra's pain.

"Yes, and you fucked off, you wouldn't even talk to me! My m-mo-" Catra choked on her words as she tried to hold back her tears. "I'm homeless now and you still ignored me," Catra said bitterly .

"I was hurt," Adora said softly , and Catra scoffed.

"So was I! I didn't want to lie to you! Do you think I wanted to make Weaver happy? I was s-scared," Catra forced out and Adora looked

sad. Catra didnt need her pity so she continued bitterly . "Do you think I want to pretend to date a guy? Instead of dating who I want to?" Catra asked and Adora' s eyes got wide, but she was on a role and she wasnt stopping for anyone. "She thought I was gay , and she almost threw me out, I didnt have a choice," Catra said with a bitter laugh, and Adora just stared. Catra didnt know what else to do so she pulled herself out of Adora's arms and wiped at her face angrily.

"A-are you?" Adora asked softly , her eyes still wide and Catra glared at her.

"Am I what?" Catra asked with annoyance and Adora swallowed audibly.

"Gay?" she asked, barely a whisper , and Catra flushed with shame at the question. She didnt want to answer but she knew she had to. No one was going to come out for her.

"Y -yes." Catra said softly and Adora looked shocked before she wrapped her arms around Catra again and crushed her against her chest. Catra felt so weirdly free admitting it out loud to Adora. She finally knew. She clung back to Adora and tried to settle her breathing.

"Thank you. Thank you for telling me," Adora said softly into her hair and Catra flushed. She was warm in the tender embrace. She didnt know what else to do besides clinging to Adora in return. Catra managed to calm down enough to quietly rest in the crook of Adora' s shoulder. She focused on the soft stroking up and down her back as her heart settled and Adora rocked her gently.

"I shouldnt have left, Im sorry ," Adora said softly and Catra huf fed softly.

"Y es, Im sorry I lied." Catra said softly and Adora nodded against the top of her head.

"I didn't like it, but I do understand. I just wish you would have told me, I can keep a secret when it's important," Adora said, her voice sounding hurt and Catra's stomach turned.

"I'm sorry I didn't trust you to keep the secret, and for everything… really" Catra said softly into her neck and felt Adora chuckle softly .

"Me too," Adora said softly .

"I know this is hypocritical of me to say , as the runner between us… but next time you're mad, don't go so far ok?" Catra said softly and Adora squeezed her gently and nodded.

"Same to you, no more running ok?" Adora said softly and Catra squeezed her eyes shut before she nodded her head. She didn't want to run anymore.

"I'll try , I can't promise to never run, but I'll try to stay close," Catra said, offering herself some grace so she could learn to be better.

"That sounds good. What happened to W eaver?" Adora asked softly and Catra huffed.

"She left a note that said to leave my keys and take my stuf f, nothing else, the house was empty," Catra said, tears welling in her eyes as she pulled back from Adora to rub her eyes. They were itchy from crying and her face felt swollen.

"What a bitch," Adora said plainly and Catra laughed. She smiled and Adora smiled back at her before she lifted her hand to Catra's cheek.

"Y ou should wash your face, you can stay in my room if you like?" Adora said softly, looking a little hopeful. Catra rolled her eyes.

"I can't," Catra said with a little sheepish smile.

"Why not?" Adora asked, looking confused.

“Linda told me when we talk I can’t stay in your room anymore,” Catra said and Adora’s cheeks coloured adorably.

“Did she say why?” Adora asked, looking a little mortified and Catra smirked.

“What do you think? No girls in your room dummy,” Catra said and Adora got redder. She looked to be thinking.

“But, you’re just Catra?” Adora said and Catra couldn’t hold back the wince at Adora’s words so she rushed to correct herself. “Not just, no just, you’re Catra, I mean, we always have sleepovers,” Adora said quickly, taking one of Catra’s hands firmly like she expected her to run.

“Yeah, but we are getting older, the sleepovers had to stop eventually,” Catra said softly and Adora nodded, looking sad about the realisation.

“I guess so, we are going to University next year,” Adora said softly and Catra nodded.

“Yep, you’ll be having different sleepovers in no time,” Catra said, her stomach twisting harshly at the idea of Adora bringing girls to their apartment next year. She would need to do everything she can to bury these feelings before then or her heart wouldn’t survive.

“I guess,” Adora said, a little frown on her brow as she looked down at their hands interlocked. “What do you need right now?” Adora asked, making eye contact and her gaze was so warm and bright it made Catra’s chest burst.

“Can we cuddle a bit?” Catra asked softly and Adora nodded, moving to lay on the single cot a little awkwardly. Once she was settled, Catra found a comfortable spot in her arms and buried her face into Adora’s shoulder.

They laid in silence for a while until they could hear footsteps approaching down the hall. There was a soft knock on the door and it opened immediately. Linda popped her head in and smiled at the two of them cuddling innocently on the bed.

"Door open girls," Linda reminded and both girls blushed.

"Mum!" Adora said, sounding scandalised. Linda laughed and popped out of the room again.

"Goodnight girls!" Linda said both Adora and Catra parroted it back to her. She walked back to the master bedroom and Adora settled in as she stroked Catra's back. She felt exhausted and finally feeling safe her eyes got heavy quickly . With no tears left and the warm embrace of her favourite person she slipped into sleep.

[..]

Adora noticed when Catra fell asleep against her. She stopped moving and her soft snores sounded vaguely like purrs against her shoulder. Adora held her while she slept, careful to keep herself awake so she wouldnt get in trouble for sleeping over . Adora started to feel herself slipping in and out of sleep and decided it was time to go.

As she carefully lifted Catra, the smaller brunette wiggled and groaned in protest. Adora laughed softly and tucked her into her blankets. Catra wasnt letting go of Adora' s sleeve and she rolled onto her back to make kissing noises at Adora in her sleep.

Adora blushed at the thought of kissing Catra now, but she knew better. Adora gently cupped Catra's cheek and pressed a soft kiss to the opposite side. Catra hummed, looking content and letting go of Adora's sleeve.

Adora brushed some curls away from her forehead and let herself out of the room. She looked down the hall to see her parents door

open with the light on. Linda was sitting up in bed reading a book and looked up when she saw Adora going to her room.

"Night Pumpkin," Linda said with a soft smile and Adora smiled in return.

"Night mum," she whispered, ducking into her room feeling more content than she had in months.

Chapter End Notes

Plz don't hate me for not doing the confession for this chapter! It just didn't fit. Sooooon <3

Thanks for reading!

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

A Promise

Chapter Notes

I hope you enjoy ~

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora came out of her room to see Adam standing on the landing that overlooked the hallway. He looked at Adora curiously as she approached him silently.

Their parents were talking in the kitchen in hushed voices and apparently now she was also eavesdropping.

"Well of course, because you cheated," Dean whispered and Linda scoffed.

"I did not cheat, I helped. She asked for my help," Linda responded back and Dean huffed. "And don't pretend you don't want to go to this hotel just as much as I do,"

"It would be nice to get those free massages,"

"See! It'll be fine," Linda said and Dean could be heard grumbling but nothing else was said. Adam looked at Adora and they shrugged before they headed down the stairs to the kitchen.

"New haircut?" Adam asked curiously as he noticed the shaved part of her head and Adora ran her hand over it with a smile.

"Yeah, I like it," She said as she sat down to have breakfast.

"It looks great hunny ," Linda said as Dean was packing his lunch and looked up.

"Very nice!" Dean said with a smile and Adora blushed under all the attention.

"Thanks," she said and heard Catra come into the kitchen. Linda and Dean exchanged a look before Adora looked at Catra. She was dressed in her usual clothing but she had paused in the doorway while looking at Adora.

Adora blushed darker under the stare and Catra finally approached Adora to touch the back of her head. Adora watched her curiously and tried not to shiver at the soft touch.

"It looks nice," Catra said softly and Adora smiled. When Catra sat down and Adora turned back to the table she noticed Adam grinning brightly at her.

"What?" Adora asked, feeling defensive.

"Nothing, did you guys make up?" he asked, trying to sound casual.

"Yeah, we talked about Weaver and the fake dating," Adora said and Adam looked at her curiously.

"Nothing else?" he asked, looking between the two of them. Adora glared at him, vaguely aware that Catra was serving him the same look. Adora didn't need her feelings to be outed at the breakfast table.

"Actually , I also told Adora that I'm gay ," Catra said in a small voice and Linda smiled like she had just won the lottery before she hugged Catra.

"Oh sweetie, thank you for telling us," Linda said and Dean gave her a hug too. Catra blushed.

"I'm not ready to come out to anyone else yet," Catra said and they nodded.

"You can tell people at your own pace sweetheart, it's not a race" Linda reassured before she grinned at her husband and lightly bumped his shoulder with hers. Dean pouted at his wife before he grinned at the kids.

"Have a good day at school kids," Dean said, dropping a kiss on Linda's cheek before he grabbed his things for work and disappeared out the door to a chorus of goodbyes.

Adam slung his arm around Catra's shoulder and gave her a half hug. He was smiling with such pride and Adora felt a little jealous spike in her stomach.

"I'm proud of you kitty-Cat" Adam said and Catra huffed before she smiled at him. She looked better rested than she had the night before but still fragile. Adora wanted to wrap her up in protective blankets and sooth all of her pain away. Adora didn't want to add more confusion to Catra's life, so despite what she said to Adam, she could wait to tell Catra her feelings.

[..]

It was a strange feeling going to school after everything that had happened. The gossip paper was up to date as ever with a front page article reading "Ding Dong the Witch has Left" which celebrated the resignation of their worst teacher. Luckily it didn't mention anything about Catra or that Weaver had skipped town.

Once Catra came out to Adora she hadn't expected it to feel so freeing, or make her feel so transparent. Now that she had said it out loud, she expected people to just see it in her. She knew they couldn't but she was afraid of being outed before she was ready to face it. She had so much shame and guilt about her sexuality that she felt like the worst thing she could do was come out to more people right now.

School added routine into Catra's chaotic existence. School, clubs, studying, sleeping and doing it all again. Without really noticing it, time was passing and the holes in her chest that Weaver had left were closing and healing.

She had still not heard anything from her mother and she expected she never would again. That part of her life was closed now. Linda and Dean had been nothing but welcoming and accepting, converting the study into a room for Catra, claiming she would need the furniture when they moved next year anyway .

Adora and Catra's friendship recovered easily and Adam was back to his bestie ways, even if he sometimes offered a little more affection like he did when they were fake dating. Adora kept her promise that she wouldnt go too far and over the weeks they managed to talk about things they used to avoid.

Holidays at the Greyskull household were easily one of Catra's favourite things. They always decorated the house to the brim and living at the Greyskulls Catra had been given an allowance like the twins had and she used that money to buy gifts for everyone. She was given a new laptop for school by Santa and Catra almost cried at the expensive gift. Adam bought Mario Party for their switch which was really a present for himself and Adora bought Catra a shirt that said kitten on it with a cat face that made Catra blush. Adora looked so proud of herself so Catra couldnt be too upset.

The rules about no girls in their bedrooms ended up being pretty easy to navigate. Catra missed sleeping with Adora but they still found time to cuddle on the couch under the heater.

Adora was sprawled out on the longer couch with Catra laid on top of her like a blanket as they watched some terrible movie.

Adam had left to pick up Teela so the four of them could hang out and watch a marathon of the Godzilla movies. Catra had been drifting in and out of sleep for a few minutes, comfortably propped against Adora's chest as the blonde made an amazing cushion.

The front door opened and closed alerting Catra to the new people in the house but she didn't bother to move. She felt Adora lift one of her hands off Catra's back where she had been stroking her and waved at the newcomers.

"Are they always like this?" Teela's soft voice came closer to the living room. Adam was silent but Catra had no doubt he was agreeing with Teela. Catra and Adora had cuddled a lot more often since the fakeup (fake breakup) and Catra's life falling apart. She was a great support to Catra both physically and mentally, but her heart was the one thriving under the soft attention.

"Is she sleeping?" Adam asked Adora and she shook a little.

"No, she's just pretending right now," Adora said with a smile in her voice. Catra pinched her hard on the side and Adora yelped. Catra couldn't help but smile as Adora pouted and both Teela and Adam laughed at her.

"You should know better than that," Catra said and Adora grinned.

"Yeah, but who knows how long you would pretend to be asleep if I didn't call you out," Adora said playfully and Catra huffed as she pushed herself up.

"Hey Teela," Catra greeted and Teela smiled.

"Hey Catra, how are you going?" Teela asked, it took weeks for Weaver leaving town to spread through the school but most people knew now which was fine.

"Yeah, good, it's freezing outside, so I am not leaving this house until spring," Catra complained as she grabbed the blanket hanging over the back of the couch to wrap around herself.

"Hibernation is a valid life choice," Teela said sitting on the loveseat with a grin. Catra smiled back. She liked Teela and since Adam and Catra had stopped fake dating she could see how much Adam liked

her too. They were taking it slow but they both clearly knew where they were heading.

Teela sat back on the couch while Adam put the movie on and sat beside her. He put his arm along the back of the seat and Teela leaned her body towards him casually as they settled into watch the movie.

Adora let out a soft oof sound as Catra flopped back onto of her and Adora wrapped her arms around the now burritoed brunette laying on top of her. This was how she wanted to spend her whole winter break.

[..]

Winter break and Adora's birthday passed in a blur. Once school started again everyone was focused on college applications and making sure their grades were as good as they could be. Scouts started coming to their football games and Catra was the first of the three of them to get an offer for a cheerleading scholarship to their dream school.

Adora was so proud of Catra, it was the confidence boost she needed to really come out of her shell again. She was starting to act like her old self and Adora loved it. She loved all the cuddles and flirting that became part of their new dynamic. Adora even convinced herself she could be happy with this. Maybe she didnt have to tell Catra that she loved her if she could have her like this.

The spring formal was coming up and everyone knew that Adam and Teela were going together. Everyone was putting in their votes for King and Queen and Adora was sure they would win the crowns.

Adora hadnt asked Catra because they always went together , so she didnt think she needed to. She also knew if she did ask her it would sound like a date and she didnt know how Catra would handle appearing to date a girl so soon after coming out to them.

Adora was sitting and eating an apple while she waited for practice to start one afternoon, the days were finally warming up so she was wearing her lighter practice clothing.

Mermista came out of the change room and Adora waved when the raven haired woman approached her.

"Hey Greyskull, do you have a date for the Spring formal yet?" Mermista asked without any inflection in her voice. Adora blinked at her in confusion for a moment before she frowned.

"Uh, not exactly." Adora said blushing softly about having to explain about her standing friend date with Catra.

"Great, go with me, we would look hot together ," Mermista said and Adora frowned in confusion.

"Arent you going with Sean?" she asked, it was hard to keep track of Mermista and Sean's relationship status, maybe they were on another break.

"No, he' s trying to make me jealous by going with Catra, so you should come with me," Mermista said and Adora' s eyes widened as her stomach swooped. Catra was going with Sean? Adora hated that idea so much, not only because it wasnt Adora she was going with but because Catra still felt she had to hide who she was.

"O-ohwhen did that happen?" Adora asked, trying to hide the disappointment and jealousy on her face.

"Earlier today , he made a big show of it. It was mortifying, I felt kinda sorry for Catra," Mermista said and Adora nodded solemnly as the knot in her chest tightened.

"Ohuhsure, we can go together." Adora said and Mermista punched her in her shoulder pad.

"Great, we are a shoe in for those crowns," Mermista said, cracking a small smile before she walked away to join the rest of the assembling team.

"Yeah," Adora said, her stomach twisting as she threw her apple in the bin. She wasn't feeling very hungry anymore as another emotion filled the space inside her body.

[...]

Catra was riding a high from her scholarship offer and the playful flirting she and Adora had been doing.

She had been waiting for it all to come crashing down and life didn't disappoint her. The good vibes couldn't last so she should have seen it coming when Sean made a very public proposal to the dance. Catra had been mortified and with so many eyes on her she felt shame fill her body until it was choking her. Wrestling with her embarrassment she agreed to go to the dance with him just so people would stop looking at her. She felt too seen, like if she said no to him that everyone would know she was gay and she wasn't ready for that. Maybe she could turn him down in private, surely he wanted to go with Mermista, right?

It wasn't until after practice that same day that Catra heard Mermista talking about going to the dance with Adora and her jealousy reared its ugly head. Adora was on the other side of the field with Adam so no one was there to stop Catra approaching Mermista.

"You're going to the dance with Adora?" Catra asked and Scorpia, who had been talking to Mermista, had to stop mid-sentence.

"Yeah, we are going to be the hottest couple in the place. Heard you're going with Sean, good luck with that?" Mermista said sarcastically and Scorpia was wringing her hands nervously.

"What are you two playing at? Is this some weird jealousy thing?" Catra snapped, she didn't want to be used as a tool to make

someone else jealous. Not when it caused her only jealousy to burn so bright.

"No, I don't care what he does. He asked you because he clearly thinks you're hot," Mermista said and Catra blushed as she glared at her.

"And you?" Catra asked and Mermista smirked as she looked over at Adora, who was approaching now with the rest of the team.

"Well obviously Greyskull is hot as fuck and I think I can show her a good time," Mermista said said, turning her smirk back on Catra who was now seething. She wanted to yell at Mermista to stay away from Adora but how could she?

Adora agreed to go with Mermista, so she clearly liked her as well. Adora wasn't Catra's to claim and just because Catra had told Adora she was gay didn't mean she was ready to be out and gay. Even if she told Adora about her feelings and Adora felt the same, Catra was nowhere near ready to tell the rest of the world about her feelings. Adora deserved better than someone who was ashamed of themselves and too embarrassed to be seen with her.

"Fine," Catra snapped, her nails digging into her palms as she squeezed her hands into fists. Mermista raised an eyebrow at the obviously hostile display but Catra just walked away. She should be happy for Adora but all she wanted to do was cry.

[..]

Adora wasn't sure if she was projecting, but Catra seemed a little distant in the days leading up to the spring dance. Adora was trying to be supportive of Catra going with Sean but she was silently kicking herself for not asking her first. She wanted to be the one taking Catra to her senior dance and wearing matching outfits. Instead she was getting ready at Mermista's house and her suit matched the blue and gold of Mermista's dress perfectly.

Mermista was right, they did look great together. Mermista had helped Adora do a braided style to her hair to show off her new haircut and some minimal makeup and jewellery. Mermista was dressed in gold extravagant jewellery and a blue and gold wrap around her body and over her shoulder. She looked gorgeous.

"Damn, we look hot," Mermista said playfully as they looked at themselves in the mirror. After some embarrassing photos by Mermista's parents they were allowed to leave. Adora drove Mermista's car simply because Mermista didn't want to take off her heels.

They arrived fashionably late according to Mermista and the dance was already in full swing. Adora scanned the crowd easily with her height advantage and spotted Catra already on the dancefloor with Sean. Her stomach swooped with confusing feelings. Catra looked amazing, her black and red dress was tight and had a slit up one leg to let her dance easily. Sean was wearing a matching tux with a red silk scarf wrapped around his throat and red tails on his jacket. They looked really good together but there was no way Adora even remotely matched Catra and it made her heart sink.

Mermista whistled softly beside her "Damn, Catra is wearing the hell out of that dress," Mermista said and Adora nodded her head mutely. "Hey, I get it, we both have someone else we would like to be here with, but let's have fun ok?" Mermista said and Adora looked down at her with surprise. She looked flushed as she watched Sean for a moment before she looked back at Adora and Adora smiled.

"Yeah, let's have fun," Adora said, feeling more relaxed. She could handle making sure Mermista had a good night. "Want to dance?" She asked and Mermista offered her hand with a twinkle in her eyes.

"I thought you'd never ask," Mermista said playfully.

[..]

Adam and Teela were in green and gold and had taken the dance by storm upon their entry. They didn't even notice anything outside of each other as they danced the night away.

Adora arrived at the spring dance like a wrecking ball to Catra's heart. She looked amazing in a navy blue and gold tux with her hair in a braid down her back.

Sean had been nothing but a gentleman with her, polite, though sometimes annoying company. She felt almost like a kindred spirit with him, he was also from a very religious family and despite his straight passing relationship with Mermista he had struggled with leaving his own closet over the years.

They danced, making eachother laugh and spending time with other friends. It wasn't long after Adora and Mermista arrived that they naturally gravitated closer to them. Sean was smitten with Mermista and it was easy to see, despite their disagreements.

"Would it be ok with you if I asked Mermista to dance?" Sean asked and Catra nodded.

"Yeah, dude, got for it," she said and he beamed before he kissed her hand needlessly and he approached Mermista. Catra watched the interaction, suddenly feeling alone in the crowded room. Mermista and Sean walked to the dancefloor and Adora's eyes landed on Catra with a heated gaze.

Catra swallowed the lump in her throat and like magnets they were drawn to each other. Catra stopped before Adora and smiled up at her shyly.

"Nice suit," Catra complimented.

"Thanks, nice dress," Adora said, her eyes skimming over Catra's form for a moment.

"I prefer you in white," Catra said playfully and Adora coloured.

"Me too," she agreed. Catra didn't want to read too much into it but she hoped Adora meant it the same way she did. She liked it much more when Adora and her were a matching set.

"Would you like to dance?" Catra asked and Adora glanced over at the dancefloor where their friends could all be seen enjoying themselves.

"Maybe later , I wouldn't mind some fresh air ," Adora said softly and Catra smiled and nodded.

"I could use some air ," Catra agreed and Adora led them out of the gymnasium into the cool night air. Catra hadn't really dressed for a brisk spring evening, but Adora was quick to resolve the issue by taking off her jacket and wrapping it around her shoulders.

"Thanks," Catra said, her cheeks colouring as Adora put her hand on her lower back and led them over to some nearby benches. Catra pulled the jacket around her shoulders as she sat down and Adora sat beside her. Catra tried to arrange her dress to cover her leg but the heavy fabric was fighting her.

Catra was biting her lip trying to get the courage to say something bold when Adora broke the silence first.

"I wish I came to the dance with you," Adora said softly as she looked out into the darkness of the oval. Catra felt butterflies erupt inside her chest at the admittance.

"Me too," Catra agreed softly , and Adora looked at her with soft sad eyes.

"I wish you didn't feel like you have to hide," Adora said and Catra shivered under the intense stare. Adora clearly thought she was still cold and put her arm around Catra to help keep her warm. It worked immediately as Catra blushed.

"Me too," She said softly .

"No rush, obviously , you take the time you need," Adora reminded her, and Catra smiled as she laughed softly.

"I know dummy ," Catra said softly , and Adora looked like she was thinking. She had a little frown between her brows and Catra lifted her hand to poke the little wrinkles that built there. "Dont think so hard," Catra teased and Adora huf fed.

"I was just thinking about something Glimmer told me," Adora said softly, a little colour coming to her cheeks which didnt seem to be from the cool night.

"Y eah, what wisdom has the mighty Sparkles bestowed upon you?" Catra poked and Adora smiled but her focus didnt waver .

"Just that when you said you liked me over the years that it might not have meant what I thought it did," Adora said softly and Catra felt her cheeks burn with embarrassment. It was bad enough managing her friendship with Glimmer as one of her few confidants without Glimmer running her mouth.

"When did this come up?" Catra asked and Adora smiled sheepishly .

"Back when the fake dating thing came out," Adora said and Catra rolled her eyes.

"And you waited all this time to talk about it?" Catra asked in a huf f but Adora was still watching her cautiously. Catra felt like maybe she was missing something when Adora looked at her like that.

"I want to tell you something, and it's fine if you dont feel the same, but before that I have something for you" Adora said and Catra watched curiously as Adora pulled a small ring sized box from the pocket of her suit. Catra's eyes widened as Adora looked a little embarrassed.

"I wanted to give it to you at Christmas but I couldnt resist that kitten shirt," Adora started and Catra frowned a little but nodded her head.

"You're such a jerk," Catra said and Adora grinned playfully.

"Yeah," Adora said and handed Catra the small box. She looked at the box with butterflies in her stomach before she pushed open the lid.

Inside the box was just what she hoped for, the gold ring with a marquise cut aquamarine stone sat within the box.

"Is it?" Catra asked as tears welled in her eyes.

"The same one? Yeah, I found it at the donation place and thought I would buy it for you again," Adora said softly and Catra tried to blink her tears away without ruining her makeup.

"You're going to make me ruin my eyeliner," Catra complained as she tried to tilt her head back to stop the tears from falling. Adora laughed gently.

"Should have used waterproof then," Adora teased and Catra scoffed.

"I can't afford that shit, so don't make me cry," Catra scolded and looked back at the ring before she took it out of the box and slid it on the pointer finger of her left hand. She smiled as it glittered in the soft light, it was small, but it made her feel like she matched Adora. Not Adora's suit, but Adora. The gem glistened like the sunny sky of her best friend's eyes and the gold was like her hair. She had missed this ring and it made her feel like she belonged.

"Thank you," Catra said and Adora smiled softly, but it looked a little sad now. Catra frowned with confusion at the change in her mood. "What did you want to tell me?" Catra asked, suddenly concerned.

"I talked to Bow and Glimmer about living with them at Unive-"

"What?!" Catra cut her off, looking shocked. "Why?! We have a plan" she asked, confused and panicked.

"I know , it's ok, just listen to me ok?" Adora said, taking her hands firmly and Catra clicked her mouth closed before she nodded. Her stomach twisting uncomfortably.

"I talked to them because I want to tell you something and I dont want you to feel trapped. It won't change anything and Im always going to be here for you, so you dont have to worry about that." Adora said and Catra could feel the tears welling in her eyes again.

"You're scaring me," Catra said softly , feeling a little pathetic for admitting it. But it was true, she didnt want Adora to live somewhere else, she wanted to live with her and cuddle in the evenings and maybe even sleep in the same room again if it wasnt weird.

"Cat, I like you," Adora said softly and Catra' s chest felt like it was bursting with happiness, but Adora wasnt done talking. "And I understand if you dont feel the same way , I just need you to know , and Ill probably need time to get over it so it doesnt make you feel weird and I hope it doesnt make you uncomfortable," Adora rambled and Catra just stared at her . Adora liked her, but did she mean like-like her?

"Adora, what do you mean when you say you like me?" Catra asked softly and Adora stopped and looked at her with a flustered blush on her cheeks. It's so cute.

"In a gay way ," Adora of fered and Catra couldnt help but laugh. She was so happy to hear those words. Adora liked her? It seemed too good to be true. Adora looked embarrassed and confused, which shook Catra out of her internal victory dance.

"Adora, Ive been in love with you since we were eight years old," Catra said and Adora looked surprised, like genuinely surprised that her feelings were returned. Adora was still like a statue so Catra leaned forward to kiss her softly and it seemed to snap her out of it as she took Catra's cheek in her hand and kissed her firmly.

Catra kissed her back as she leaned into her warmth. The kiss was pretty tame, soft and gentle like a promise. Adora wrapped her arms around Catra and when they separated from the kiss Adora rested her forehead against Catra's.

"Wow I was seriously understating my feelings by the way . I love you too," Adora said softly and Catra laughed with relief as she ran her fingertips over the back of Adora's head, enjoying the short soft hair she found there.

"You're such an idiot," Catra whispered, her words dripping with affection.

"Yeah, but I could be your idiot," Adora breathed back, her eyes closed as they shared each others air. Catra hummed, her heart too big for her chest.

"I would like that, so much." Catra said, her voice carrying a sad lilt to the end which caused Adora to pull back and make eye contact with Catra. Catra couldn't help the guilty look on her face.

"I don't want to have to hide you while I'm still working things out," Catra said remorsefully, "you deserve better than that," Catra said and Adora frowned a little before she smiled softly.

"I want to be with you Catra, whatever that looks like. If we have to pretend to be friends at school and I still get to show you how much I love you at home. Then I can do that until you're ready ," Adora said softly as she stroked Catra's cheek gently and she leaned into the affection.

"You're too good for me," Catra said softly and Adora frowned.

"Weaver is not allowed in this conversation," Adora said firmly , and Catra blushed before she nodded.

"Sorry , it's something I'm working on," she said gently and Adora nodded, a small smile growing on her lips again.

I know and I love you so we can work the rest out as we go,”Adora said gently and Catra smiled. Letting out a sigh of relief as she felt a weight being lifted off her shoulders. She felt so light that she might just float away so she clung to Adora tightly and hid her face in her shoulder.

I love you too, Dummy ,”She whispered.

[..]

Adora was riding a high like she had never known. She got to dance with her best friend under a tacky disco ball and way too many plastic vines to terrible songs she knew by heart. They didnt dance to any of the slow songs but Adora made it her personal goal to make Catra laugh so hard that she couldnt breath.

Mermista and Sean hadnt been seen since they went to dance and neither Adora nor Catra found their night lacking without them. They were likely making up and would show up eventually.

After the dance wrapped up at 10pm some of their friends went back to Glimmer's house to keep the party going. Linda and Dean already knew they were staying at Glimmers after the dance so they had an easy night of freedom.

Mermista and Sean arrived at the party on Sean’s motorbike an hour after Adora and Catra caught a ride home with Glimmer. Scorpia, Perfuma, Adam and Teela all joined them to end the night with some good music and alcoholic drinks.

Adora finally got her slow dance, surrounded by rainbow lights and a tacky bubble machine in the pool house out the back of Glimmer's place. Catra was so close that there was barely any space between them. She was rocking slowly with her head on Adora’s shoulder as a soft slow song played. The group was all couples so everyone was in their own little world as they rocked to the music.

Adora leaned down, her chest bursting to say those three simple words every chance she got for the rest of her life.

"I love you," Adora whispered into her ear and Catra shivered before she squeezed Adora closer and tilted her head up to look at the blonde.

"I love you too," she whispered back, the words being lost in the song playing and Adora beamed like the sun. Catra smiled and rested her head back on her shoulder to continue their dancing.

They stayed up late drinking and dancing before they arranged pillows and blankets on the floor of the living room and everyone paired off to sleep. Adora was excited to sleep with Catra in her arms again. It felt like it had been months since the last time and she missed it.

Catra looked equally excited as she settled in beside Adora. Something felt so different and so charged about this embrace that it made it almost impossible to sleep. Adora could see with enough light that Catra's eyes were open as she looked back at Adora with barely an inch between them. Catra's eyes moved down to Adora's lips and Adora bit into her lower lip.

Catra mimicked the action subconsciously as she moved closer to her and slotted herself under Adora's chin. Just like that the tension was gone, Adora ran her hands up and down Catra's back. She didn't feel like she was missing out by not getting a kiss but she was excited for the next time they could have one.

[..]

Catra woke with her back sore from the hard ground and a heavy weight on top of her. She groaned softly and tried to roll off her back but found herself pinned. She cracked her eyes open lazily to find Adora sleeping on her chest with one arm and leg around her. No wonder she couldn't move. She tried to wiggle out from under the dead weight but was unsuccessful.

"You guys are cute together," Mermista's soft whisper came from beside Catra and she snapped her head in that direction. Mermista was sitting up in her many pillows she called a bed and despite the early morning she still looked practically flawless. Sean, Perfuma and Scorpia were already missing from the room but Bow and Glimmer were still sleeping wrapped around each other and Adam and Teela were sleeping close together but not quite touching.

Catra was embarrassed but she noticed a lack of shame filling her chest as Mermista watched her with understanding in her eyes.

"Thank you," Catra said softly. The first step was acceptance, right? It was progress. Mermista nodded.

"Don't mention it, or I'll deny it," Mermista threatened and Catra laughed softly.

"Sure," she said and Adora moved beside her to snuggle somehow closer. She seemed to deem that uncomfortable and moved again immediately. She rolled onto her back and pulled Catra with her. She giggled softly and that seemed to wake Adora as she looked at her with bleary eyes. Catra smiled back, vaguely aware that Mermista got to her feet to leave the room. Catra pressed a soft kiss to her sleepy girlfriend's face and a scandalised gasp came from the direction of Glimmer's pillow palace.

"Bow, Bow!" Glimmer's excited whisper came with a groan from the man himself.

"Sleeping," he mumbled and Glimmer just shook him harder to his loud protest. Teela and Adam woke to the sound of Glimmer's not so effective whispering but Adora was almost back to sleep by this point.

"Bow, they did it!" Glimmer said, and climbed out of the blankets, pulling them with her. Bow groaned again at being completely uncovered and sat up to glare at Glimmer.

"What happened? T ell me everything!" Glimmer said, grabbing Catra by the shoulders and shaking her. Adora groaned as Catra was taken from her arms and finally woke up for real this time.

"Glimmer , people are sleeping," Adam said with annoyance as he sat up and Teela did the same before lazily leaning against him. He wrapped his arm around her shoulder as she closed her eyes again.

"I dont care, are you together now? How did it happen?" Glimmer asked and Catra blushed as Adora sat up beside her and gently pulled Catra from Glimmer's clutches.

"Glim, she's not out, so stop it will you," Adora defended and Catra smiled at her protectiveness. She snuggled into Adora's arms and sighed happily.

"W ait, Im confused, what's happening then?" Glimmer asked, looking confused.

"W e are together, but Im still in the closet right now , so we arent telling people, you losers have to keep a secret," Catra explained and Glimmer pouted before she nodded.

"Ok, fine,"

"A w, I am both touched and outraged to be part of this secret," T eela offered and Catra snorted before she grinned at Adam.

"I like her ," Catra said and Adam blushed but smiled at T eela.

"Me too," he said softly , and Teela blushed.

"Y oure alright, I guess," T eela said and yelped when he pinched her on the side. They all laughed as Teela tussled with Adam to pinch him in return.

[..]

Catra was sitting on the swings in the park between her old house and the Greyskulls. Things had been going amazingly and the weather was warming up again. Adam and Adora had finally been offered Football scholarships to their dream school and everything was coming together just like they planned.

It was almost overwhelming how good things were going and Catra felt like she was walking on eggshells as she waited for something to ruin the fragile happiness she had built for herself. Adora had been a patient and understanding girlfriend. They didn't always communicate the best but they had kept their promises to never run too far.

Catra was keeping that promise right now since she and Adora had a mild disagreement. Catra was upset that Adora was ok with Catra hiding Adora from the world and Adora tried to reassure her again that she was fine with it. Adora didn't mind and she wasn't getting frustrated or anything. She had been so understanding and patient with Catra's choice to stay in the closet while they were still in highschool and she would work on coming out when they had moved. It was a common argument between them because Catra felt like Adora was angry with her, or frustrated. Catra would hate it if Adora wanted to hide her like an embarrassment so why was Adora ok with it?

"Hey Kitten," Catra looked up, she didn't even realise she wasn't alone anymore as she rocked back and forth on the swings deep in thought. She expected to see Adora but she was instead greeted by Dee who had a camera strap over their shoulder. They were wearing an outfit that looked like a suit on the top and a dress on the bottom. It billowed in the spring wind and shimmered.

"Don't call me that," Catra said with an annoyed frown and Dee smiled.

"Sorry , I forgot, I have to be at least six foot for you to like it," Dee said, twirling their platinum blonde hair around their finger casually.

“Can I help you with something?” Catra asked and Dee laughed.

“Not exactly , I think I am here to help you,” Dee said and stepped forward. They lifted the camera and clicked a few buttons before they showed Catra a photo on the little display. Catra’s eyes widened at the image of Adora and Catra kissing outside during the spring dance.

“How do you have this?” Catra asked and Dee pulled the camera to sling it back over their shoulder.

“A little birdy took it for me. It was suggested that I write a story to match it but it came to my attention that you are not out yet,” Dee said and Catra gasped.

“Y ou write the gossip paper?” she asked in shock as they laughed and flicked their hair.

“Guilty , you and buff Barbie are really good for sales, but Im not trying to out someone before they are ready,” they said and Catra looked back at the camera before she looked at Dee again.

“Thank you,” Catra of fered and they tutted and waved their hand.

“Dont thank me darling,” they said and picked some fluf f off their suit jacket. “I do have some advice for you though, from one queer to another,”

“What is it?” Catra asked, trying to force down the shameful blush that wanted to colour her face at the accusation.

“Our parents may raise us but they dont get to tell us who to be,” Dee started and Catra frowned at the reminder of Weaver and everything she put Catra through. “But if you hide who you are then it just reinforces that you think you are doing something wrong. If you know who you are, be proud of that person,” Dee said and Catra frowned as she thought over those words and let them reside in her chest. She found that she felt a little lighter.

"Thanks Dee, spoken from experience?" She asked and they smiled as they started walking away.

"Lets just say there is a reason I live with my nanna rather than my parents. See you later Kitten," they said and Catra huffed but didnt correct the nickname this time.

She stayed a little longer, watching the sun change the colour of the sky and feeling the temperature drop below comfortable.

She got up from the swing and headed for home, ready to apologise and snuggle with Adora until everything was good again. She knew she had a long road ahead to deal with the emotional scars her mother left behind but little steps forward were still progress.

She arrived at the Greyskull house to see Adora sitting out the front. She had been watching the sky change colour but she perked up as she noticed Catra. As she got closer Adora stood and smiled at her.

"Hey ," Adora said, a little nervous but still hopeful.

"Hey Dummy ," Catra said, stepping closer to hug the blonde and having Adora wrap her arms around her in return.

"I'm sorry ," Catra said and Adora let out a sigh of relief as she held her.

"I'm sorry too," Adora said gently even though she hadn't done anything wrong. Catra held onto her tighter and melted into her embrace.

She would work her hardest to learn to be the person she wanted to be. Not only was it what Adora deserved in a partner, but it was what Catra deserved too. When she worked out who she really was, she wouldn't have to hide anymore.

Chapter End Notes

It's a wrap!For now ~

I have plans for more for this AU so if you are interested keep your eyes peeled. I may update more chapters to this story over time but I do have a seqel planned for college life. No relationship drama for the nekone (besides little disagreements), so you can rest assured, our girls are staying together.

Thank you so much to everyone who has supported this fic and commented such sweet encouragement, you really kept me going!Thank you for your patience too, it took almost a year to get this one finished but I am a better writer now because of it.

If you are interested in seeing my art or learning about my other AU's you can find me @nniiart on T witter, Instagram, tumblr and Patreon.

Cheers.

End Notes

Let me know what you think!Thank you for reading <3

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!